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Historians' Roundtable

The 2026 War in Historical Context

Six Perspectives · One Synthesis

Classical Antiquity · Democratic Decline · American Wars
Asian Perspectives · Middle East & Colonialism · Trade & Globalization

Academic Roundtable Proceedings
March 6, 2026

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Chapter 1

Roundtable Synthesis

A Synthesis of Six Perspectives

Academic Roundtable Proceedings — March 6, 2026

INTRODUCTION: WHY HISTORY MATTERS NOW

On the seventh day of Operation Epic Fury, with Supreme Leader Khamenei dead, 175 children buried at Minab, the Strait of Hormuz selectively closed, and an American president demanding the right to appoint Iran's next leader, six historians were asked a single question: *What does your period of expertise tell us about what is happening — and what happens next?*

The question is not rhetorical. Real-time intelligence can tell us how many missiles Iran has launched (500+), how many ships sit anchored in the Gulf (approximately 200), how many sorties the coalition has flown (2,500 strikes, 6,000+ munitions). It can quantify the degradation of air defenses (80%), the reduction in missile launch rates (90%), the price of Brent crude ($84). What real-time intelligence cannot do — what it is structurally incapable of doing — is tell us what these numbers *mean*. Meaning requires context, and context is the domain of history.

The six scholars assembled for this roundtable bring radically different temporal lenses to the same event. The classicist reads 2026 through Thucydides' account of the Sicilian Expedition and Rome's seven-century confrontation with Parthia. The specialist in democratic decline sees Weimar's emergency decrees and the institutional decay that precedes democratic collapse. The Americanist traces the recurring logic of overreach from Saigon to Baghdad to Tehran. The Asianist watches from Tokyo, Beijing, and New Delhi as energy reserves tick toward zero and strategic calculations shift. The Middle East historian hears the echo of Mossadegh, Sykes-Picot, and the Ottoman collapse. The trade historian maps chokepoints from the Portuguese fortress at Hormuz in 1507 to the selective closure of 2026.

These are not six ways of saying the same thing. They are six different ways of seeing, each illuminating aspects of the crisis that the others miss. The classicist sees patterns that recur across millennia; the Americanist sees contingencies that could have been avoided. The Asianist sees opportunity where the Middle East historian sees tragedy. The democratic decline specialist sees institutional rot where the trade historian sees structural fragility.

But what compelled the convening of this roundtable is not the differences — it is the convergences. When a classicist studying Thucydides, a Vietnam specialist studying McNamara, an Asianist studying the 1941 oil embargo, a Middle East historian studying the Mossadegh coup, a democratic theorist studying Weimar, and a trade historian studying chokepoint warfare *independently* arrive at the same set of conclusions about the structural dynamics of the 2026 conflict, that convergence constitutes something more than academic agreement. It constitutes a warning.

The warning, stated plainly, is this: the patterns that have produced strategic failure, democratic erosion, regional destabilization, and unintended consequences in every prior instance of the dynamics visible in 2026 are present in their most concentrated and accelerated form. Not one of these patterns — imperial overreach, democratic war-making without consent, the gap between

military capability and political objectives, the weaponization of energy, the law of unintended consequences — is absent from the current conflict. All of them are operating simultaneously. And they are operating at a speed that compresses into days what previously unfolded over years.

History does not predict. But it identifies the structural conditions under which specific categories of outcome become more or less likely. The structural conditions identified by this panel — unanimously, from six independent perspectives spanning twenty-five centuries — are the conditions under which great powers discover that their wars cost more than they planned, last longer than they expected, and produce consequences they never imagined. That this has happened before does not mean it must happen again. But the burden of proof lies with those who claim that 2026 is the exception, not the rule.

The historians assembled here do not agree on everything. They disagree about whether the patterns they identify are cyclical or contingent, whether they reflect deep structural forces or accumulated policy failures, whether analogy illuminates or obscures. These disagreements are not weaknesses; they are the intellectual engines that make historical analysis productive. But on the central question — whether the 2026 war exhibits the structural characteristics associated with strategic overreach, democratic erosion, and cascading unintended consequences — the panel is unanimous.

What follows is not a summary of six essays. It is an attempt to trace the threads that connect them — the patterns that emerge when classical antiquity, modern European history, American foreign policy, Asian geopolitics, Middle Eastern studies, and trade history converge on the same event. The synthesis is, by design, an argument: that the past, properly interrogated, speaks to the present with an urgency that no intelligence briefing can match.

I. THE PATTERNS THAT RECUR

The most striking feature of the six essays is the degree to which scholars working from entirely different historical periods, geographic regions, and methodological traditions identify the same structural dynamics at work in the 2026 conflict. These convergences are not the product of coordination; the essays were written independently. They represent the signal that emerges when multiple expert perspectives triangulate on the same phenomenon.

The Gap Between Military Capability and Political Objectives

Every contributor identifies, in their own vocabulary, the fundamental disconnect between what military force can accomplish and what political outcomes it is expected to produce. The classicist frames this through Rome's experience with Parthia: Rome could capture the Parthian capital of Ctesiphon — and did so, repeatedly, under Trajan, Septimius Severus, Carus, and Julian — but could never translate tactical victory into political control. The pattern was, as the classicist notes, "monotonously consistent: advance, capture, withdraw."

The Americanist identifies the identical dynamic in Vietnam, Iraq, and Afghanistan. The United States dropped more bombs on Vietnam than all parties dropped in all theaters of World War II combined. It achieved aerial supremacy, killed enemy combatants in staggering numbers, and won virtually every major engagement. It lost the war. In Iraq, the military campaign toppled Saddam's regime in forty-three days; the political aftermath produced a decade of insurgency, the Islamic State, and the empowerment of Iranian influence across the region. In Afghanistan, twenty years of occupation and $2.3 trillion produced a state that collapsed in eleven days.

The Asianist locates this pattern in the mismatch between the war's military theater and its economic impact zone: "a war conceived in Washington and Jerusalem whose most acute material consequences fall on Asian capitals." The trade historian frames it as the recurring tragedy of military strategists who "plan for the battlefield while the economy bleeds from a thousand cuts they never anticipated."

The Middle East historian personalizes it: when Trump demands to be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader, he is reenacting a pattern that extends from the British installation of Hashemite monarchs after World War I through the CIA's restoration of the Shah in 1953 — a pattern in which external powers assume that military superiority confers the right and the capacity to determine the political arrangements of societies they do not understand.

The convergence is unmistakable. Whether the lens is classical, modern American, Asian, Middle Eastern, or economic, the conclusion is the same: **military capability does not translate into political outcomes in civilizations that possess deep historical identity, institutional complexity, and the capacity for asymmetric resistance.** Iran — a civilization of ninety million people with twenty-five centuries of continuous political identity — falls squarely into this category.

Democratic War-Making Without Consent

A second pattern emerges with equal force: the crisis of democratic legitimacy in war-making. The classicist reads this through Thucydides' account of Athens, where democratic assemblies could be stampeded into war by demagogues (the Sicilian Expedition) or bypassed by leaders who acted without genuine popular mandate. The 2026 case, the classicist argues, represents "the second failure mode — a war launched by executive decision, ratified after the fact by the narrowest of legislative margins, in the face of overwhelming public opposition."

The democratic decline specialist drives this point to its sharpest expression. The 25-27% initial approval rating for Operation Epic Fury is, as the essay demonstrates, historically unprecedented — lower than any major American military operation in the era of scientific polling. The absence of any rally-around-the-flag effect breaks a pattern that political scientists had identified as one of the most robust findings in the field. The failed War Powers votes — defeated 47-53 in the Senate and 212-219 in the House — represent, in the Weimar analogy that structures the essay, the moment when the legislature has the opportunity to defend its constitutional authority and chooses not to.

The Americanist traces the constitutional trajectory "from Tonkin to Tehran" as a trajectory of declining democratic constraint. The Gulf of Tonkin Resolution, for all its dishonesty, was a congressional act passed 88-2. The Iran war began without congressional authorization, was challenged under the War Powers Resolution, and survived — Congress ratifying presidential war-making through the "negative act of failing to stop it."

Even the Asianist, whose primary concern is the strategic positioning of non-Western powers, notes the structural irony: the nations most materially affected by the war — Japan, South Korea, India — "had no role in the decision to launch Operation Epic Fury." Democratic consent is absent not only domestically but across the alliance network. The trade historian adds a further dimension: the economic consequences fall most heavily on allies who were not consulted, making the Hormuz crisis a weaponization of a chokepoint "against the alliance network of the war's initiator."

The pattern across all six perspectives: **the 2026 war represents a crisis of consent — domestic, allied, and international — that is deeper and more immediate than in any previous American military operation.**

The Law of Unintended Consequences

The third universal pattern is the cascade of unintended effects. The Middle East historian frames this most explicitly through the 1953→1979→2026 cycle: each American intervention in Iran has produced a successor regime more hostile to Western interests than the one it replaced. Mossadegh was a parliamentary democrat seeking to renegotiate oil terms. The Shah was an authoritarian modernizer. The Islamic Republic is a theocratic state. "If the pattern holds, what follows the Islamic Republic will be worse — not better — from the perspective of Western interests."

The trade historian identifies the economic dimension: the sanctions regime designed to constrain Iran instead pushed it toward China, strengthened hardliners, and accelerated nuclear development — "the tool designed to prevent war created the conditions that made war more likely." The Asianist identifies the geopolitical dimension: the selective Hormuz closure advantages China, America's primary strategic competitor, while devastating America's most important Asian allies. The classicist sees the pattern in Trajan's eastern conquests, which triggered simultaneous revolts across the empire and had to be immediately abandoned by his successor.

The democratic decline specialist identifies perhaps the most consequential unintended consequence: the potential restructuring of democratic institutions in a more authoritarian direction, following the French precedent in which the Algerian War produced not democratic renewal but the Fifth Republic's concentration of executive power.

The convergence: **every historical period examined in this roundtable demonstrates that military interventions produce cascading consequences that exceed their architects' imagination, and the consequences most consistently underestimated are those that affect the intervening power's own institutions, alliances, and strategic position.**

Energy as Geopolitical Weapon

The weaponization of energy and trade flows connects the trade historian's primary argument to the concerns of every other panelist. The Asianist's analysis of Japan's Pearl Harbor decision — driven by the 1941 oil embargo that created "a slow strangulation" — echoes the trade historian's treatment of the 1973 oil shock and the classicist's discussion of Athens' control of grain routes through the Hellespont. The Middle East historian traces the centrality of oil to Western intervention in the region from the 1901 D'Arcy Concession through every subsequent conflict.

The 2026 war has produced, for the first time in history, the simultaneous disruption of three energy chokepoints — Hormuz, the Bab el-Mandeb threat, and Qatar's LNG terminals. The trade historian frames this as a stress test that "no scenario planner fully anticipated, despite decades of warnings." The Asianist measures its impact in the starkest terms: Japan has three weeks of LNG reserves; South Korea has nine days.

The recurring pattern: **energy dependence creates vulnerability, vulnerability invites weaponization, and weaponization produces consequences that reorder the global system.** The 1973 shock restructured global finance and energy policy for decades. The 2026 shock may accelerate the transition from maritime-dependent globalization to regionalized trade blocs — a structural transformation whose consequences will outlast the war by generations.

Imperial Overreach

Finally, every contributor identifies — in terms ranging from the Thucydidean concept of *hubris* to the Americanist's "credibility trap" to the Asianist's observation of Chinese "strategic pa-

tience" — the dynamic of imperial overreach. The classicist's treatment is the most sweeping: the observation that "the Persian question has never been resolved by military force," supported by evidence spanning from Crassus at Carrhae (53 BCE) through Julian's failed campaign (363 CE). The Americanist is the most granular: the documentation of how war aims expanded from counterproliferation to regime change in six days, replicating a pattern that took years in Vietnam and weeks in Iraq. The Middle East historian is the most passionate: the insistence that "the powerful never believe history applies to them."

The convergence is total. Six specialists, six periods, six geographic perspectives, one conclusion: **the 2026 campaign exhibits every structural characteristic of imperial overreach as identified across twenty-five centuries of historical analysis.**

II. THE DISAGREEMENTS

The convergences are striking. But a roundtable that produced only agreement would be intellectually suspect. The six perspectives diverge in ways that are productive — revealing genuine tensions in how the 2026 conflict should be understood.

Cyclical vs. Contingent

The deepest disagreement is epistemological. The classicist sees recurring patterns driven by structural constants of human nature and great-power competition. Thucydides wrote for the future because he believed that "human nature being what it is, similar events would recur at some time or other and in much the same ways." The classicist's analysis proceeds from this conviction: the Sicilian Expedition, Crassus at Carrhae, Trajan in Mesopotamia — these are not merely analogies but instances of a recurring structural dynamic. The implication is deterministic: if the structural conditions are present, the outcomes are foreseeable.

The Americanist pushes back, implicitly, through emphasis on contingency. The Vietnam essay is structured around specific decisions by specific actors — Johnson's response to Tonkin, McNamara's body-count metrics, Bremer's de-Ba'athification orders — each of which could have gone differently. The credibility trap, in this reading, is not a structural inevitability but a product of accumulated choices. The war in Iran did not have to happen; it happened because specific institutions failed and specific actors chose escalation over restraint.

The Middle East historian occupies a position between these poles — seeing structural patterns (the 1953→1979→2026 cycle) but insisting that these patterns are driven not by human nature in the abstract but by specific, identifiable material interests (oil, strategic positioning, domestic politics) that could, in principle, be managed differently.

This tension matters practically. If the classicist is right that the patterns are structural and recurring, then the outcome of the 2026 war is largely predetermined by the category of conflict it represents. If the Americanist is right that the patterns are contingent on specific decisions, then intervention — better policy, different leadership, functioning institutions — could still alter the trajectory. The distinction between "this is how great-power wars in Persia always end" and "this is how American wars end when specific institutional safeguards fail" is not academic. It determines whether the appropriate response is fatalism or reform.

Opportunity vs. Tragedy

The Asianist and the Middle East historian read the same event through lenses that produce fundamentally different emotional registers. For the Middle East historian, the 2026 war is a

tragedy — the latest iteration of a century of Western interference that has destroyed democratic possibilities, empowered authoritarians, and left a trail of civilian casualties from Halabja to Minab. The tone is one of moral urgency and accumulated grief.

For the Asianist, the same war is primarily a strategic disruption to be navigated — a crisis that creates both dangers (energy strangulation, alliance fragility) and opportunities (Chinese positioning, BRI acceleration, the weakening of American hegemony). The Asianist does not dismiss the human cost, but the analytical framework is instrumental rather than moral. The relevant question is not "is this just?" but "how do states position themselves in relation to it?"

This divergence reflects a genuine intellectual tension. The moral framework insists that the war's meaning is constituted by its human costs — the dead children, the shattered societies, the violated sovereignty. The strategic framework insists that the war's meaning is constituted by its structural effects — the redistribution of power, the reordering of alliances, the reshaping of trade routes. Neither framework is wrong. Both are incomplete. The discomfort produced by their juxtaposition is the discomfort of honestly confronting a world in which catastrophe and opportunity coexist.

The Question of Iranian Agency

A subtler disagreement concerns the degree of agency attributed to Iran itself. The classicist and the Middle East historian both emphasize Iran's civilizational depth and resilience — the former through the Achaemenid legacy and the catalogue of invasions absorbed, the latter through the 1953→1979→2026 cycle and the concept of *sabr* (patient endurance). In these readings, Iran is a historical agent with its own strategic culture, its own theory of victory, and its own civilizational continuity.

The Americanist, by contrast, treats Iran primarily as an object of American policy — the latest in a series of adversaries against whom the recurring logic of American war-making has been deployed. Iran's internal dynamics, political culture, and strategic calculations receive less attention than the structural pathologies of American decision-making. The trade historian similarly treats Iran as a geographic feature — the crossroads of Eurasian commerce, the controller of Hormuz — rather than as a political agent with purposes of its own.

The Asianist occupies a middle position, recognizing Iran's agency (the selective Hormuz closure is, after all, an Iranian strategic decision) while analyzing it primarily through its effects on other actors. China's Hormuz exemption exists because Iran chose to grant it; but the Asianist's interest is in what the exemption means for Chinese positioning, not in what it reveals about Iranian grand strategy.

These differences matter. An analysis that treats Iran primarily as a victim of Western interference (the Middle East historian's tendency) will generate different policy implications than one that treats Iran as a structural feature of great-power competition (the classicist), a target of American policy pathology (the Americanist), a strategic actor in Asian power dynamics (the Asianist), or a node in global trade networks (the trade historian). The reality encompasses all of these, and the full picture requires holding them in tension.

III. WHAT 2026 REVEALS ABOUT THE PRESENT MOMENT

The war against Iran is not only about Iran. Viewed through the lenses of democratic decline, trade fragmentation, and Asian strategic rebalancing, the conflict crystallizes trends that were already reshaping the global order before the first missile was fired.

The Democratic Recession Made Kinetic

The democratic decline essay places the 2026 war within a global wave of autocratization that the V-Dem Institute documented as the most severe since the interwar period. Forty-five countries are undergoing democratic backsliding. Autocracies outnumber democracies for the first time since the early 2000s. The United States itself is identified as experiencing "the fastest evolving episode of autocratization the USA has been through in modern history" — a judgment rendered before February 28.

The war is both symptom and accelerant of this trend. As symptom: it was launched by an administration with historically low approval ratings, facing an affordability crisis, with DHS in shutdown — the classic pattern of democracies in crisis launching foreign adventures for domestic reasons. The democratic decline specialist traces this pattern from Wilhelmine Germany through Argentina's Falklands invasion to Russia's annexation of Crimea.

As accelerant: the war's prosecution without democratic consent, the failure of the War Powers Resolution, the seven-vote House margin, and the expansion of objectives from counterproliferation to regime change in six days — all establish precedents that weaken democratic constraints on executive war-making. The comparison to Weimar's Article 48 emergency provisions is not alarmist; it is structural. Carl Schmitt's dictum that "sovereign is he who decides on the exception" has been operationalized: the president decides what constitutes an emergency, launches military operations accordingly, and no other institution says otherwise.

But the most revealing datum is the absence of a rally effect. Every major American military operation since scientific polling began has produced at least a temporary surge in public support. The Iran war produced none. The democratic decline essay identifies four explanations: the post-Iraq trust deficit, partisan sorting, the information environment, and the betrayal of Trump's anti-interventionist brand. Together, these factors describe a polity in which the mechanism by which democracies legitimize war — patriotic solidarity in the face of external threat — has broken down.

The implications extend far beyond the United States. The Asianist notes that America's democratic dysfunction is observed by every capital calculating its alignment strategy. If the United States cannot sustain domestic consent for its most consequential military operations, the credibility of American security commitments erodes — not because American military power has diminished, but because the political foundation on which alliances rest has fractured.

The Oligarchic Dimension

The democratic decline essay identifies a structural transformation that the other panelists address tangentially: the merger of economic and political power into what it calls "an oligarchic formation without precedent in American history." The technology billionaires' attendance at Trump's inauguration, Musk's installation in a government efficiency role, and the military-industrial-technology complex's stake in continued conflict — these are not peripheral features of the 2026 landscape. They are its defining political economy.

The relationship between oligarchy and war-making is, as the democratic decline specialist notes, "ancient and well-documented" — from Athenian commercial interests driving the Sicilian Expedition to the British East India Company maintaining its own army. What is novel is the fusion of military-industrial power with technology-sector wealth, creating a class of actors whose economic interests are served by both the war itself (defense contracts, interceptor replacement, hardened infrastructure markets) and the crisis it generates (emergency governance, information control, the punishment of ethical dissent, as in the Anthropic-Pentagon dispute).

The trade historian adds an economic dimension: the cost-exchange equation of the war —

$50,000 Iranian drones forcing the expenditure of $5-15 million interceptors — is not merely a military problem. It is a business model. Every interceptor fired represents demand for replacement. Every piece of destroyed infrastructure represents a reconstruction contract. The political economy of permanent war, first identified by Eisenhower, has achieved its most refined expression.

Globalization's Stress Test

The trade historian's central argument — that the 2026 war represents a stress test of the globalized economy that reveals fragilities previously obscured by decades of peace — intersects with the Asianist's analysis of energy vulnerability and the Middle East historian's treatment of the region's centrality to global commerce.

The selective Hormuz closure has created, in effect, a two-tier global economy: one in which Chinese-flagged vessels transit safely and access Iranian energy at potentially discounted rates, and another in which Western-flagged vessels sit anchored while their dependent economies scramble for alternatives. This is not merely a wartime disruption; it is a demonstration of principle — that the global commons can be divided along geopolitical lines, and that the division advantages America's primary strategic competitor.

The trade historian traces the historical precedent: the United States occupied precisely this position during the European wars of 1914-1918, leveraging geographic distance from the theater of destruction into economic advantage. China in 2026 occupies the analogous position. The Asianist makes the same comparison explicitly: "Every day the war continues, the United States expends military resources, diplomatic capital, and domestic political cohesion."

The combined picture is of a global order undergoing accelerated fragmentation — not through any single cause, but through the convergence of democratic decline, oligarchic capture, energy weaponization, and great-power competition, all catalyzed by a war that was launched without consent and is producing consequences beyond anyone's control.

The Information Revolution

All six essays address, to varying degrees, the transformation of the information environment and its effects on war-making. The classicist reads this through Herodotus's "paradox of modern information war: more information produces not convergence toward truth but proliferation of competing narratives." The democratic decline specialist analyzes the destruction of Habermas's public sphere — the shared information environment that democratic deliberation requires. The Americanist traces the evolution from Vietnam's "credibility gap," which took years to open, to Iraq's WMD deception, which took months to expose, to the Iran war's "terminal credibility gap," which was "present at the moment of initiation."

The convergence: the information architecture that enabled twentieth-century democracies to manufacture consent for war has been destroyed, but it has not been replaced by an information architecture that enables informed democratic dissent. The result is neither consent nor informed opposition but fragmentation — parallel information ecosystems in which supporters and opponents of the war inhabit different factual universes. The 175 dead children of Minab are, simultaneously, documented in real-time by Amnesty International and BBC Verify, and filtered through partisan narratives that neutralize their political impact. The consequence is a form of democratic paralysis: the public cannot be rallied, but neither can it effectively resist.

IV. THE PERSIAN QUESTION THROUGH TIME

Among the most remarkable convergences in the roundtable is the recognition — from three entirely different disciplinary perspectives — that Iran is not merely the latest site of great-power conflict but a *recurring* site, and that this recurrence is not coincidental but structural.

The Crossroads

The classicist, the Middle East historian, and the trade historian all identify Iran's geography as the fundamental driver of its centrality to world-historical conflict. Iran sits at the crossroads of every major trade route connecting East Asia to Europe, the Persian Gulf to Central Asia, and South Asia to the Mediterranean. The Achaemenid Royal Road, the Silk Road, the maritime spice route, the modern oil tanker route through Hormuz — all pass through or past Iranian territory. This is not accident; it is geology and topography.

The trade historian frames this most explicitly: "Iran's position — between the Caspian Sea and the Persian Gulf, between Mesopotamia and Central Asia — makes it the unavoidable crossroads of any east-west or north-south trade route across the Eurasian landmass." China's Belt and Road Initiative, the twenty-first century's most ambitious infrastructure program, recognizes this geography: the $400 billion China-Iran strategic cooperation agreement was designed to formalize a commercial relationship whose deep structure is two millennia old.

The classicist tells the military history of this geography: Rome fought Persia for seven centuries without ever establishing a stable eastern frontier. The border between the two civilizations was "the most militarized in the ancient world" — not because of ideological hostility but because of geographic inevitability. Two great powers, sharing a contested frontier in territory of immense strategic value, could not avoid confrontation.

The Middle East historian tells the political history: from the 1907 Anglo-Russian Agreement that divided Iran into spheres of influence, through the 1953 coup, through the Iran-Iraq War, to the present conflict, Western powers have treated Iran's political arrangements as subject to external revision — precisely because Iran's geographic position makes its domestic politics a matter of global consequence.

Civilizational Persistence

The classicist and the Middle East historian converge on a second point: Iran's civilizational persistence. "Persia is conquered, but Persia endures. The conqueror is absorbed. The civilization persists." Alexander burned Persepolis; within a century, his successors had adopted Persian titles and patronized Persian culture. The Arabs imposed Islam; within two centuries, Ferdowsi's *Shahnameh* had reasserted Persian literary identity. The Mongols devastated the land; within a century, the Il-Khanate had adopted Persian administration and language.

The Middle East historian traces this persistence into the modern period: the Shah's quarter-century of American-backed rule did not erase the memory of Mossadegh; the Islamic Republic's forty-seven years have not erased the memory of secular nationalism. The Iranian capacity to absorb external shocks and reconstitute — what the classicist calls "strategic patience as cultural practice" and what the Islamic tradition calls *sabr* — is not a strategic posture adopted for the current conflict. It is a civilizational disposition cultivated across millennia.

The strategic implication, identified by both the classicist and the Middle East historian, is that Iran belongs to a category of adversary that cannot be subdued by military force alone. Rome learned to manage Persia but never to defeat it. The distinction, as the classicist notes, "matters." The 2026 campaign's architects appear to have conflated the two — assuming that

tactical devastation (which they have achieved) is equivalent to strategic resolution (which the historical record suggests is unachievable through these means).

The Mossadegh Cycle and Its Acceleration

The Middle East historian's treatment of the 1953→1979→2026 cycle acquires additional depth when read alongside the trade historian's analysis of the sanctions paradox. The 1953 coup was driven by oil interests and Cold War positioning. Its unintended consequence — the 1979 revolution — created a regime more hostile to Western interests than Mossadegh ever was. The revolution's unintended consequence — the nuclear program, driven by the desire for sovereign deterrence — created the justification for the 2026 war. And the sanctions campaign designed to prevent the nuclear program instead accelerated it while pushing Iran toward China.

Each intervention was designed to solve the problem created by the previous intervention. Each created a new problem that was "larger, more complex, and more resistant to external manipulation than the last." The trade historian adds the economic dimension: maximum pressure sanctions did not produce maximum compliance but rather maximum resistance, maximum alignment with China, and maximum nuclear advancement. "The 2026 war is, in a meaningful sense, the kinetic phase of a sanctions campaign that failed on its own terms."

The question the Middle East historian poses — "What will 2026 create the conditions for?" — haunts the entire roundtable. The honest answer, offered by the Middle East historian with characteristic directness, is: "no one knows, and anyone who claims to know is selling something." But the historical pattern is clear enough to constitute a warning.

V. WHAT HISTORY WARNS

If the six historians of this roundtable could deliver a joint briefing to the decision-makers directing Operation Epic Fury, what specific warnings would they offer? The essays converge on five.

First Warning: The Escalation Trap Is Already Closing

The Americanist's analysis of the "credibility trap" is the panel's most operationally urgent contribution. The mechanism is precise: once a war is initiated, the political costs of admitting failure exceed the political costs of continuing. Each additional commitment of blood and treasure raises the retrospective stakes. Six American servicemembers are dead. 175 children are dead at Minab. A head of state has been assassinated. The Strait of Hormuz is functionally closed. To stop now would be to acknowledge that all of this was undertaken without adequate justification.

The trap, as the Americanist documents, took a decade to form in Vietnam, months in Iraq, and has formed in six days in Iran. Trump's rejection of the March 1 CIA back-channel contact — "I said Too Late!" — closed the earliest available off-ramp. The White House ultimatum of "immunity" or "absolutely guaranteed death" eliminates the middle ground where negotiations occur. Hegseth's declaration that the campaign is "just getting started" establishes the rhetorical framework for indefinite continuation.

The classicist reinforces this from ancient precedent: Crassus did not plan merely to punish Parthia but to conquer it, and his ambitions escalated as the campaign progressed. The dynamic is structural, not personal: military success generates its own momentum, and each tactical achievement makes the next objective seem achievable.

Second Warning: The Home Front Is the Real Battlefield

The democratic decline specialist and the classicist converge on what may be the panel's most consequential warning: that the wars which destroy great powers are not the wars they lose abroad but the wars that corrode their institutions at home.

The classicist frames this through Athens after Sicily: the failed expedition did not merely lose men and ships; it triggered the oligarchic coup of 411 BCE and the cascade of political instability that ended Athenian democracy. The democratic decline specialist frames it through Weimar: the emergency provisions that enabled executive war-making did not merely bypass the Reichstag; they hollowed out the constitutional structure until there was nothing left to defend.

The 2026 war has already damaged American democratic institutions: the War Powers Resolution has been tested and found wanting; the principle of congressional authority over war has been further eroded; the precedent of preemptive regime change without authorization has been established. The democratic decline specialist identifies the most dangerous trajectory: not dramatic collapse but "a prolonged period of institutional ambiguity — a gray zone in which democratic forms persist... but the substance of democratic governance is progressively hollowed out." This is the Orbán model, the Erdoğan model — and, increasingly, the American model.

Third Warning: The Energy Shock Will Restructure the Global Order

The trade historian and the Asianist converge on the long-term consequences of the energy disruption. The 1973 oil shock did not merely raise oil prices temporarily; it permanently restructured global finance, energy policy, and Middle Eastern politics. The 2026 shock, which the trade historian argues is more severe in its simultaneity if not yet in its duration, will drive comparable restructuring.

The Asianist's analysis of the 1941 oil embargo against Japan provides the most alarming historical parallel: energy desperation "compresses decision-making timelines, narrows the perceived range of acceptable options, and creates conditions under which previously unthinkable choices become thinkable." Japan in 1941 did not want to attack the United States; it felt it had no alternative. South Korea with nine days of gas reserves, Japan with three weeks of LNG, India in "war mode" — these nations are not yet in 1941-level desperation, but the trajectory is in that direction.

The trade historian warns that the longer-term consequence may be the acceleration of deglobalization — the fragmentation of the integrated global economy into regionalized blocs. The selective Hormuz closure demonstrates that "the global commons can be divided along geopolitical lines," and nations dependent on those commons will rationally seek to reduce their dependence. The aggregate effect of these individual rational choices will be the fragmentation of the system itself.

Fourth Warning: The Mossadegh Cycle Will Continue

The Middle East historian's warning about the law of unintended consequences is reinforced by every other contributor. The classicist's observation that Rome's client-king installations worked only when the client state was "small, geographically accessible, culturally permeable, and surrounded by Roman power" — and failed when it was "large, distant, culturally resistant, and possessed of its own imperial tradition" — applies with obvious force to Iran.

The Americanist's documentation of de-Ba'athification's catastrophic consequences in a country of twenty-six million provides the most recent precedent for what regime dissolution might look like in a country of eighty-eight million. The Asianist's analysis of the Korean partition

and the Afghan collapse provides further evidence that "external military intervention that destroys a regime without a plan for what follows frequently produces not reconstruction but fragmentation."

The warning is specific: whatever follows the Islamic Republic — if the regime falls — will be shaped by the memory of the 2026 war. The dead children of Minab will join the memories of Mossadegh, SAVAK, chemical weapons, and Flight 655 in the foundation of the next generation's political consciousness. "These memories will not fade when the missiles stop. They will harden into the foundation of the next generation's political consciousness."

Fifth Warning: Nuclear Proliferation Will Accelerate

This warning appears in multiple essays but is stated most directly by the Americanist and the Middle East historian. The destruction of Iran's nuclear program paradoxically strengthens the case for nuclear acquisition by every state that fears American military action. The lesson, as the strategic synthesis notes, is clear: "without nuclear weapons, you can be attacked with impunity." North Korea's nuclear arsenal has made it untouchable. Iran's nuclear program, still short of a weapon, has failed to deter attack. The incentive structure for proliferation has never been more favorable.

VI. WHAT HISTORY CANNOT TELL US

The panel's intellectual honesty requires acknowledging what historical analysis cannot illuminate. Several features of the 2026 conflict are genuinely unprecedented, and historical analogy may obscure rather than reveal their significance.

The information environment has no historical parallel. The classicist reaches for Herodotus's management of competing oral traditions; the democratic decline specialist invokes Habermas's public sphere; the Americanist traces the evolution from Cronkite to embedded journalism to OSINT. But the 2026 information ecosystem — real-time satellite imagery, AI-generated analysis, algorithmic curation, simultaneous global distribution of contradictory narratives — is qualitatively different from anything that preceded it. Whether this environment empowers democratic accountability or paralyzes it is a question that historical precedent cannot answer.

AI in warfare represents a genuinely novel variable. The Anthropic-Pentagon dispute, the integration of AI into operational planning, and the potential for autonomous weapons systems introduce decision-making dynamics that no prior conflict has exhibited. The speed of AI-assisted targeting compresses the observe-orient-decide-act cycle beyond human cognitive capacity, creating a form of warfare in which the traditional friction that Clausewitz identified — and that gave diplomats time to intervene — may be eliminated entirely.

The destruction of cloud infrastructure creates a category of economic warfare with no historical parallel, as the trade historian acknowledges. The cascading effects of data center destruction on banking, logistics, humanitarian operations, and governance represent a vulnerability that did not exist a generation ago and for which no historical analogy is adequate.

The speed of the 2026 conflict exceeds all precedent. The classicist notes that the Peloponnesian War lasted twenty-seven years; the Iran-Iraq War lasted eight; the 2026 conflict has produced more strategic consequences in six days than most ancient campaigns produced in a season. The ability to kill a head of state in the opening minutes, to expand war aims from counterproliferation to regime change in less than a week, to disrupt the global energy system

in seventy-two hours — this compression of consequence into ever-shorter timeframes creates a decision-making environment that no historical model fully captures.

History warns, illuminates, and contextualizes. But it does not predict, and the 2026 war unfolds in a technological, informational, and economic environment that differs in kind — not merely in degree — from any prior conflict. The historians assembled here offer their perspectives with the caveat that the classicist states most directly: "classical parallels are illuminating but not deterministic. History does not repeat; it rhymes. But some rhymes are so persistent, across so many centuries and so many configurations of power, that to ignore them is itself an act of hubris."

The panel convenes in the conviction that this hubris — the belief that the present is exempt from the patterns of the past — is the most dangerous delusion available to the powerful. Whether the decision-makers of 2026 share that conviction, the coming months will reveal.

This synthesis was prepared for the Academic Roundtable on the Historical Context of the US-Iran War, March 6, 2026. It integrates the perspectives of six contributing historians specializing in classical antiquity, modern European democratic decline, American foreign policy, Asian geopolitics, Middle Eastern and colonial history, and trade and economic history. The views expressed represent the synthesist's interpretation of convergences and divergences across the contributing essays.

Chapter 2

Classical Antiquity: Empire, Hubris, and the Persian Question

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For the Academic Roundtable on Historical Context of the US-Iran Conflict

March 2026

Prologue: The Oldest War in the Western Canon

On February 28, 2026, the United States launched Operation Epic Fury against the Islamic Republic of Iran — the largest American military operation since the 2003 invasion of Iraq. Within minutes, a precision strike killed Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei. Within days, 2,500 strikes had delivered 6,000 munitions across all twenty-four Iranian provinces. The stated rationale shifted, in less than a week, from counterproliferation to explicit regime change, with the American president demanding to be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader.

To a classical historian, every sentence of that summary resonates with echoes two and a half millennia old.

The West's war with Persia is the oldest continuous geopolitical narrative in the European tradition. When Herodotus sat down in the mid-fifth century BCE to explain why Greeks and Persians fought, he was inaugurating not only the discipline of history but a framework of civilizational opposition — West versus East, freedom versus despotism, the city-state versus the empire — that has never entirely lost its hold on the Western political imagination. The Greco-Persian Wars gave us Marathon and Thermopylae, yes, but they also gave us the conceptual vocabulary through which Western powers have understood, and misunderstood, their encounters with Persian civilization for twenty-five centuries.

This essay argues that the classical record offers not merely poetic parallels but structural insights into the dynamics of the 2026 conflict. The Thucydidean trap, the Sicilian Expedition, Rome's Parthian wars, the Achaemenid legacy, and the structural tension between democratic governance and sustained military campaigns are not analogies deployed for rhetorical effect. They are patterns — recurring configurations of power, ambition, information, and misjudgment — that illuminate the present because the underlying dynamics of great-power competition, imperial overreach, and democratic war-making have not fundamentally changed.

I. Thucydides and the Trap: Athens, Sparta, and the Logic of Preemption

The Structural Theory

Graham Allison's "Thucydides Trap" — the proposition that war becomes likely when a rising power threatens to displace an established one — has become perhaps the most cited classical framework in contemporary international relations. Allison drew the concept from Thucydides'

famous formulation in Book I of the *History of the Peloponnesian War*: "It was the rise of Athens, and the fear that this inspired in Sparta, that made war inevitable" (1.23.6).

The framework is typically applied to US-China relations, but the 2026 conflict reveals a more complex geometry. The United States did not attack Iran because Iran was rising to displace American hegemony — Iran's GDP is smaller than that of the state of Ohio. The war is better understood through a different Thucydidean lens: the dynamics by which a dominant power, anxious about a shifting balance and emboldened by its own military superiority, launches a preemptive campaign that generates consequences far exceeding its original intentions.

This is not the Thucydides Trap of Book I. It is the Thucydides Trap of Books VI and VII — the Sicilian Expedition.

The Sicilian Expedition and the Architecture of Overreach

In the summer of 415 BCE, the Athenian assembly voted to launch a massive naval expedition against Syracuse, the most powerful city in Sicily. The proximate cause was a request for aid from the small Sicilian city of Segesta, which was engaged in a local conflict. The deeper cause was imperial ambition: Alcibiades, the expedition's most vocal champion, argued that conquering Sicily would give Athens the resources to dominate the entire Mediterranean. As Thucydides reports, most Athenians "were ignorant of the size of the island and the numbers of its inhabitants... and they did not realize that they were taking on a war of almost the same magnitude as the war against the Peloponnesians" (6.1).

The structural parallels to 2026 are striking, and they operate at multiple levels.

First, the information deficit. The Athenian assembly voted for the Sicilian Expedition on the basis of wildly inaccurate intelligence. Segesta's envoys had borrowed gold and silver plate from neighboring cities to create the impression of wealth sufficient to finance the campaign (Thuc. 6.46). Athenian envoys sent to verify the claims were deceived. The assembly committed the largest expeditionary force in Athenian history — 134 triremes, 5,100 hoplites, and approximately 30,000 total personnel — based on what amounted to fraudulent intelligence about conditions on the ground.

Operation Epic Fury was launched with considerably better intelligence about Iranian military capabilities. But the strategic intelligence — the questions of what would happen *after* the strikes, how Iranian society would respond, whether regime change was achievable without ground forces, how regional actors would react — appears to have been either absent or ignored. The expansion of war aims from counterproliferation to regime change within six days suggests that the campaign's architects, like the Athenian assembly, committed to a course of action without fully reckoning with its implications. When the American president demanded a role in selecting Iran's next leader, he was, in Thucydidean terms, revealing that the war's objectives had expanded beyond the capacity of the force deployed to achieve them — the precise dynamic that doomed Athens in Sicily.

Second, the democratic assembly and distant war. Thucydides is acutely attentive to the psychology of democratic decision-making about military operations. The Athenian assembly was seized by what he calls *eros* — a collective desire that overwhelmed prudential calculation: "A passionate desire (*eros*) to sail fell upon everyone alike" (6.24). Nicias, the reluctant general who argued against the expedition, attempted to dampen enthusiasm by demanding an enormous force, thinking the cost would deter the assembly. Instead, the assembly voted to give him everything he asked for and more, interpreting the scale of the commitment as evidence of its seriousness rather than its danger.

The 2026 dynamic is, in one respect, the inverse. Where the Athenian *demos* was seized by

enthusiasm for a distant war, the American *demos* has been conspicuously resistant. The 25-27% approval rating for the strikes is the lowest initial support for any major US military operation in recorded polling history. No rally-around-the-flag effect materialized. And yet the war proceeded — not because the people demanded it, but because institutional mechanisms that might have checked executive action (the War Powers Resolution, defeated 212-219 in the House) proved inadequate.

This inversion is itself deeply Thucydidean. Thucydides understood that democratic war-making could fail in two directions: the assembly could be stampeded into war by demagogues (Sicily), or it could be bypassed by leaders who acted without genuine popular mandate (as when Alcibiades conducted secret diplomacy with Sparta). The 2026 case represents the second failure mode — a war launched by executive decision, ratified after the fact by the narrowest of legislative margins, in the face of overwhelming public opposition. Thucydides, who lived through both the democratic enthusiasm for Sicily and the oligarchic coup of 411 BCE that followed military disaster, would have recognized the pattern: when democratic institutions fail to constrain war-making, legitimacy erodes, and the political order itself becomes unstable.

Third, the problem of the secondary front. The Sicilian Expedition drew Athenian resources away from the primary theater — the war against Sparta and its allies in mainland Greece. While Athens poured men and ships into Sicily, Sparta fortified Decelea in Attica, establishing a permanent base that disrupted Athenian agriculture and cut off access to the silver mines at Laurion (Thuc. 7.27-28). The result was a two-front war that Athens lacked the resources to sustain.

The 2026 conflict has already produced a second front. Israel's simultaneous campaign in Lebanon — the blanket evacuation of 500,000 residents from Dahiya, ground combat confirmed by UNIFIL at Kfar Kila — replicates the structural danger of strategic overextension. Iran's distributed retaliation across six countries, the Houthi threat in the Red Sea, and the selective closure of the Strait of Hormuz create precisely the kind of multi-axis resource drain that destroyed Athens in the years after Sicily. The Athenians, too, believed that the conquest of Syracuse would *simplify* their strategic position. It did not.

II. Rome and Regime Change: When Does Killing the King Work?

The Logic of Decapitation

The killing of Ayatollah Khamenei in the opening minutes of Operation Epic Fury is, as the synthesis document notes, "the most consequential leadership decapitation in modern military history." The Roman experience with political assassination and regime change in foreign states offers the deepest classical archive for evaluating this strategy — and the record is decidedly mixed.

The Cases Where It Worked

Rome's most celebrated case of successful decapitation was the defeat of Jugurtha, king of Numidia, in 105 BCE. After years of frustrating guerrilla warfare across North Africa — a campaign marked by corruption, incompetence, and repeated Roman embarrassments — Jugurtha was betrayed by his father-in-law Bocchus and delivered to the Roman general Sulla. Jugurtha was paraded through Rome in Marius' triumph and executed by strangulation in the Tullianum prison (Plutarch, *Marius* 12; Sallust, *Bellum Jugurthinum* 113-114).

But the success of this decapitation was contingent on specific conditions. Numidia was a tribal confederation held together primarily by Jugurtha's personal authority and network of alliances. Removing him dissolved the opposing coalition. Rome had an alternative client — Bocchus himself — ready to assume power. And Numidia was on Rome's doorstep, within the established sphere of Roman military and diplomatic influence.

Similarly, the defeat of Mithridates VI of Pontus — Rome's most persistent eastern adversary, who fought three wars against Rome between 88 and 63 BCE — ultimately succeeded through a combination of military pressure and the king's suicide in 63 BCE after betrayal by his own son Pharnaces (Appian, *Mithridatic Wars* 111-112). Again, the preconditions were specific: Mithridates' power was substantially personal, his coalition was exhausted by decades of war, and Rome had clear succession arrangements.

The Cases Where It Failed: Parthia and the Eternal Frontier

The Roman experience that bears most directly on the 2026 conflict is the centuries-long confrontation with Parthia and its successor state, Sassanid Persia — the ancient power that controlled precisely the territory now governed by the Islamic Republic of Iran.

The first major Roman campaign against Parthia was Marcus Licinius Crassus' invasion of 53 BCE, which ended in catastrophic defeat at the Battle of Carrhae (modern Harran, in southeastern Turkey). Crassus — the wealthiest man in Rome, driven by a desire for military glory to match Pompey and Caesar — led seven legions across the Euphrates into the Mesopotamian desert. At Carrhae, the Parthian general Surena destroyed the Roman force using mounted archers who employed the famous "Parthian shot" — firing backward while retreating, drawing the Roman infantry into an exhausted pursuit across open terrain. Crassus was killed during negotiations. Twenty thousand Romans died; ten thousand were captured (Plutarch, *Crassus* 25-31; Dio Cassius 40.21-27).

Carrhae established the pattern that would persist for seven centuries. Rome could invade Mesopotamia. Rome could even capture the Parthian or Sassanid capital of Ctesiphon (modern Salman Pak, near Baghdad) — as Trajan did in 116 CE, as Septimius Severus did in 198 CE, as Carus did in 283 CE, and as Julian attempted in 363 CE. But Rome could never *hold* the territory. The pattern was monotonously consistent: advance, capture, withdraw. The geography — vast distances, hostile terrain, extended supply lines, a population that did not welcome liberation — defeated occupation every time.

Trajan's campaign is particularly instructive. In 114-116 CE, the emperor conquered Armenia, Mesopotamia, and Assyria, reaching the Persian Gulf — the deepest Roman penetration into Persia. He reportedly wept at the shore, saying he was too old to follow Alexander's path to India (Dio Cassius 68.29). But within months, revolts erupted across the conquered territory. The Jewish diaspora rose in simultaneous rebellion across Cyrenaica, Egypt, and Cyprus. Trajan was forced to withdraw, and he died on the return journey. His successor Hadrian immediately abandoned all the eastern conquests, recognizing that the territory was indefensible.

The parallel to 2026 is structural, not merely geographic. The United States can — and has — devastated Iran's military infrastructure from the air. It has killed the supreme leader and dozens of senior officials. It has achieved near-complete aerial superiority. But the synthesis document's assessment that the campaign's "strategic coherence is questionable" echoes a judgment that every Roman emperor from Trajan to Julian eventually confronted: tactical victories in Persia do not translate to strategic outcomes because the underlying power — a civilization of enormous depth, geographic extent, and resilience — cannot be subdued by military force alone.

The Romans never found a solution to the Persian question. They tried decapitation (Crassus against Orodes II), overwhelming force (Trajan), punitive campaigns (Septimius Severus), and

ideological warfare (Julian, who attempted to rally Persian Christians against the Sassanid state). None produced a lasting resolution. The frontier between Rome and Persia remained the most militarized border in the ancient world for seven centuries — until the Arab conquests of the seventh century CE destroyed both the Sassanid Empire and Rome's eastern provinces simultaneously, rendering the question moot through mutual catastrophe.

The lesson is not that military force against Persia is futile. It is that Persia — Iran — represents a category of adversary that Rome learned to manage but never to defeat. The distinction matters.

Regime Change and Its Aftermath

Rome's experience also illuminates the aftermath of successful decapitation. When Rome removed a foreign leader, the result was rarely the stable, compliant successor state that planners envisioned. The assassination of Jugurtha produced decades of instability in North Africa. The defeat of Perseus of Macedon in 168 BCE led to the partition of Macedonia into four republics — which promptly rebelled, requiring direct Roman annexation (Livy 45.29; Polybius 36.17). The elimination of Cleopatra and the annexation of Egypt in 30 BCE produced a province so strategically vital that the emperor prohibited senators from even visiting it without permission, for fear that any rival who controlled Egypt's grain supply could hold Rome hostage (Tacitus, *Annales* 2.59; Dio Cassius 51.17).

Trump's demand to be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader echoes, with remarkable precision, the Roman practice of installing client kings — *reges socii et amici populi Romani*. The Roman record suggests that such arrangements work when the client state is small, geographically accessible, culturally permeable, and surrounded by Roman power (as with the Herodian dynasty in Judaea). They fail when the state is large, distant, culturally resistant, and possessed of its own imperial tradition. Iran, a nation of ninety million people with twenty-five centuries of continuous political identity, falls emphatically into the second category.

III. The Achaemenid Perspective: 2,500 Years of Being Invaded

Iran Is Persia

No participant in the 2026 conflict possesses a longer historical memory than Iran itself. When Iranian officials, intellectuals, and ordinary citizens process the current war, they do so through a civilizational lens that extends to Cyrus the Great's founding of the Achaemenid Empire in 550 BCE. This is not metaphorical. The continuity of Iranian civilization — through Achaemenid, Seleucid, Parthian, Sassanid, Arab, Mongol, Safavid, Qajar, and Pahlavi eras — is a foundational element of Iranian national identity, reinforced by the Persian language (which has maintained recognizable continuity for over two millennia), the Nowruz festival (celebrated continuously for at least 3,000 years), and the physical monuments of Persepolis, Pasargadae, and Isfahan.

This civilizational depth produces a strategic posture that Western analysts frequently misread. When Iranian Foreign Minister Araghchi declares Iran "ready for ground invasion" and frames the conflict as a "quagmire," he is drawing on a national narrative in which foreign invasions are absorbed, endured, and ultimately outlasted. The narrative is not without foundation.

The Catalogue of Invasions

Alexander of Macedon conquered the Achaemenid Empire between 334 and 323 BCE, burning Persepolis in 330 BCE in an act of destruction that remains a living wound in Iranian collective

memory. But the Seleucid state that Alexander's successors established was itself gradually absorbed by Persian culture — the Parthians who replaced the Seleucids in the second century BCE adopted Persian titles, patronized Zoroastrianism alongside Hellenistic traditions, and positioned themselves as heirs to the Achaemenid legacy.

The Arab conquest of the seventh century CE imposed Islam but did not erase Persian identity. Within two centuries, the Persian language had reasserted itself through literary culture — Ferdowsi's *Shahnameh* (completed c. 1010 CE) consciously preserved pre-Islamic Iranian mythology and history as a national epic. The Mongol invasions of the thirteenth century — which killed perhaps ninety percent of the population in some regions and destroyed the irrigation infrastructure that sustained Persian agriculture — represent the deepest wound in Iranian historical memory. And yet, within a century, the Mongol Il-Khanate had adopted Persian administrative practices, the Persian language, and eventually Islam.

The pattern is consistent: Persia is conquered, but Persia endures. The conqueror is absorbed. The civilization persists.

This is not the experience of a state that can be restructured by decapitation strikes. Iran's 130-hour internet blackout, its panic buying, its 100,000 refugees fleeing Tehran — these are real. But the assumption that military devastation will produce political capitulation reflects a misunderstanding of how Iranian society processes external violence. The Iran-Iraq War of 1980-1988 — in which Iraq, backed by the United States and most of the Arab world, invaded Iran and fought a devastating eight-year war that killed approximately 500,000 Iranians — produced not collapse but consolidation. The war is remembered in Iran as the "Sacred Defense" (*Defa-e Moqaddas*), and it remains the foundational legitimating narrative of the Islamic Republic.

Strategic Patience as Cultural Practice

The concept of *sabr* — patience, endurance, steadfastness — is central to both Islamic and specifically Iranian cultural traditions. In Shi'a Islam, which has been the state religion of Iran since the Safavid conversion of the sixteenth century, the theme of righteous suffering is theologically foundational: the martyrdom of Imam Hussein at Karbala in 680 CE provides a paradigm in which defeat in the present is spiritually meaningful and ultimately vindicated.

This is not to essentialize Iranian culture or reduce strategic calculation to theological determinism. Iranian leaders make rational calculations based on material interests, as the secret March 1 CIA contact demonstrates. But the cultural and historical depth that underlies Iran's strategic patience is a factor that purely material analysis consistently underweights. When the synthesis document notes that Iran's "theory of victory is survival," it is identifying a strategic posture rooted in twenty-five centuries of practice.

The Achaemenid kings had a saying, preserved in the Behistun inscription of Darius I (c. 520 BCE): "By the favor of Ahura Mazda, I am of such a sort that I am a friend to right, I am not a friend to wrong." The inscription was propaganda, of course — Darius was justifying his seizure of power through a narrative of divine legitimacy. But the structure of the claim — patience, righteousness, the confidence that time vindicates the just — echoes through Iranian political culture to the present day.

IV. Herodotus and the Information War: Narrating the Other

The First Historian and the First Culture War

Herodotus of Halicarnassus (c. 484-425 BCE) wrote the *Histories* to explain why Greeks and Persians went to war. In doing so, he created not only the first work of historical inquiry but the first sustained narrative of civilizational encounter — and the first systematic distortion of an adversary's culture in the service of political narrative.

The Greek image of Persia was a study in projection. The Persians were portrayed as despotic, luxurious, effeminate, servile, and incapable of free thought — the negative image against which Greek freedom, austerity, and rationality were defined. Aeschylus' *Persae* (472 BCE), the oldest surviving Greek tragedy, depicts the Persian court as a place of wailing, breast-beating, and abject submission — a spectacle designed to flatter Athenian self-regard. The historical Persians, who administered the largest and most diverse empire the world had yet seen through a sophisticated system of satrapies, royal roads, and multicultural tolerance (as documented in the Cyrus Cylinder), bore little resemblance to their Greek caricatures.

Herodotus was more nuanced than Aeschylus — he praised Persian courage, noted Persian customs with ethnographic curiosity, and even suggested that some Persian practices were superior to Greek ones (Hdt. 1.131-140). But even Herodotus structured his narrative around a fundamental opposition between Greek liberty and Persian servitude, famously reporting that when Xerxes asked the exiled Spartan king Demaratus how the Greeks could resist his massive army, Demaratus replied: "They are free, but not entirely free: the law is their master, and they fear that more than your subjects fear you" (Hdt. 7.104).

The 2026 Information Architecture

The parallels to contemporary media framing are uncomfortable and instructive. The narrative infrastructure surrounding the 2026 conflict reproduces, with remarkable fidelity, the classical structure of civilizational opposition. Iran is presented as a theocratic tyranny whose people yearn for liberation — a framing that reprises, with updated vocabulary, the Greek assumption that Persian subjects were slaves who could not fight with the conviction of free men. The American president's claim that he should be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader assumes that the Iranian political order is an illegitimate imposition upon a population waiting to be freed — precisely the assumption Alexander carried to Persepolis in 330 BCE.

But the information environment of 2026 differs from that of fifth-century Greece — and from that of 2003 — in ways that fundamentally alter the dynamics of narrative control. The synthesis document identifies a critical structural shift: "The administration cannot manufacture consent because the information architecture that enabled consent-manufacturing no longer exists." BBC Verify contradicts CENTCOM within hours. Open-source intelligence documents civilian casualties in real time. The Minab school strike — 175 children killed on Day 1 — circulates through global media simultaneously with official narratives of precision and restraint.

Herodotus would recognize this dynamic, though its scale would astonish him. The *Histories* were composed in a world where competing narratives coexisted: Greek accounts, Persian accounts (now largely lost), Egyptian accounts, Babylonian accounts. Herodotus explicitly noted contradictions between sources, sometimes presenting multiple versions of the same event and leaving the reader to judge (e.g., Hdt. 1.95 on the origins of Cyrus). The difference is velocity and accessibility. Where Herodotus spent decades traveling the Mediterranean world collecting oral testimonies, the 2026 information environment delivers contradictory narratives to every connected device within minutes.

The consequence is what might be called the **Herodotean paradox of modern information**

war: more information produces not convergence toward truth but proliferation of competing narratives, each marshaling its own evidence, each serving its own political constituency. The Greek public of 480 BCE held a broadly unified narrative of the Persian Wars. The American public of 2026 cannot agree on whether the war is justified, let alone what it means.

Barbarians and the Construction of the Enemy

The Greek concept of *barbaros* — originally an onomatopoeia for incomprehensible speech ("bar-bar-bar") — evolved during the Persian Wars into a full-blown ideology of civilizational hierarchy. After Marathon and Salamis, "barbarian" ceased to mean merely "non-Greek-speaking" and came to connote a fundamental inferiority of character: the barbarian was slavish by nature, incapable of self-governance, and fated to be ruled (Aristotle, *Politics* 1.1252b; Euripides, *Iphigenia at Aulis* 1400).

This ideological construction served a practical purpose: it justified Athenian imperialism. The Delian League, founded in 478 BCE as a defensive alliance against Persia, was transformed by Athens into an instrument of tribute extraction and political domination — justified by the claim that Athens was defending Greek civilization against barbarism. When Pericles diverted League funds to build the Parthenon, the Samian ambassadors protested that Athens was "acting like a vain woman, covering herself with expensive jewelry bought with money taken by force" (Plutarch, *Pericles* 12). Athens responded with the argument that as long as it provided defense against the barbarian threat, it could use the surplus as it wished.

The construction of Iran as a civilizational threat — rather than a strategic competitor with specific, identifiable interests — serves an analogous function in 2026. It transforms a conflict over nuclear proliferation, regional influence, and geopolitical competition into a struggle between civilization and barbarism, foreclosing the possibility of negotiation with an adversary who has been placed outside the boundaries of legitimate political order. Thucydides, who watched Athens destroy the neutral island of Melos with the argument that "the strong do what they can and the weak suffer what they must" (5.89), understood where such logic leads.

V. Democratic War-Making: The Structural Tension

The Athenian Experience

Athens in the fifth century BCE was the first state to face the structural challenge that the United States confronts in 2026: how does a democratic polity sustain a military campaign when the popular assembly that authorizes war can also repudiate it?

The Athenian answer was: badly. The Athenian *ekklesia* could be stampeded into war by eloquent demagogues (the Sicilian Expedition), but it could also turn savagely on commanders who failed to deliver results. After the naval victory at Arginusae in 406 BCE, the Athenian assembly executed six of its own generals — including the son of Pericles — for failing to rescue drowning sailors after a battle they had *won* (Xenophon, *Hellenica* 1.7). Socrates, serving as an epistates (presiding officer) that day, refused to put the illegal collective trial to a vote and was overruled (Plato, *Apology* 32b). The incident illustrates the terrifying volatility of democratic war governance: the same assembly that commissions a campaign can destroy the careers and lives of those who carry it out.

Alcibiades' trajectory is even more instructive. The most charismatic Athenian politician of his generation, Alcibiades championed the Sicilian Expedition, was recalled to face trial for religious sacrilege before the campaign was complete, defected to Sparta (where he helped Sparta destroy

Athens' position in Sicily), then defected to Persia, then returned to Athens in triumph, then was exiled again when a subordinate lost a minor naval engagement (Thuc. 6.53-61; Xenophon, *Hell.* 1.4-5). His career is a case study in the impossibility of sustained strategic leadership within a political system that oscillates between enthusiasm and repudiation with no stable middle ground.

The Roman Comparison

The Roman Republic managed the problem somewhat better through institutional design. The Roman system of annual magistracies, senatorial oversight, and the triumph — a public ceremony that simultaneously honored and controlled the victorious general — created mechanisms for channeling military ambition while maintaining civilian control. The practice of *prorogatio imperii* (extension of command) allowed campaigns to continue beyond the normal one-year magistracy, providing operational continuity.

But the Roman system failed in the late Republic precisely because sustained military campaigns created personal loyalty between soldiers and commanders that overrode institutional allegiance. Marius' army reforms of 107 BCE — which opened military service to the propertyless and made soldiers dependent on their generals for land grants — transformed the Roman army from a citizen militia into a professional force loyal to its commander. The result, over the next seventy-five years, was a series of civil wars that destroyed the Republic: Marius against Sulla, Caesar against Pompey, Octavian against Antony.

The structural tension is clear: democracies struggle to sustain prolonged military campaigns because the political costs accumulate while the military benefits remain distant or abstract. The 25% approval rating for Operation Epic Fury on Day 1 — not after years of attrition, but at the moment of initiation — suggests that the American political system has reached a condition where this structural tension is acute from the outset rather than developing over time. The synthesis document's observation that "the gap between the public's preferences and the government's actions is wider than at any point since Vietnam — and it was established on Day 1" describes a crisis of democratic legitimacy that the Athenians would recognize instantly.

The House vote of 212-219 — a seven-vote margin sustaining the president's war-making authority — is a modern analogue of those moments in the Athenian assembly where a major strategic decision turned on a handful of votes, with consequences that reverberated for decades. When the Athenian assembly voted to destroy the rebellious city of Mytilene in 428 BCE, then reversed itself the following day by a narrow margin (Thuc. 3.36-49), Thucydides used the episode to illustrate the terrifying contingency of democratic decision-making about matters of war and peace.

VI. Lessons the Ancients Would Recognize

What Would Be Familiar

A Roman senator of the late Republic — say, Cicero, who lived through the era of Crassus' disaster at Carrhae and Caesar's civil war — would find much of 2026 grimly familiar. He would recognize the dynamic of a powerful state launching a preemptive war against a Persian adversary across the Euphrates. He would recognize the confidence that superior military technology could overcome geographic and demographic disadvantages. He would recognize the domestic political calculation: Crassus invaded Parthia not because it posed an imminent threat to Rome but because he needed military glory to match his rivals. He would recognize the expansion of war

aims — Crassus did not plan merely to punish Parthia but to conquer it, and his ambitions escalated as the campaign progressed.

Thucydides would recognize the information dynamics: the competing narratives, the fog of war, the way that each side's account of events serves its own political needs. He would recognize the alliance management problems — the synthesis document's description of a "coalition of the grudging" echoes his accounts of Athenian allies who contributed to the League out of fear rather than conviction and defected at the first opportunity.

Herodotus would recognize the cultural dimension: the Western assumption of superiority over a Persian civilization that is, by any objective measure, older and more continuous than the Western tradition itself. He would recognize the paradox of a democratic state fighting a war that its own citizens oppose, and he would note — with the ethnographic curiosity that was his signature — the strangeness of a political system that can launch a war without popular support and sustain it through institutional inertia.

What Would Shock Them

The scale and velocity would astonish any ancient observer. The Peloponnesian War lasted twenty-seven years; the Iran-Iraq War lasted eight; the 2026 conflict has produced more strategic consequences in six days than most ancient campaigns produced in a season. The ability to kill a head of state in the opening minutes of a war — before air defenses could even be activated — would strike an ancient observer as almost supernatural. Ancient wars opened with sacrifices, omens, and declarations; they did not begin with the instant death of the opposing sovereign.

The economic interconnection would be incomprehensible. The concept of a selective closure of the Strait of Hormuz — in which ships from one great power pass safely while others are frozen — would be recognizable in principle (the Athenians controlled the grain routes through the Hellespont), but the scale and sophistication of the mechanism would require extensive explanation. That the destruction of invisible digital infrastructure ("cloud data centers") in the Gulf could disrupt banking systems across continents would seem like sorcery.

Most profoundly, an ancient observer would be shocked by the gap between military capability and political legitimacy. Athens, for all its democratic dysfunction, never launched a major campaign that only a quarter of its citizens supported — the Sicilian Expedition was wildly popular at its inception. Rome's late Republican wars were driven by ambitious generals, but those generals commanded genuine loyalty from their soldiers. The 2026 configuration — overwhelming military power deployed with minimal democratic mandate — would strike the ancients as a novel form of tyranny, all the more alarming for being cloaked in democratic forms.

Thucydides, in his account of the revolution at Corcyra, described how "words changed their ordinary meaning and took that which was now given them" (3.82.4) — a passage that has resonated with every generation of readers because it describes the corruption of political language in times of crisis. He would recognize, in the rhetoric of 2026 — "immunity or absolutely guaranteed death," the demand to appoint a foreign leader, the framing of regime change as counterproliferation — the same process he documented in the fifth century BCE: the use of euphemism and redefinition to obscure the exercise of naked power.

Conclusion: The Persian Question Has No Military Answer

The classical record converges on a single conclusion that no amount of contemporary technological superiority can override: **the Persian question has never been resolved by military**

force.

Alexander conquered the Achaemenid Empire and died at thirty-two, his empire fragmenting before his body was cold. Rome fought Persia for seven centuries and never established a stable eastern frontier. The Arab conquest imposed a new religion but could not erase Persian cultural identity. The Mongols devastated the land and were absorbed by the civilization they destroyed. The United States, in 2026, has achieved extraordinary tactical results — and is discovering, as every Western power before it has discovered, that Persia is not a problem to be solved but a reality to be managed.

Thucydides began his history by observing that he wrote it "in the belief that it would be a great war, and more worthy of relation than any that had preceded it" (1.1). He wrote for the future, believing that human nature being what it is, similar events would recur "at some time or other and in much the same ways" (1.22.4). Twenty-five centuries later, his confidence in the recurrence of these patterns appears fully vindicated.

The war of 2026, like the wars that preceded it across this same geography, will eventually end — not because one side achieves its maximum objectives, but because the costs of continuation exceed the benefits of persistence for all parties. This, too, is a classical lesson. The Peloponnesian War ended not in Spartan triumph but in the exhaustion of all parties. The Roman-Parthian confrontation ended not in Roman victory but in the mutual destruction wrought by a third force. The Iran-Iraq War ended not in victory for either side but in the acceptance, by Ayatollah Khomeini, of a ceasefire he compared to "drinking poison."

The ancients would counsel patience — not because patience is a virtue, but because it is a recognition of reality. They would counsel humility — not as a moral posture, but as a strategic assessment based on the accumulated evidence of twenty-five centuries of Western encounters with Persian civilization. And they would counsel attention to the home front — because the wars that destroy great powers are not the wars they lose abroad but the wars that corrode their institutions at home.

This is the lesson of Athens after Sicily. This is the lesson of Rome after the Parthian campaigns drained the treasury and empowered the generals who destroyed the Republic. This is the lesson that Thucydides embedded in every page of his unfinished masterwork: the greatest danger to a powerful state is not the enemy without, but the *hubris* within.

The author wishes to acknowledge that classical parallels are illuminating but not deterministic. History does not repeat; it rhymes, as the saying goes. But some rhymes are so persistent, across so many centuries and so many configurations of power, that to ignore them is itself an act of hubris.

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Chapter 3

Democratic Decline: Weimar Echoes and Oligarchic Drift

An Essay for the Historical Context Roundtable on the US-Iran War of 2026

March 6, 2026

I. The Global Right-Wing Turn in Historical Context

There is a temptation, when democracies begin to fail, to treat each failure as sui generis — a product of local grievances, particular demagogues, unique circumstances. This is how the interwar generation understood what was happening to them, too. Mussolini was an Italian problem. Pilsudski was a Polish one. The NSDAP was a German pathology rooted in Versailles humiliation. It was only afterward — after the camps, after the ruins — that historians recognized the pattern: a global wave of democratic collapse driven by structural forces that transcended any single nation.

We are living through the second such wave, and we have less excuse for failing to recognize it.

The data are unambiguous. The V-Dem Institute's 2025 Democracy Report — titled, with a precision that now reads as prophecy, *25 Years of Autocratization: Democracy Trumped?* — documented 45 countries undergoing autocratization in 2024, up from twelve just twenty years prior. For the first time since the early 2000s, autocracies outnumber democracies worldwide. The "third wave of democratization" that Samuel Huntington celebrated in 1991 has not merely stalled; it has reversed. The institute identified the United States as undergoing "the fastest evolving episode of autocratization the USA has been through in modern history" — a judgment rendered *before* the bombs fell on Tehran.

The roster of the rightward turn reads like a geopolitical roll call. Viktor Orbán in Hungary since 2010, systematically dismantling judicial independence, press freedom, and electoral fairness while remaining inside the European Union — proving that democratic backsliding could proceed within liberal institutional frameworks rather than against them. Narendra Modi in India, presiding over the democratic degradation of the world's largest democracy through Hindu nationalist mobilization, institutional capture, and the systematic marginalization of Muslim citizens. The Brexit referendum of 2016, which married nativist sentiment to economic grievance in the world's oldest parliamentary democracy. Jair Bolsonaro in Brazil, who attempted what Trump later achieved more gradually: the conversion of populist energy into institutional subversion. Giorgia Meloni in Italy, the first post-fascist prime minister of a G7 nation, whose Brothers of Italy descends directly from the Movimento Sociale Italiano, itself the successor to Mussolini's Republican Fascist Party. Javier Milei in Argentina, the libertarian-authoritarian hybrid whose chainsaw politics represented the economic desperation of a continent. And Trump — first in 2016, then again in 2024, each iteration more radical, more openly contemptuous of constitutional restraint, more willing to test the tensile strength of institutions that had been assumed to be load-bearing.

The 1920s-1930s parallel is imperfect but instructive. Then as now, the democratic recession followed a period of rapid globalization and its discontents. Then as now, a catastrophic economic

shock (1929; 2008) delegitimized ruling elites and created mass constituencies for radical alternatives. Then as now, new communications technologies (radio; social media) enabled demagogues to bypass institutional gatekeepers and speak directly to mass audiences. Then as now, liberal internationalist institutions (the League of Nations; the post-1945 rules-based order) proved unable to constrain the states they were designed to govern. And then as now, the democracies that survived did so not because their institutions were inherently resilient, but because specific political actors made specific choices to defend them — choices that were never inevitable and that, in many countries, were never made.

The crucial difference is speed. The interwar collapse took roughly fifteen years, from the March on Rome in 1922 to the Anschluss in 1938. The current wave has compressed that timeline. Hungary went from liberal democracy to what Orbán himself calls "illiberal democracy" in a single decade. The United States moved from the norms-testing of Trump's first term to the constitutional crisis of the Iran war in under two years of the second.

And here is where the war fits the pattern with terrible precision. Democracies in crisis have historically launched foreign adventures for domestic reasons. Wilhelmine Germany's naval buildup and colonial ambitions were inseparable from Bismarck's and then Wilhelm's management of domestic social tensions. Argentina's junta invaded the Falklands in 1982 as the economy collapsed and domestic opposition mounted. Russia's annexation of Crimea in 2014 followed the Maidan revolution and served to reconsolidate domestic support. The mechanism is not mysterious: external conflict creates rally effects, justifies emergency powers, delegitimizes domestic opposition as disloyal, and redirects public attention from governance failures to patriotic fervor.

Operation Epic Fury was launched by an administration facing historically low approval ratings, an "affordability crisis" its own supporters identified as their primary concern, and a Department of Homeland Security in its third week of shutdown. The war's timing — following the June 2025 Israel-Iran war that had already tested and validated the operational concept — suggests not spontaneous response to imminent threat but calculated escalation toward a predetermined objective. Trump's demand, six days into the campaign, to be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader is not the rhetoric of defensive counterproliferation. It is the rhetoric of imperial prerogative.

But here is what makes 2026 genuinely novel, and genuinely terrifying: the rally didn't come. Every prior foreign adventure by a democracy in crisis produced at least a temporary surge of patriotic support. Even Iraq 2003, launched on fabricated intelligence, commanded 76% initial approval. Operation Epic Fury sits at 25-27% — the lowest initial support for any major American military operation in recorded polling history. The democracy-in-crisis launched its foreign adventure, and the public refused to play its assigned role in the script.

This is not a minor data point. It represents the failure of a mechanism that has operated reliably for at least two centuries. And its failure raises a question that should keep every democratic theorist awake: What does a government do when it can no longer rally its people? History suggests two answers: it either retreats, or it stops needing their consent.

II. Weimar Lessons: The Mechanisms of Democratic Erosion

The Weimar Republic did not die on January 30, 1933, when Hindenburg appointed Hitler chancellor. It died incrementally, through a series of constitutional improvisations that each seemed defensible in isolation and proved catastrophic in accumulation. The instrument of death was Article 48 of the Weimar Constitution — the emergency powers provision that allowed the president to "take measures necessary for the restoration of law and order" when "public safety

and order are seriously disturbed or endangered." Between 1930 and 1933, Heinrich Brüning, Franz von Papen, and Kurt von Schleicher governed almost entirely through emergency decrees, bypassing the Reichstag. By the time Hitler took office, parliamentary governance had already been suspended for three years. The Nazis did not destroy the Weimar Republic; they moved into a building whose foundations had already been removed.

The parallel to the American war powers crisis is not exact — historical parallels never are — but the structural homology is striking. The US Constitution vests the power to declare war in Congress. Article I, Section 8 is unambiguous. Yet since 1945, presidents have initiated military operations of increasing scale and duration without congressional declarations. The Korean War, the Vietnam War (authorized by the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution, passed under fraudulent pretenses), the invasions of Grenada and Panama, the bombing of Serbia, the intervention in Libya — each established a precedent that the next president could cite. The War Powers Resolution of 1973, passed over Nixon's veto in the aftermath of Vietnam, was designed to reassert congressional authority. It has never once forced the withdrawal of American forces from a conflict.

On March 4-5, 2026, both chambers of Congress voted on War Powers challenges to Operation Epic Fury. The Senate rejected the resolution 47-53. The House defeated it 212-219 — a margin of seven votes. Only two Republicans, Thomas Massie and Warren Davidson, voted to constrain the president's authority. Every other Republican member chose partisan loyalty over constitutional prerogative. The mechanism that Article I was designed to provide — legislative deliberation over the most consequential decision a republic can make — was tested and found wanting.

The Weimar analogy illuminates the specific pathology at work. Article 48 was not a bug in the Weimar Constitution; it was a feature, designed to enable emergency governance in a new and fragile democracy. Its framers — Hugo Preuß chief among them — intended it as a temporary measure, bounded by presidential judgment and parliamentary review. What they did not anticipate was that the emergency would become permanent, that the exception would become the rule, and that the Reichstag, rather than fighting for its authority, would acquiesce in its own marginalization.

This is precisely what has happened to American war powers. The "emergency" of presidential military authority, originally justified by the nuclear age's demand for rapid response, has been normalized into a standing prerogative. Each president has pushed the boundary further. Obama intervened in Libya without even the fig leaf of a congressional authorization. Trump ordered the assassination of Qassem Soleimani in January 2020 without congressional notification. Now Trump has launched the largest American military operation since Iraq — a regime-change war against a sovereign state — and Congress has ratified it after the fact through the negative act of failing to stop it.

The German constitutional theorist Carl Schmitt argued that "sovereign is he who decides on the exception." Schmitt meant this descriptively, but it has functioned prescriptively: the power to declare emergencies is the power to rule. When Congress failed to invoke the War Powers Resolution — when it had the opportunity to reclaim its constitutional authority and chose not to — it conceded Schmitt's point. The president is sovereign because the president decides what constitutes an emergency, and no other institution will say otherwise.

There is a deeper mechanism at work, one that the Weimar scholars identified but that has received insufficient attention in the American context: **legislative abdication as a rational strategy for individual legislators.** Weimar parliamentarians who supported Brüning's emergency decrees did so not because they believed in executive supremacy but because they feared the political consequences of taking responsibility for governance during a crisis. If the

Reichstag voted on austerity measures, individual members would be held accountable. If the president decreed them, members could distance themselves from the outcomes.

The identical logic operates in the American war powers context. A vote to authorize war creates accountability. A vote to stop a war already in progress creates political risk — the accusation of "not supporting the troops," of being "soft on Iran," of undermining national security. The path of least resistance for any individual legislator is to let the president act and avoid the vote entirely. The War Powers Resolution's 60-day clock, which expires in late April, creates a future confrontation. But history suggests that when the clock runs, Congress will find a reason not to act — just as the Reichstag found reasons to extend Article 48 authority again and again until there was no authority left to extend.

The erosion of norms accelerates the process. Trump's rhetoric — "I have to be involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader, "immunity or absolutely guaranteed death" — is not merely bellicose. It is the language of a sovereign who recognizes no constraint. The comparison to Venezuela, the demand for personal involvement in another country's governance — these are not the statements of a president operating within constitutional limits. They are the statements of what the framers feared most: an executive who has absorbed the war power entirely and treats it as personal prerogative.

Hannah Arendt observed that totalitarianism does not begin with concentration camps. It begins with the destruction of the space between citizens in which political action becomes possible. The American constitutional system created that space through the separation of powers — the requirement that war, the gravest act of state, must be a shared decision between the executive and the legislature. When that space collapses, when war becomes a unilateral executive act that the legislature can only ratify or impotently protest, the constitutional structure retains its form while losing its substance. The building still stands. The foundations are gone.

III. The Oligarchic Turn

In January 1961, Dwight Eisenhower — a five-star general who had commanded the largest amphibious invasion in human history — used his farewell address to warn against "the acquisition of unwarranted influence, whether sought or unsought, by the military-industrial complex." The warning was prophetic, but it was also incomplete. Eisenhower could not have anticipated the fusion of military-industrial power with the concentrated wealth of the technology sector, creating an oligarchic formation without precedent in American history.

The numbers tell part of the story. In 2025, the three wealthiest Americans — Elon Musk, Jeff Bezos, and Mark Zuckerberg — controlled more wealth than the bottom 50% of the American population combined. The top 0.1% of households held more wealth than the bottom 80%. The Gini coefficient of the United States had reached levels not seen since the original Gilded Age of the 1890s. But wealth concentration alone does not produce oligarchy. What produces oligarchy is the conversion of economic power into political power — the moment when wealth stops buying influence and starts buying governance.

That moment arrived. Musk's installation at the head of a government efficiency operation with authority to reshape federal agencies was not lobbying. It was not even the revolving door between industry and government. It was the direct exercise of governing power by a private citizen whose wealth exceeds the GDP of most nations. The tech billionaire class's attendance at Trump's second inauguration — sitting in positions of honor that had traditionally been reserved for elected officials and dignitaries — was a visual text that required no interpretation.

The relationship between oligarchy and war-making is ancient and well-documented. Thucydides recorded how Athenian commercial interests drove the Sicilian Expedition — the catastrophic military adventure that destroyed Athenian democracy. The Venetian Republic's wars were inseparable from the commercial interests of its merchant oligarchy. The British East India Company maintained its own army and conducted its own foreign policy. The American entry into World War I was shaped, as the Nye Committee documented in 1934-1936, by the financial interests of banks that had extended enormous loans to the Allied powers.

In the current conflict, the military-industrial-technology complex operates through several channels. Defense contractors — Lockheed Martin, Raytheon (now RTX), Northrop Grumman — see their stock prices surge with every missile fired. The cost-exchange equation of the Iran war is, from their perspective, not a problem but a business model: each $50,000 Iranian drone that forces the expenditure of a $5-15 million interceptor represents not waste but demand. The Anthropic-Pentagon dispute over AI weapons use — in which the president ordered federal agencies to phase out the technology of a company that drew ethical lines on military applications — demonstrates how the war economy punishes ethical restraint and rewards complicity. The destruction of AWS data centers in the UAE, far from discouraging cloud investment in conflict zones, will drive demand for hardened, militarized cloud infrastructure — a new market measured in tens of billions.

The historical parallel that illuminates most sharply is not the Gilded Age but the late Roman Republic. In the decades before Caesar, the Roman political system was formally democratic — assemblies voted, tribunes exercised veto power, magistrates were elected. But the reality was oligarchic: a small number of wealthy families controlled the Senate, military commands went to political allies, and the spoils of conquest were distributed through patronage networks. The formal mechanisms of republican government continued to function, but they had been hollowed out by wealth concentration that made genuine democratic deliberation impossible. The Republic did not fall to a foreign enemy. It fell because the oligarchy's internal competition escalated from political maneuvering to civil war, and the institutions that should have mediated that competition had been too thoroughly captured to do so.

Yale's research on democratic backsliding, presented at ISPS in 2025, demonstrated empirically what historians have long observed: income inequality increases political polarization, and polarization increases the likelihood of democratic breakdown. The mechanism is straightforward. When economic gains concentrate at the top, the wealthy develop interests that diverge from those of the majority. To protect those interests in a formally democratic system, they must either persuade the majority (increasingly difficult as inequality becomes visible) or capture the institutions that translate majority preferences into policy. Institutional capture — through campaign finance, regulatory revolving doors, media ownership, and direct participation in governance — is the rational strategy of an oligarchy operating within democratic forms.

The Iran war is, among other things, a product of this institutional capture. The 25% of Americans who support it are not the 0.1% who profit from it. The 75% who oppose it lack the institutional channels to translate their opposition into policy restraint. Congress — the institution designed to represent majority preferences on questions of war and peace — voted along lines determined not by constituent opinion but by partisan loyalty, which is itself shaped by donor networks, media ecosystems, and the career incentives of professional politicians. The oligarchic turn does not require a conspiracy. It requires only that the institutions designed to check concentrated power be gradually, incrementally, rationally captured by that power.

IV. When Democracies Go to War Without Consent

The 25-27% approval figure for Operation Epic Fury is not merely low. It is historically anomalous in a way that demands explanation.

Every major American military operation since scientific polling began has generated a "rally-around-the-flag" effect. Pearl Harbor produced near-universal support. Korea began at 66% approval before declining. The Gulf of Tonkin Resolution passed 88-2 in the Senate and 416-0 in the House; initial Vietnam support exceeded 60%. The first Gulf War commanded 80%+ approval. Even Iraq 2003 — launched on intelligence that many suspected was fabricated, against an enemy that had not attacked the United States, in defiance of the UN Security Council — achieved 76% initial support.

The rally effect has been one of the most robust findings in political science. John Mueller's seminal 1970 work established the pattern; subsequent research by Matthew Baum, Tim Groeling, and others refined it. The mechanism operates through several channels: patriotic identification, threat perception, media deference to executive framing, the desire for national unity in crisis, and the information asymmetry that favors the government in the early stages of conflict. Rally effects are temporary — Vietnam support eroded to 28% by 1971; Iraq fell below 40% by 2005 — but they are, or were, reliable.

The absence of any rally effect for the Iran war breaks the pattern. Understanding why requires understanding what has changed in the relationship between democratic publics and their governments.

The first change is the post-Iraq trust deficit. The Iraq war's fraudulent WMD rationale did not merely discredit a specific policy; it damaged the epistemic authority of the executive branch on questions of war and peace. When the Trump administration cites Iran's nuclear program as justification for preemptive strikes, the public hears an echo of Colin Powell at the UN. Trust, once shattered, does not regenerate within a generation. The boy who cried wolf does not get believed the third time, even if there is a wolf.

The second change is partisan sorting. In the mid-twentieth century, foreign policy retained bipartisan character; wars were national undertakings that transcended party. That era is over. In a political environment where partisan identity determines positions on virtually every issue, a war launched by a Republican president with no Democratic support is, by definition, a partisan project. The pool of persuadable citizens that could generate a 30-point rally effect has shrunk to near zero.

The third change is the information environment, which I address separately below.

The fourth change is the most fundamental: the "peace president" problem. Trump campaigned explicitly as an anti-interventionist. His base — the populist coalition of economically anxious voters who rejected the bipartisan foreign policy consensus — supported him precisely because he promised to end America's "forever wars." Operation Epic Fury is the ultimate betrayal of that promise. When 63% of voters cite gas prices as their primary concern about the war, they are expressing not just economic anxiety but the specific grievance of voters who chose a leader to prioritize domestic welfare and found themselves funding another Middle Eastern war.

The historical precedents for democracies fighting wars their publics oppose from the outset are sparse and instructive. The closest is the Boer War (1899-1902), which divided British public opinion from the beginning and produced the term "pro-Boer" as an epithet for dissenters. The Liberal opposition, much of the press, and significant segments of the public opposed the war on both moral and practical grounds. The result was not immediate policy change — the war continued for three years — but a fundamental realignment of British politics. The Liberal

landslide of 1906 was, in substantial part, a delayed referendum on the Boer War and the Conservative government that had prosecuted it.

The more troubling precedent is France during the Algerian War (1954-1962). The war was never popular with metropolitan French opinion; it was sustained by a combination of military momentum, colonial-lobby pressure, settler political power, and the institutional inertia of a state apparatus committed to *l'Algérie française*. The disconnect between public opinion and state action produced the crisis of the Fourth Republic, a military coup attempt, de Gaulle's return to power, and ultimately the creation of the Fifth Republic — a more centralized, executive-heavy constitutional order designed precisely to insulate presidential authority from legislative and popular constraint. The Algerian War ended, but French democracy was permanently restructured in a more authoritarian direction.

This is the pattern that should concern us most. When a democratic state fights a war its public opposes, the resolution is rarely that the public's preferences prevail in real time. More commonly, the disconnect between popular will and state action is resolved either by the eventual exhaustion of the war effort (Vietnam, where it took seven years of declining support to produce withdrawal) or by the restructuring of democratic institutions to reduce popular influence over security policy (France's Fifth Republic). The first outcome requires time and sustained political mobilization. The second is the more permanent danger — and it is the direction in which the American constitutional system is already moving.

V. The Information Environment and Democratic Deliberation

The relationship between communications technology and democratic governance is the great undertheorized variable in the study of war and democracy. Jürgen Habermas argued that the bourgeois public sphere — the space of rational deliberation among citizens — emerged from the technology of print: newspapers, pamphlets, coffeehouses where printed matter was discussed. This public sphere was the essential precondition for democratic governance, because democracy requires not merely voting but deliberation — the formation of considered public judgment through the exchange of information and argument.

Every subsequent communications revolution has reshaped this public sphere, with consequences for democratic war-making. Radio enabled Roosevelt's fireside chats, which built support for intervention in World War II, but it also enabled Father Coughlin's proto-fascist broadcasts and Goebbels's propaganda machine. Television brought Vietnam into American living rooms — the "living room war" that Walter Cronkite's 1968 broadcast exemplified — and made it impossible to sustain the gap between official optimism and battlefield reality. Cable news created the 24-hour information cycle that shaped public perception of the Gulf War and Iraq.

The social media revolution of the 2010s did something qualitatively different: it destroyed the possibility of a shared information environment. Previous communications technologies, however they distorted reality, at least created a common frame of reference — Americans watching Cronkite or reading the *New York Times* disagreed about the meaning of events but agreed on what events had occurred. Social media shattered that shared reality into algorithmically curated information silos, each with its own facts, its own authorities, its own narrative of events.

For democratic war-making, the consequences are profound and contradictory. On one hand, the collapse of shared reality makes the *manufacture* of consent — the process Edward Herman and Noam Chomsky described in their analysis of media and propaganda — nearly impossible. In 2003, the Bush administration could construct a narrative of Iraqi WMD through a

compliant media ecosystem: embedded journalists, patriotic cable news coverage, the institutional authority of the Secretary of State at the UN. That infrastructure of narrative control no longer exists. In 2026, BBC Verify contradicts CENTCOM's ship-sinking claims within hours. Amnesty International verifies civilian casualty footage in real time. OSINT analysts on social media track military movements with commercial satellite imagery. The administration cannot manufacture consent because the information architecture that enabled consent-manufacturing has been destroyed.

On the other hand, the same fragmentation that prevents manufactured consent also prevents informed democratic deliberation. Citizens do not share a common set of facts from which to reason. Supporters of the war inhabit an information ecosystem in which Iran posed an imminent nuclear threat and the strikes are a necessary defensive measure. Opponents inhabit one in which the war is an illegal act of aggression driven by domestic political calculation. Neither group encounters the other's evidence. The public sphere that Habermas described — the space of rational-critical debate among citizens — has been replaced by parallel universes of motivated reasoning.

The specific innovation of the 2026 information environment is real-time OSINT documentation of civilian casualties. The Minab school strike — 175 children killed on Day 1 — was documented by six verified videos (Amnesty International), satellite imagery (BBC Verify), and WHO confirmation of 13 hospital strikes, all within 48 hours. This information reached global audiences unfiltered by military public affairs offices, government spokespeople, or editorial gatekeeping.

The political significance is difficult to overstate. In every prior American war, the government controlled the initial narrative. Civilian casualties were acknowledged gradually, retrospectively, often years after the fact. The Iraq Body Count project documented Iraqi civilian deaths over years; the Lancet studies that estimated 600,000+ excess deaths were published in 2006, three years after the invasion. The time lag between the act and its documentation created political space for the war's advocates.

That space no longer exists. When 175 dead children are documented within hours, the political calculus changes fundamentally. The moral weight of civilian casualties lands on public opinion *during the rally window* rather than after it. This is one reason the rally never came: the public was confronted with the war's human costs before the patriotic narrative could take hold. Democratic legitimacy depends on the capacity of the public to understand and accept the consequences of state action. When those consequences are broadcast in real time to a public that never consented, the gap between democratic form and democratic substance becomes a chasm.

VI. European Fragmentation and Alliance Dissolution

The Concert of Europe — the system of great-power cooperation established at the Congress of Vienna in 1815 — maintained relative peace in Europe for a century. Its collapse was gradual, driven by the unification of Germany, the rigidification of alliance systems, the arms race, and the inability of existing diplomatic mechanisms to manage crises among increasingly antagonistic blocs. When the system finally failed in July 1914, a regional dispute between Austria-Hungary and Serbia escalated into a world war because alliance commitments transformed local conflicts into systemic ones.

NATO, the post-1945 alliance system that replaced the Concert of Europe's informal arrangements with a formal treaty structure, is now experiencing its own crisis of coherence — and the Iran war is both symptom and accelerant.

The fractures are visible in the coalition's structure. The United Kingdom has crossed from defensive positioning to active co-belligerency by confirming Akrotiri as a basing platform for American bomber operations — a decision that makes British territory a legitimate military target under international humanitarian law without a parliamentary vote authorizing such exposure. France has offered base access with "guarantees" that facilities will not be used for offensive operations — a legal fiction that satisfies neither international law nor domestic politics, but that allows Macron to maintain the appearance of allied solidarity without the substance of co-belligerency. Spain has refused to allow US bases on its territory for the campaign while simultaneously deploying a frigate to Cyprus — a gesture of European solidarity that carefully avoids material contribution to the war effort. The Netherlands, Italy, and Portugal have made contributions calibrated to demonstrate alliance reliability without incurring significant risk.

The most revealing fracture involves Turkey. When an Iranian missile aimed at "Greek Cyprus" deviated and struck Hatay province, Turkey had grounds to invoke Article 5 — the collective defense provision that is NATO's raison d'être. NATO Secretary General Rutte discussed the possible invocation. Pentagon spokesman Hegseth immediately denied its applicability. The message was unmistakable: Article 5 applies when American interests are served by its application, and not otherwise. For Turkey — which has spent decades balancing NATO membership against regional relationships — the lesson is that the alliance's security guarantee is conditional, political, and ultimately unreliable.

This selective application of alliance commitments mirrors the pre-1914 dynamic in which alliance obligations were simultaneously binding and ambiguous. Austria-Hungary expected German support under the Dual Alliance; Germany gave its "blank check." Russia expected French support under the Franco-Russian Alliance; France honored its commitment. Britain's obligations under the Entente Cordiale were less formal, and its entry into the war came later and for different reasons. The system's failure was not that alliances existed but that they were simultaneously rigid enough to transmit escalation and flexible enough to permit miscalculation.

NATO in 2026 exhibits the same pathology. The alliance is rigid enough that member states feel compelled to demonstrate solidarity — hence the British basing, the French base access, the pan-European naval deployments — but flexible enough that each member calibrates its contribution to minimize risk and maximize deniability. The result is not a coherent coalition but a collection of bilateral arrangements, each driven by domestic political calculation rather than strategic logic. Spain's refusal of bases alongside its deployment of a frigate is the perfect expression of this incoherence: solidarity in principle, distance in practice.

The European joint statement calling for "dialogue and diplomacy" while member states provide basing for bomber operations captures a deeper crisis. Europe cannot decide whether it is an American ally participating in a military campaign or an independent actor seeking diplomatic resolution. It is attempting to be both simultaneously, and the contradiction is unsustainable. As the war extends — and every indication suggests it will extend for months — European governments will face increasing pressure to choose. The history of alliance fragmentation during active conflict suggests that the longer the war lasts, the wider the fractures become.

VII. Where This Leads: Democratic Recovery or Democratic Failure

The most consequential question is not how this war ends but what it does to the democratic institutions that authorized — or failed to prevent — its beginning.

History offers two models of post-crisis democratic recovery. The first is the post-Vietnam/post-Watergate reform era. The combined trauma of an illegal war, a criminal presidency, and do-

mestic surveillance abuses produced a remarkable burst of institutional reform: the War Powers Resolution (1973), the Congressional Budget Act (1974), the Foreign Intelligence Surveillance Act (1978), the Ethics in Government Act (1978), the creation of the Senate and House Intelligence Committees. These reforms were imperfect — the War Powers Resolution, as we have seen, has never successfully constrained a president — but they represented a genuine attempt to reassert democratic control over executive power.

The second model is institutional decay. The Roman Republic's crisis of the late second and first centuries BCE produced not reform but the progressive normalization of extra-constitutional action. Sulla's march on Rome in 88 BCE was shocking; Caesar's crossing of the Rubicon in 49 BCE was merely the logical conclusion of precedents Sulla had established. Each violation of republican norms made the next violation more conceivable. The Republic's formal institutions continued to exist under Augustus, but they had been emptied of meaning — the Senate met, consuls were elected, but power resided in the princeps.

Which model applies to the United States of 2026?

The conditions for a post-Vietnam-style reform are present: a deeply unpopular war, visible institutional failures, public outrage, and an approaching electoral test (the 2026 midterms). If the war produces the kind of political backlash that Vietnam and Iraq eventually generated — and the absence of any rally effect suggests the backlash may come faster — the midterms could produce a Congress willing to reassert its constitutional authority. The 60-day War Powers clock, expiring in late April, creates a specific institutional moment for confrontation.

But the conditions for institutional decay are also present — and they may be stronger. The failed War Powers votes have established a precedent that will be cited by every future president: Congress had the opportunity to constrain the executive and chose not to. The oligarchic capture of political institutions makes reform dependent on the willingness of officeholders whose careers depend on the donors who profit from the status quo. The information environment prevents the formation of the kind of broad, bipartisan consensus that powered the post-Watergate reforms. And the speed of events — the compression of what took years during Vietnam into days during the Iran war — may outpace the capacity of democratic institutions to respond.

The French precedent haunts. The Algerian War produced not democratic renewal but the Fifth Republic — a constitutional order designed to concentrate power in the presidency, insulate security policy from parliamentary interference, and ensure that the military and the executive could prosecute wars without the inconvenience of democratic deliberation. De Gaulle's constitution was, in many ways, the institutional expression of the lesson France's elite drew from Algeria: that democracy is too slow, too fractious, too susceptible to public emotion to manage the serious business of war and peace.

If the American constitutional system follows this trajectory — if the post-2026 settlement is not reform but consolidation of executive war powers — the consequences extend far beyond the United States. American democratic decline does not occur in isolation. The V-Dem data demonstrate that autocratization is contagious: when powerful democracies weaken, the effect cascades through the international system, emboldening autocrats and demoralizing democrats worldwide. The United States has served, however imperfectly and hypocritically, as a reference point for democratic governance. When the reference point degrades, the entire system degrades with it.

There is a third possibility, one that the historical record supports but that is rarely discussed in the literature on democratic decline: **that the crisis produces not reform or decay but a prolonged period of institutional ambiguity** — a gray zone in which democratic forms persist, elections are held, courts rule, and legislatures convene, but the substance of democratic governance — popular sovereignty, government by consent, the rule of law — is pro-

gressively hollowed out. This is Orbán's Hungary, Erdoğan's Turkey, and increasingly Modi's India: not dictatorship but democracy without democrats, constitutionalism without constitutional restraint, elections without meaningful choice.

The United States may already be in this gray zone. A war launched without consent, sustained without approval, and unchecked by the legislature — while elections proceed on schedule and courts remain nominally independent — is precisely the kind of institutional arrangement that characterizes competitive authoritarianism. The question is not whether the Republic will fall with a dramatic collapse. The question is whether it has already fallen, quietly, through the accumulation of precedents and the abdication of the institutions designed to prevent precisely this outcome.

Arendt wrote in *The Origins of Totalitarianism* that the most dangerous moment for a society is not when it is confronted by evil but when it loses the capacity to recognize evil as evil — when the monstrous becomes normal, when the exception becomes the rule, when citizens lose the ability to be shocked. The Minab school strike killed 175 children. Six days later, the news cycle has moved on. The war continues. Congress has voted to let it continue. The president demands to choose Iran's next leader. And 75% of Americans oppose what is being done in their name, but the machinery of democratic self-governance has no mechanism to translate that opposition into restraint.

This is where the Weimar parallel reaches its sharpest point. The Weimar Republic's citizens did not lack the desire for democracy. They lacked the institutions capable of defending democracy against those who used democratic forms to undermine democratic substance. The question facing the American Republic is whether its institutions retain that capacity — or whether, like Weimar's, they will be discovered to have been already empty when the crisis demanded they bear weight.

The answer to that question will not be determined by this war alone. But it will be shaped, decisively, by how this war ends, what accountability follows, and whether the democratic public — the 75% who never consented — finds a way to make their dissent consequential. History does not determine outcomes. But it illuminates the stakes. And the stakes, in March 2026, could not be higher.

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Chapter 4

American Wars: The Long Shadow of Saigon

By [Historian, US Foreign Policy & Vietnam]

Contributed to the Academic Roundtable on the Historical Context of the US-Iran War of 2026

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Introduction

On the evening of February 28, 2026, the United States launched Operation Epic Fury — the largest American military operation since the invasion of Iraq in March 2003. Within minutes, precision strikes killed Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei before Iranian air defenses could respond. Within hours, strikes had expanded across all twenty-four Iranian provinces. Within six days, the stated objective had expanded from counterproliferation to regime change, with President Trump demanding to be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader. The war commands the support of roughly one in four Americans — the lowest initial approval for any major US military operation in the history of modern polling.

None of this is unprecedented. Not the preemptive strike launched without congressional authorization or UN mandate. Not the rapid escalation of war aims. Not the gap between tactical brilliance and strategic incoherence. Not the administration's insistence that military victory equates to political resolution. What is unprecedented is the speed at which patterns that took years to unfold in Vietnam and months in Iraq have manifested in days.

This essay examines what the history of American war-making — specifically Vietnam (1955–1975), Iraq (2003–2011), and Afghanistan (2001–2021) — can tell us about the trajectory, logic, and likely consequences of the US-Iran War. It argues that Operation Epic Fury represents not a departure from the pattern of American wars since 1945, but its most compressed and accelerated expression. The structural dynamics that produced quagmire in Southeast Asia, strategic failure in Mesopotamia, and twenty years of futility in the Hindu Kush are already visible in the Iran campaign — not as distant analogies, but as recurring features of how the United States initiates, escalates, justifies, and ultimately fails to conclude its wars.

I. The Vietnam Parallel: What Maps and What Doesn't

The invocation of Vietnam in American war discourse has become so reflexive as to be almost meaningless. Every conflict since 1975 has been called "another Vietnam" by its opponents and declared categorically unlike Vietnam by its proponents. Serious historical analysis requires more precision.

What maps. The most direct parallel between Vietnam and Iran 2026 is the relationship between pretext and reality. On August 4, 1964, President Lyndon Johnson told the American people that North Vietnamese torpedo boats had launched an "unprovoked" attack on the USS *Maddox* in the Gulf of Tonkin. The Senate passed the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution 88-2 three days later, granting Johnson effectively unlimited authority to use military force in Southeast Asia.

We now know, from declassified NSA documents and the testimony of participants, that the August 4 incident almost certainly did not occur — that sonar operators were tracking phantom contacts in heavy seas, that Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara suppressed contradictory intelligence, and that the administration exploited ambiguous evidence to secure authorization for a war it had already decided to fight.

Operation Epic Fury dispensed with even this pretense. There was no precipitating attack on American forces or territory. The Pentagon, when pressed by Congress, acknowledged that Iran posed no imminent threat to the United States. The justification — counterproliferation, the destruction of Iran's missile and nuclear capabilities — rests on the doctrine of preemptive war, which the United States formally adopted in the 2002 National Security Strategy and first applied in Iraq. But where Johnson at least manufactured a casus belli and secured congressional authorization, the Iran campaign launched without either. The Gulf of Tonkin Resolution, for all its dishonesty, was a congressional act. The Iran war began, was challenged under the War Powers Resolution, and survived: the Senate voted 47-53 against constraining the president; the House defeated its own resolution 212-219. Both chambers effectively ratified presidential war-making after the fact. The constitutional trajectory from Tonkin to Tehran is a trajectory of declining democratic constraint.

The escalation dynamics offer a second parallel, though the timescale is radically different. Vietnam's escalation was glacial by comparison. President Eisenhower sent the first military advisors in 1955. Kennedy expanded the advisory mission to 16,300 personnel by 1963. Johnson initiated sustained bombing (Operation Rolling Thunder) in March 1965 and committed ground combat troops that same month. By 1968, 536,100 American troops were deployed. The escalation from advisory mission to full-scale ground war took a decade. At each stage, the expansion of commitment was framed as a modest, necessary adjustment — what David Halberstam called the logic of "one more step."

In Iran, the escalation from counterproliferation to regime change took six days. On February 28, the stated objective was the destruction of Iran's missile and nuclear capabilities. By March 5, Trump was demanding a role in selecting Iran's next leader, comparing the situation to Venezuela, and calling the designated successor Mojtaba Khamenei "a lightweight." Defense Secretary Hegseth declared that American firepower was "about to surge dramatically" and that the campaign was "just getting started." The White House offered Iran's leadership a binary: "immunity" or "absolutely guaranteed death." The structural dynamic is identical — limited objectives giving way to maximalist aims — but the compression is extraordinary. What took Johnson three years (from Tonkin in August 1964 to the commitment of 500,000 troops by 1967) has taken Trump less than a week.

The "credibility" trap, which I will examine at greater length below, operates in both cases. Johnson's national security team — McGeorge Bundy, Dean Rusk, McNamara — consistently argued that American credibility as a superpower required demonstrating resolve in Vietnam. The domino theory provided the strategic rationale, but credibility provided the psychological one. As McNamara wrote in a 1965 memo to Johnson, 70% of the reason for fighting in Vietnam was "to avoid a humiliating US defeat (to our reputation as a guarantor)." The actual welfare of the South Vietnamese people accounted for roughly 10% of his calculus. In Iran, the credibility argument is already audible: Hegseth's language about the campaign being "just getting started," the refusal to acknowledge the CIA back-channel contact that Iran initiated on March 1, and the administration's systematic closure of diplomatic off-ramps all reflect the same logic. To negotiate now would be to admit that the killing of a head of state, 175 children at Minab, and the disruption of the global economy were undertaken for objectives that could have been achieved by other means.

What doesn't map. The differences are equally important. Vietnam was a ground war fought

by conscripts against a nationalist insurgency with deep popular support, operating on its own territory with sanctuary across an international border. Iran 2026 is a standoff air and missile campaign fought by an all-volunteer professional military against a state's conventional forces. There are no American ground troops in Iran and, as of Day 7, no indication that any will be deployed. The IRGC, whatever its domestic support, is not the Viet Cong — it is a state military apparatus, not a guerrilla movement rooted in peasant mobilization.

Vietnam's geography — triple-canopy jungle, a 17,000-mile coastline, porous borders — negated American technological superiority. Iran's geography is different but no less challenging: a country of 1.65 million square kilometers with mountainous terrain, 88 million people, and a military doctrine designed precisely for asymmetric resistance to American air power. The coalition has achieved "near-complete aerial superiority" over Iran, as IDF Chief Zamir declared on March 5. But aerial superiority over North Vietnam was never in question either. The United States dropped more bombs on Vietnam than all parties dropped in all theaters of World War II combined. It lost the war.

The most significant difference is the draft. The conscription system that fed the Vietnam War also generated its most powerful opposition. The universal vulnerability of military service — the knowledge that any American family's son could be sent to die in the Mekong Delta — created a constituency for opposition that cut across class, race, and region (though, as Christian Appy documented in *Working-Class War*, the burdens fell disproportionately on the poor). The all-volunteer force that fights in Iran insulates the majority of Americans from the personal consequences of war. This is not incidental; it is by design, a lesson the national security establishment drew explicitly from Vietnam.

II. Iraq 2003: The Middle Chapter

The US-Iran War cannot be understood without Iraq, and not merely as analogy. The 2003 invasion of Iraq created the material conditions for the 2026 war in ways that are causal, not merely parallel.

Begin with the doctrinal inheritance. The Bush administration's 2002 National Security Strategy formalized the doctrine of preemptive war — the claim that the United States could attack states that posed potential future threats, even absent imminent danger. This doctrine justified the invasion of Iraq on the basis of weapons of mass destruction that did not exist, intelligence that was manipulated (the "Curveball" source, the aluminum tubes, the yellowcake uranium from Niger), and a public case built on fear rather than evidence. Secretary of State Colin Powell's February 2003 presentation to the UN Security Council — which he later called a "blot" on his record — represents perhaps the most consequential act of manufactured intelligence in American diplomatic history.

Operation Epic Fury rests on the same doctrinal foundation. The Pentagon's admission to Congress that Iran posed no imminent threat is the 2026 equivalent of the missing WMDs. The difference is that the Bush administration at least attempted to construct an evidentiary case, however dishonest, and secured congressional authorization through the Authorization for Use of Military Force Against Iraq (October 2002). The Iran campaign skipped both steps. The doctrinal evolution from Iraq to Iran is not a departure from preemptive war doctrine but its logical terminus: if the president can attack a state that poses no imminent threat, the requirement for evidence or authorization becomes purely decorative.

The assumption that military victory produces political outcomes is the second inheritance. The "Mission Accomplished" banner aboard the USS *Abraham Lincoln* on May 1, 2003 — forty-

three days after the invasion began — has become shorthand for the delusion that toppling a regime constitutes winning a war. Baghdad fell on April 9. The insurgency began within weeks. The United States would fight in Iraq for eight more years, at a cost of 4,431 American dead, an estimated 150,000-600,000 Iraqi dead (depending on methodology), and $2 trillion in direct expenditure.

The Iran campaign is reproducing this assumption at accelerated speed. The killing of Khamenei, the destruction of 80% of air defenses, the 90% reduction in ballistic missile launches, the sinking of 30+ naval vessels — all of this represents extraordinary tactical achievement. IDF Chief Zamir's declaration of "near-complete aerial superiority" and the announcement of a "next phase" targeting underground sites and "regime foundations" mirrors the rhetoric of April 2003 with uncanny precision. But the question that Iraq should have taught us to ask — what happens the day after the shooting stops? — remains unanswered.

De-Ba'athification offers the most precise cautionary tale. When L. Paul Bremer issued Coalition Provisional Authority Orders 1 and 2 in May 2003 — dissolving the Iraqi military and banning Ba'ath Party members from government employment — he eliminated the administrative capacity of the Iraqi state at a stroke. An estimated 400,000 armed men were simultaneously unemployed. The insurgency that followed was, in significant part, a direct consequence of this decision. The Sunni officers and officials who had run Iraq's government and military became the cadre of first the Sunni insurgency and later the Islamic State.

Trump's demand to be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader, and the White House's call for IRGC members to "lay down arms" and diplomats to "seek asylum," reproduce the logic of de-Ba'athification with a state apparatus of 88 million people. The IRGC is not merely a military organization; it controls an estimated 20-40% of Iran's economy, manages vast construction and engineering enterprises, and employs millions directly and indirectly. Dismantling it would replicate the Iraqi catastrophe at a scale four times larger.

Most directly, Iraq created the conditions for 2026. The power vacuum left by the destruction of Saddam Hussein's regime empowered Iran as the dominant external actor in Iraqi politics. The sectarian civil war that followed the invasion drove Iraq's Shia majority toward Iranian patronage. The Islamic State, born from the remnants of de-Ba'athification, drew Iran's IRGC and its proxy network deeper into the region. The "Shia Crescent" that American strategists now cite as a threat is, in substantial part, an artifact of the 2003 invasion. We are, in a sense, bombing the consequences of our last bombing.

III. The Domestic Front: From Kent State to Austin

On May 4, 1970, Ohio National Guardsmen fired sixty-seven rounds in thirteen seconds at students protesting the expansion of the Vietnam War into Cambodia. Four students — Allison Krause, Jeffrey Miller, Sandra Scheuer, and William Schroeder — were killed. Nine were wounded. Scheuer and Schroeder were not even part of the protest; they were walking between classes. The Kent State massacre catalyzed the largest student strike in American history: over four million students at 450 universities walked out. One hundred thousand people marched on Washington. Construction workers in New York attacked the protesters with hard hats and wrenches while police watched.

The Vietnam-era antiwar movement was the most sustained and consequential domestic opposition to an American war since the Civil War. The October 15, 1969 Moratorium to End the War in Vietnam brought an estimated two million people into the streets across the country — the largest single-day demonstration in American history to that point. Draft resistance, which

began with individual acts of conscience (the burning of draft cards, the flight to Canada) and escalated to organized mass refusal, struck at the material foundation of the war effort. By 1969, the Selective Service System was processing 300,000 inductions per year; by 1972, the system was in crisis, with conviction rates for draft evasion plummeting as juries refused to convict.

The domestic opposition to the Iran war operates in a fundamentally different political and structural environment. The most obvious difference is the absence of conscription. The all-volunteer force, established in 1973 in direct response to Vietnam, was designed to decouple military service from civilian life and thereby reduce the political costs of war. It has succeeded. Six American servicemembers have been killed in Iran as of Day 7 — all in Kuwait, none in combat in Iran itself. The families of the dead are concentrated in the military communities of Iowa and Sacramento, not distributed across every congressional district in the country. The differential exposure to sacrifice that Appy documented in Vietnam — where working-class and minority communities bore disproportionate burdens — has been institutionalized into a system where the vast majority of Americans bear no burden at all.

And yet: 25% approval. The lowest initial support for any major American military operation in polling history. No rally-around-the-flag effect. Trump's overall approval at an all-time low of 44%. How do we explain mass opposition to a war that imposes almost no direct cost on the opposing public?

Three factors distinguish 2026 from both the Vietnam era and the early Iraq period. First, the post-Iraq trust deficit. The American public was lied to about weapons of mass destruction in 2003, and it knows it was lied to. When the Pentagon acknowledges that Iran posed no imminent threat — a concession extracted by congressional questioning, not volunteered — the public maps this onto the WMD template immediately. The credibility of preemptive war justifications has been permanently degraded by Iraq. Seventy-six percent of Americans supported the Iraq invasion in March 2003; by 2007, that figure had fallen below 30%. The Iran war starts where Iraq ended.

Second, the information environment. The Vietnam-era antiwar movement operated through teach-ins, underground newspapers, and network television coverage that, despite government pressure, eventually turned critical (Walter Cronkite's February 1968 editorial is the iconic moment). The Iraq war was fought in an era of embedded journalism and Fox News patriotism, where dissent could be marginalized as unpatriotic. The Iran war unfolds in an information ecosystem where BBC Verify contradicts CENTCOM claims within hours, where Amnesty International verifies the Minab school strike with satellite imagery and six independent videos, and where the gap between official narrative and observable reality is exposed in real time. The administration cannot manufacture consent because the infrastructure of consent-manufacturing — centralized media, information asymmetry, patriotic deference — no longer exists.

Third, the Austin shooting. On March 2, four days into the campaign, a man wearing Iranian flag imagery killed three people at a bar in Austin, Texas. The FBI opened a terrorism investigation. The incident immediately bifurcated the domestic political landscape: for the administration and its allies, it validated the securitization of dissent (Representative Scalise cited the FBI's elevated threat warning); for opponents, it validated the core antiwar claim that the war generates blowback. The cycle that took years during Vietnam — protest, radicalization, violence, repression, deeper polarization — has been compressed into days. Kent State occurred five years into major combat operations. Austin occurred four days in.

The all-volunteer force functions as what the political scientist Andrew Bacevich has called a "political insulator" — it allows wars to be fought without mobilizing the population, and therefore without creating the mass constituency for opposition that conscription generated in Vietnam. But the insulator has limits. It insulates against casualty-driven opposition; it does

not insulate against economic opposition. Sixty-three percent of voters are concerned about the gas price impacts of the Iran war. When costs are made explicit, support drops to 18%. The Strait of Hormuz's selective closure, the triple chokepoint crisis, and rising energy prices may accomplish what the absence of a draft prevents: they may make the war's costs visible and personal to Americans who have no family member in uniform.

IV. The Credibility Trap

In November 1967, General William Westmoreland returned from Vietnam to address the National Press Club in Washington. "We have reached an important point," he told the assembled reporters, "when the end begins to come into view." Two months later, on January 30, 1968, the Tet Offensive shattered this assessment. Eighty-four thousand Viet Cong and North Vietnamese troops attacked simultaneously across South Vietnam, penetrating the US Embassy compound in Saigon, seizing the imperial capital of Hu for twenty-five days, and demonstrating that the "light at the end of the tunnel" was, as Senator George Aiken quipped, an oncoming train.

Tet was a military defeat for the North Vietnamese — they suffered catastrophic casualties and failed to hold any major objective. But it was a strategic victory of the first order, because it revealed the unbridgeable gap between the official narrative of progress and the observable reality of a war that was, at best, stalemated. This gap — what journalists called the "credibility gap" — is the defining pathology of American wars.

The credibility trap operates through a specific mechanism. Once a war is initiated, the political costs of admitting failure exceed the political costs of continuing. Each additional commitment of blood and treasure raises the retrospective stakes: if we withdraw now, then the previous sacrifices were "in vain." This logic, which the economist would recognize as the sunk cost fallacy and the psychologist as escalation of commitment, has driven the persistence of every major American war since Korea.

In Vietnam, the trap operated for a decade. Johnson could not withdraw because withdrawal would mean that the 58,000 Americans who would eventually die had died for nothing. Nixon could not withdraw because withdrawal would damage American "credibility" — the belief among allies and adversaries that the United States would honor its commitments. Nixon's "peace with honor" formulation was itself a product of the credibility trap: the "honor" required continued fighting to produce conditions that looked, however implausibly, like something other than defeat. The result was four more years of war, an expansion into Cambodia and Laos, and a final withdrawal in 1975 that produced exactly the outcome Nixon had fought to prevent.

In Iraq, the trap was articulated most clearly by the "surge" debate of 2006-2007. By late 2006, the Iraq Study Group — a bipartisan commission chaired by James Baker and Lee Hamilton — concluded that the situation was "grave and deteriorating" and recommended a drawdown. Instead, President George W. Bush ordered a surge of 20,000 additional troops, justified explicitly in the language of credibility: "If we increase our support at this crucial moment, and help the Iraqis break the current cycle of violence, we can hasten the day our troops begin coming home." The surge produced a temporary reduction in violence but did not resolve any of the political conflicts that had generated the insurgency. The United States withdrew in 2011. The Islamic State seized Mosul in 2014. The sacrifices were, by any honest assessment, in vain.

In Afghanistan, the trap persisted for twenty years. The original objective — the destruction of al-Qaeda's safe haven — was substantially achieved by 2002. The war continued for nineteen more years because no president was willing to accept the political consequences of withdrawal. Obama surged to 100,000 troops in 2010 while simultaneously announcing a withdrawal timeline

— a contradiction that satisfied no one. Trump negotiated with the Taliban while maintaining the fiction that the Afghan government was viable. Biden finally withdrew in August 2021, producing the chaotic scenes at Kabul airport that the credibility trap had been designed to prevent.

The Iran war is six days old, and the trap is already forming. Hegseth's declaration that the campaign is "just getting started" and that the United States is prepared to "go far longer" than four to five weeks establishes the rhetorical framework. Trump's "I said Too Late!" — his rejection of the diplomatic overture Iran made through the CIA on March 1 — closes the off-ramp that might have prevented escalation. The White House's ultimatum of "immunity" or "absolutely guaranteed death" eliminates the middle ground where negotiations occur. Six American servicemembers are dead. One hundred seventy-five children are dead at Minab. A head of state has been assassinated. The Strait of Hormuz is functionally closed. To stop now would be to acknowledge that all of this was undertaken without adequate justification — that the Pentagon's own admission of "no imminent threat" means what it plainly says. The credibility trap does not require years to form. It requires only that the costs already incurred be large enough to make honesty politically unbearable.

V. War Aims Creep: The Structural Logic of Expansion

The pattern is so consistent across American wars as to constitute something close to a law: limited objectives expand to encompass regime change and political transformation. The expansion is not accidental. It is driven by structural incentives that are embedded in the American way of war.

Vietnam. The original objective was containment — preventing the fall of South Vietnam to communism as part of the broader Cold War strategy. By 1965, the objective had expanded to include the creation of a viable, democratic South Vietnamese state — a goal that required not merely military defense but political transformation of a society the United States barely understood. The failure to achieve this expanded objective produced further escalation, as military force was applied to problems that were fundamentally political. The strategic bombing campaigns — Rolling Thunder (1965-1968), Linebacker I and II (1972) — reflected the persistent American belief that sufficient application of firepower could compel political outcomes. It could not.

Iraq. The stated objective was the destruction of weapons of mass destruction. Within weeks of the invasion, the objective had expanded to include regime change (achieved with the fall of Baghdad), de-Ba'athification (CPA Orders 1 and 2), and the construction of a democratic Iraqi state (the Coalition Provisional Authority, the transitional government, the 2005 constitution and elections). Each expansion of objectives required deeper commitment and longer timelines. The original war plan envisioned a force drawdown to 30,000 troops by September 2003. Instead, troop levels increased to 170,000 by November 2007.

Iran 2026. On February 28, the objective was counterproliferation — the destruction of Iran's missile and nuclear capabilities. By March 5 — Day 6 — Trump demanded to be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader. The White House called on IRGC members to "lay down arms" and diplomats to "seek asylum." IDF Chief Zamir announced a "next phase" targeting "regime foundations." The progression from counterproliferation to regime change took six days. In Iraq, the equivalent progression took weeks. In Vietnam, it took years.

The structural incentives that drive this expansion are threefold. First, military success generates its own momentum. The destruction of Iran's air defenses, the killing of Khamenei,

the degradation of missile capabilities — each tactical success makes the next objective seem achievable. If we can destroy their air force, why not their nuclear program? If we can kill their leader, why not reshape their government? The logic of capability becomes the logic of obligation. Second, the domestic political incentive structure rewards escalation over de-escalation. A president who initiates a war and then accepts a limited outcome invites the charge of having "wasted" the sacrifice. A president who escalates can point to expanded objectives as evidence of ambition and resolve. Third, the military institutional culture rewards operational expansion. Every combatant command, every service branch, every weapons program has an interest in demonstrating its relevance through mission expansion.

The result is a ratchet that turns in only one direction. War aims expand because the political, institutional, and psychological incentives all favor expansion and none favor restraint.

VI. The Pentagon Papers Moment

In June 1971, *The New York Times* began publishing the Pentagon Papers — a 7,000-page classified study commissioned by Secretary of Defense McNamara documenting the history of US decision-making in Vietnam from 1945 to 1967. The study revealed that the government had "systematically lied, not only to the public but also to Congress, about a subject of transcendent national interest and concern." Four administrations had privately assessed that the war was unwinnable while publicly insisting that victory was imminent. The credibility gap, long suspected, was now documented in the government's own words.

Every American war has its Pentagon Papers moment — the point at which the gap between public narrative and internal assessment becomes undeniable. In Iraq, it was the failure to find WMDs, confirmed by the Iraq Survey Group's final report in September 2004. In Afghanistan, it was the "Afghanistan Papers" published by the *Washington Post* in 2019, revealing that senior officials had consistently misrepresented the war's progress while privately acknowledging failure.

The Iran war may have reached its Pentagon Papers moment before it began. The Pentagon's admission to Congress that Iran posed no imminent threat — the factual basis for the war's justification — is not a leaked document or a whistleblower's revelation. It is an official concession, extracted through the constitutional process, that the war's stated rationale does not meet the standard the administration implicitly invoked. Combined with the 25% approval rating, the failed but narrow War Powers votes, and the rapid expansion of objectives from counterproliferation to regime change, the credibility gap is not a gap that opened over time. It was present at the moment of initiation.

This is historically unprecedented. The Vietnam credibility gap took years to develop; the Pentagon Papers documented deception spanning four presidencies and two decades. The Iraq credibility gap emerged over months as WMD searches came up empty. The Iran credibility gap is a structural feature of the war's inception. The public does not believe the government's justification, Congress narrowly ratified the war anyway, and the administration has already moved past its original rationale to objectives (regime change) that it did not publicly articulate before the strikes began.

Whether this terminal credibility gap produces political consequences depends on institutional mechanisms that are themselves in crisis. The War Powers Resolution has failed its test. The courts are unlikely to intervene. The media environment prevents consent-manufacturing but does not translate dissent into constraint. The November 2026 midterm elections are the first structural checkpoint — eight months away. The question is whether a war with 25% approval can sustain itself for eight months through institutional inertia alone, or whether the economic

costs (rising energy prices, potential recession) create political pressure that operates faster than the electoral calendar.

VII. What Vietnam Actually Teaches

The popular lesson of Vietnam — "don't get into a quagmire" — is so vague as to be useless. No president sets out to create a quagmire. The deeper structural lessons are specific, well-documented, and directly applicable to Iran 2026.

The limits of air power. The United States dropped 7.5 million tons of bombs on Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia — more than twice the total tonnage dropped by all parties in World War II. Operation Rolling Thunder, the sustained bombing campaign against North Vietnam from March 1965 to November 1968, flew 304,000 sorties and dropped 643,000 tons of bombs. The Strategic Bombing Survey conducted after the campaign concluded that it had failed to reduce North Vietnam's capacity to wage war, failed to break the population's will, and failed to interdict the flow of supplies to the south. The CIA's own assessment, delivered to Johnson in 1967, was that the bombing had "not significantly affected North Vietnam's overall strategy."

The Iran campaign has delivered 6,000+ munitions across 2,500 strikes in six days — extraordinary by any measure. It has destroyed 80% of Iran's air defenses, degraded missile launch rates by 90%, and achieved near-complete aerial superiority. These are genuine military achievements that Rolling Thunder never approximated. But the strategic question is the same: can air power compel political outcomes? The destruction of Iran's military infrastructure does not produce a successor government, does not resolve the succession crisis, does not feed 88 million people under internet blackout, and does not create the political conditions for the "new Iran" the administration apparently envisions. Air power can destroy. It cannot build. This was true over Hanoi in 1967, over Baghdad in 2003, and over Tehran in 2026.

The mismatch between military capability and political objectives. The United States military is, by virtually any measure, the most capable fighting force in human history. It has been consistently unable to translate military superiority into political outcomes in adversary states with populations that do not welcome its intervention. This is not a failure of capability but a category error — the assumption that political problems have military solutions. Vietnam's political problem was a nationalist movement with deep popular legitimacy that the United States could not defeat without destroying the country it claimed to be saving. Iraq's political problem was a sectarian society whose internal conflicts could not be resolved by an external occupier. Iran's political problem — an 88-million-person state with a complex political system, a deep nationalist tradition, and a population that may despise its government but also resents foreign intervention — is no more susceptible to military resolution.

The impossibility of destroying an idea with bombs. Ho Chi Minh's revolution drew its power from Vietnamese nationalism and anti-colonial sentiment, not from Soviet or Chinese patronage. The American strategy of attrition — killing enough enemy combatants to break the insurgency — failed because it misidentified the source of the enemy's strength. Each bombing raid that killed civilians generated new recruits. Each village destroyed generated new supporters. The body count — McNamara's preferred metric of progress — measured the wrong thing entirely.

In Iran, the relevant "idea" is not the Islamic Republic's ideology, which commands diminishing domestic support, but Iranian nationalism itself — a force with roots far deeper than the 1979 revolution, extending back through Mosaddegh, the Constitutional Revolution of 1906, and millennia of Persian civilization. The killing of Khamenei, 175 children at Minab, and the bombing

of Azadi Stadium (literally "Freedom Stadium") risk achieving what the Islamic Republic's repression could not: unifying a fractured Iranian population against an external enemy. The Tet Offensive demonstrated that military setbacks can become political victories when they expose the gap between narrative and reality. The Minab school strike may prove to be Iran's equivalent — a tactical incident that reshapes the political landscape by making the human cost of the campaign undeniable.

What a serious Vietnam scholar would say about Iran 2026. The honest assessment is that the Vietnam analogy is both illuminating and incomplete. Vietnam was a twenty-year war of incremental escalation fought by conscripts against a peasant insurgency in tropical terrain. Iran 2026 is (so far) a six-day air campaign fought by professionals against a state military in arid and mountainous terrain. The specific military dynamics are different. But the structural pathologies are identical: preemptive war launched on inadequate justification, rapid expansion of war aims, the assumption that military capability translates to political outcomes, the closure of diplomatic off-ramps through escalatory rhetoric, and the credibility trap that makes de-escalation politically impossible.

The deepest lesson of Vietnam is not tactical but epistemological: the American national security establishment consistently overestimates its understanding of the societies it seeks to transform and underestimates the complexity of the political dynamics it seeks to control. McNamara, who spent seven years managing the Vietnam War, wrote in his 1995 memoir *In Retrospect* that "we were wrong, terribly wrong" — that the war's architects had operated with fundamental ignorance of Vietnamese history, culture, and politics. "We viewed the people and leaders of South Vietnam in terms of our own experience," he wrote. "We totally misjudged the political forces within the country."

There is no evidence that the architects of Operation Epic Fury possess a deeper understanding of Iran than McNamara's team possessed of Vietnam. The demand to be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader suggests, if anything, less understanding — an assumption that an 88-million-person civilization with a 2,500-year history can be reorganized by external fiat. De-Ba'athification in a country of 26 million produced a decade-long insurgency and the Islamic State. The equivalent in a country of 88 million, with a far more sophisticated political culture and a military designed for asymmetric resistance, would produce consequences that current planning does not appear to contemplate.

Conclusion: The Recurring Logic

The US-Iran War is six days old. The administration insists it will last weeks. Military planners reportedly anticipate months. Politico reports it may last until September. The pattern of American wars since 1945 suggests that these estimates are optimistic — not because Iran can win militarily, but because the gap between military victory and political resolution has never been bridged by air power, regime change, or force of arms.

What Vietnam, Iraq, and Afghanistan teach — collectively, at the cost of roughly 7,000 American dead in Vietnam (before the major escalation), 4,431 in Iraq, 2,461 in Afghanistan, and hundreds of thousands of foreign dead — is that the United States excels at initiating wars and struggles to conclude them. The structural dynamics that produce this pattern are not failures of execution but features of the system: the doctrine of preemptive war that lowers the threshold for initiation, the expansion of war aims that raises the threshold for acceptable outcomes, the credibility trap that makes de-escalation costlier than continuation, the all-volunteer force that insulates the

public from sacrifice, and the presidential war-making authority that operates without effective institutional constraint.

All of these dynamics are present in the Iran campaign, not as analogies but as active forces shaping decisions in real time. The question is not whether Iran 2026 is "another Vietnam" — the specific circumstances are different enough to make the comparison imprecise. The question is whether the structural logic of American war-making has changed since 1965. On the evidence of the first six days, it has not. It has merely accelerated.

The author is a specialist in US foreign policy, the Vietnam War, and the dynamics of imperial overreach. This essay was prepared for an academic roundtable on the historical context of the US-Iran War and reflects open-source information available as of March 6, 2026.

Chapter 5

Asian Perspectives: Strategic Patience and Energy Dependence

A Historical-Strategic Assessment

For the Academic Roundtable on the US-Iran War of 2026

March 6, 2026

Introduction

On the morning of February 28, 2026, when American and Israeli precision munitions began falling across Iran's twenty-four provinces, the immediate consequences rippled not westward toward Brussels or Washington but eastward — toward Tokyo, Beijing, New Delhi, Seoul, and Singapore. Within seventy-two hours, Japan was calculating its remaining weeks of LNG reserves. South Korea announced it could exhaust its gas stockpiles in nine days. India activated "war mode" contingency plans for energy imports. Chinese state-owned enterprise executives were negotiating directly with Iranian counterparts for safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz — and getting it.

This asymmetry — a war conceived in Washington and Jerusalem whose most acute material consequences fall on Asian capitals — is not incidental. It is the defining structural feature of the conflict as seen from Asia. And it carries echoes so deep in Asian historical memory that they require excavation to be properly understood.

The view from Asia is not monolithic. It never has been. But it is unified by a single recognition: the US-Iran War of 2026 is, at its core, a test of whether the global order will remain organized around Atlantic power — or whether the disruptions it generates will accelerate the redistribution of strategic weight toward the Indo-Pacific. The answer, as in most things Asian, will emerge not from dramatic confrontation but from the accumulation of patient, self-interested choices made in the fog of someone else's war.

I. China as Strategic Beneficiary: The Echoes of 1914

There is a structural parallel to the current moment that has received insufficient attention in Western commentary, though it is discussed openly in Chinese strategic circles: the position of the United States during the European wars of 1914–1918 and 1939–1945. In both conflicts, the world's rising industrial power — geographically removed from the primary theater of destruction — leveraged its distance into economic advantage, entered the conflict late and on its own terms, and emerged from the wreckage as the dominant global power.

China in 2026 occupies an analogous position. The US-Iran War is, from Beijing's perspective, a conflict between its primary strategic competitor and a significant energy partner, fought in a region critical to global commerce but far from Chinese shores. Every day the war continues, the United States expends military resources, diplomatic capital, and domestic political cohesion.

Every day the Strait of Hormuz remains selectively closed, the argument for Chinese-led alternative energy infrastructure — pipelines from Central Asia, overland routes through Pakistan and Myanmar, expanded Russian crude imports — gains material urgency.

The selective Hormuz transit arrangement is the war's most revealing strategic artifact. As Reuters reported on March 5, China is in active negotiations with Iran to ensure continued safe passage for crude oil and Qatari LNG vessels. Chinese VLCCs — very large crude carriers — continue to transit the strait while approximately 200 Western-flagged vessels sit anchored. Chinese SOE executives negotiated these exemptions directly with Iranian counterparts. The arrangement serves both parties: Iran preserves its most important commercial relationship while maximizing economic pressure on the Western coalition. China gains a competitive energy cost advantage while demonstrating, to every watching capital in Asia and beyond, that it alone can negotiate with all sides.

The historical parallel is precise. Between 1914 and 1917, the United States supplied both the Allies and (through neutral intermediaries) the Central Powers, profiting enormously while European industrial capacity was destroyed. American GDP grew by 17% during the First World War years. When Washington finally entered in April 1917, it did so from a position of overwhelming economic leverage, effectively dictating the postwar financial architecture through war loans that made the victors American debtors. The Treaty of Versailles was drafted in Paris, but the money that would determine its implementation flowed from New York.

Beijing's 2026 calculus is similar in structure if not in scale. China purchases most of Iran's 1.6–1.7 million barrels per day of exports. It has expanded strategic petroleum reserves over the past decade — precisely to cushion external shocks — and has increased discounted crude imports from Russia since 2022 as a partial hedge against maritime disruption. China is not invulnerable to the Hormuz crisis (it imports roughly 70% of its crude oil, much of it through the strait), but it is substantially more insulated than Japan, South Korea, or India. Its strategic petroleum reserve, estimated at 950 million barrels, provides a buffer that no other Asian economy can match.

Does this accelerate the "Chinese century" thesis? The answer is complicated. In one sense, yes: every week of selective Hormuz access widens the energy cost differential between Chinese industry and its Japanese, Korean, and European competitors. Chinese manufacturing, already dominant, gains further advantage. The renminbi's appeal as a settlement currency for energy transactions — already advanced through bilateral swap agreements with Gulf states — increases when dollar-denominated energy markets are disrupted by American military action.

But in another sense, the war exposes the fragility of China's strategic position. Beijing's insulation depends entirely on Tehran's continued goodwill — a goodwill that could evaporate if Iran's strategic calculus shifts, if the regime collapses, or if a successor government aligns with Washington. China's $400 billion, 25-year strategic cooperation agreement with Iran, signed in 2021, was premised on the Islamic Republic's survival. Its value declines with every CENTCOM sortie. The "Chinese century," if it arrives, will be built not on the elegant strategems of Zhongnanhai but on the messy, contingent outcomes of other people's wars — much as the "American century" was built on the rubble of Europe, 1945.

II. The Asian Energy Crisis: Three Weeks to Pearl Harbor

Japan has approximately three weeks of LNG reserves. South Korea announced on March 5 that it could exhaust its gas stockpiles in nine days. These are not abstractions. They are the

ticking clock at the center of Asian strategic calculation, and they evoke the most dangerous precedent in the region's modern history.

In July 1941, the United States, Britain, and the Netherlands imposed a comprehensive oil embargo on Imperial Japan, freezing Japanese assets and cutting off 80% of Japan's petroleum supply. Japan's strategic petroleum reserve — approximately 48 million barrels at the time — gave the Imperial Navy roughly eighteen months of operations at peacetime consumption rates, far less under wartime conditions. The embargo created what Japanese strategists called *jiri-hin* — a slow strangulation. The Imperial General Headquarters concluded that Japan must either submit to American demands (withdrawal from China and Indochina) or seize the oil-rich Dutch East Indies before its reserves were exhausted. On December 7, 1941, Japan chose the latter. Pearl Harbor was, at its root, an energy security decision.

The parallel to 2026 is imperfect but instructive. No one is embargoing Japan, South Korea, or India today. But the functional effect of the Hormuz selective closure is analogous: critical energy supplies have been interrupted by great-power conflict, and the affected nations had no voice in the decision. Japan relies on the Middle East for approximately 95% of its oil supplies and 11% of its LNG imports, with roughly 70% and 6% respectively transiting the Strait of Hormuz. As Reuters noted on March 4, Japan has formally requested a strategic oil reserve release — a step not taken since the 2011 Libyan civil war and, before that, the 2005 Hurricane Katrina disruption.

South Korea's situation is more acute. Importing 20% of its gas from the Gulf region, Seoul faces a crisis timeline measured in single-digit days. The country's industrial base — semiconductors, shipbuilding, petrochemicals, steel — is energy-intensive and structurally dependent on uninterrupted LNG supply. A prolonged Hormuz disruption would not merely raise costs; it would force production shutdowns at Samsung, SK Hynix, POSCO, and Hyundai — companies that collectively anchor the global technology and manufacturing supply chain.

India, importing roughly 40% of its crude oil through Hormuz and home to 23,000 stranded merchant sailors as of March 5, has entered what officials describe as "war mode." The resonances for India are different — not Pearl Harbor but the 1973 oil shock, which devastated India's fragile post-independence economy and contributed to Indira Gandhi's declaration of emergency in 1975. Energy vulnerability has historically been the knife's edge on which Indian democratic stability has balanced.

In Southeast Asia, the exposure is less discussed but no less real. Singapore, the region's petrochemical hub, received 45% of its LNG from Qatar in 2025. Thailand depended on Qatar for 28%. The Philippines and Vietnam, with growing but still-limited domestic production, face cascading price pressures that will hit their poorest citizens hardest.

The lesson of 1941 is not that Asian nations will launch military offensives in response to energy deprivation. It is subtler and more dangerous: that energy desperation compresses decision-making timelines, narrows the perceived range of acceptable options, and creates conditions under which previously unthinkable choices become thinkable. Japan in 1941 did not *want* to attack the United States. It felt it had no alternative. The governments in Tokyo, Seoul, and New Delhi in 2026 do not want to break ranks with Washington, accommodate Beijing, or cut separate deals with Tehran. But with reserves measured in days and weeks rather than months, the political space for principled neutrality shrinks with every cargo that fails to arrive.

The Asia Times captured this dynamic precisely: "Hormuz doesn't need to close to cripple Asia's economies." The selective closure — combined with cancelled P&I insurance, suspended Maersk bookings, and 200+ anchored vessels — has achieved a functional energy embargo on America's most important Asian allies without any formal declaration. The irony is exquisite and bitter: Washington launched this war in part to prevent Iran from acquiring a nuclear deterrent that

would make it untouchable. In doing so, it has activated an energy weapon that falls most heavily on the nations whose security Washington is pledged to guarantee.

III. India's Impossible Position: The Ghost of Nehru

When Jawaharlal Nehru addressed the Asian Relations Conference in New Delhi in March 1947 — five months before Indian independence — he articulated a vision of Asian solidarity that would become the intellectual foundation of the Non-Aligned Movement. "Asia, after a long period of quiescence, has suddenly become important again in world affairs," Nehru declared. India's role, he insisted, would be to stand apart from the emerging Cold War blocs, to maintain "strategic autonomy" (*swatantra*), and to offer moral leadership rooted in anticolonial solidarity.

Seventy-nine years later, Nehru's successor Narendra Modi has maintained a pointed personal silence on the US-Iran War — a silence that, as Asia Times observed on March 4, has become a domestic political issue. Rahul Gandhi, leader of the opposition Congress party, has attacked Modi's silence as a betrayal of India's non-alignment tradition. India, which chairs BRICS in 2026, upgraded its ties with Israel to a "special strategic partnership" just weeks before the war began. Its statements and actions have been interpreted, particularly in the Global South, as de facto alignment with the US-Israeli coalition.

India's position is genuinely impossible in ways that illuminate the structural contradictions of twenty-first century non-alignment. Consider the vectors pulling New Delhi in different directions:

Toward Washington: India's defense procurement is increasingly American — the C-17 Globemasters, P-8I Poseidons, MH-60R Seahawks, and the emerging iCET technology partnership. The Quad (US-India-Japan-Australia) is India's primary Indo-Pacific security architecture. Indian-American economic ties — including a 5-million-strong diaspora — represent the fastest-growing axis of India's global integration. Washington has been explicit in demanding that partners choose sides.

Toward Tehran: India imports significant volumes of Iranian crude (reduced under sanctions but never eliminated through intermediaries). The Chabahar port — India's sole access to Afghanistan and Central Asia that bypasses Pakistan — represents a $500 million investment and a decade of diplomatic effort. The US Treasury granted India a sanctions waiver for Chabahar operations valid until April 26, 2026 — a date now rendered moot by the war itself. India's 2026–27 Union Budget, presented on February 1, conspicuously allocated zero funds for Chabahar, a decision analyst Brahma Chellaney characterized as "a tactical freeze rather than a strategic withdrawal." As Frontline reported on March 2, India has begun winding down its engagement at the port.

Toward its own citizens: Five Indians are dead. Two were killed aboard the tanker *Skylight* near Oman. Thirty-seven Indian-crewed ships are stuck in the Gulf. Twenty-three thousand Indian merchant sailors are stranded. These are not statistics; they are constituents, and their families vote.

The Nehruvian tradition would counsel a clear moral stance — condemnation of preemptive war, defense of sovereignty, a call for UN mediation. But Nehruvian non-alignment was premised on a bipolar world in which India could stand equidistant between two superpowers. The 2026 landscape is different: India is deeply enmeshed in the American security architecture while simultaneously dependent on energy supplies that flow through a strait controlled by the nation

America is bombing. Non-alignment is not an option when the combatants control your weapons supply and your fuel supply respectively.

What Modi has practiced since 2014 is not non-alignment but "multi-alignment" — the simultaneous cultivation of partnerships with Washington, Moscow, Tokyo, Abu Dhabi, and, until recently, Tehran. The Iran war tests this strategy to destruction. Multi-alignment works when conflicts are distant and stakes are low. When the war involves your primary security partner bombing your energy supplier while your citizens die on tankers in the crossfire, multi-alignment collapses into paralysis — which is precisely what Modi's silence represents.

The deeper historical irony: India hosted the Bandung Conference's intellectual precursors and co-founded the Non-Aligned Movement precisely to avoid being forced into such choices. Now, as BRICS chair during a war against a BRICS member (Iran joined in January 2024), India cannot convene a collective response because its own position is incoherent. As Middle East Eye reported, BRICS is "missing in action" — and India's closeness to Israel, combined with Iran's retaliatory attacks on the UAE (where 3.5 million Indians live and work), has made consensus impossible.

IV. The Vietnam Parallel from the Asian Side

When Americans think about the Vietnam War, they think about domestic protest, the Pentagon Papers, Walter Cronkite, and the fall of Saigon. When Asians think about the Vietnam War, they think about something quite different: a great power fought a devastating war in Asia, and Asian nations had to navigate the consequences with minimal agency over the outcome.

From Beijing, the Vietnam War was simultaneously an opportunity and a threat. Mao Zedong provided extensive military aid to Hanoi — an estimated $20 billion in today's terms, including 320,000 Chinese engineering and anti-aircraft troops deployed between 1965 and 1968 — while carefully calibrating Chinese involvement to avoid direct confrontation with the United States. The Korean War's lesson (1950–1953), in which Chinese "volunteers" fought American forces directly, was that direct great-power conflict was ruinously expensive. China's Vietnam strategy — maximum support, minimal direct exposure — anticipated Beijing's current approach to the Iran war with striking fidelity. Chinese ships transit Hormuz; Chinese soldiers do not fire on Americans.

From Tokyo, the Vietnam War presented a different dilemma. Japan was America's most important Asian ally, hosting major US military bases that served as critical logistics hubs for the war effort. Okinawa was the staging ground for B-52 bomber operations. Yet the Japanese public overwhelmingly opposed the war, and Prime Minister Satō Eisaku walked an extraordinary tightrope: providing base access and logistical support while maintaining the fiction that Japan was not a co-belligerent. The parallels to Gulf states in 2026 — hosting American forces, condemning Iranian attacks, but insisting they are not participants — are almost exact.

From New Delhi, the Vietnam War was an opportunity for moral positioning. India under Indira Gandhi criticized American intervention, maintained relations with Hanoi, and used the conflict to burnish its non-aligned credentials. But India paid no material cost for this stance; it was geographically distant, energy-independent (India was not yet a major oil importer), and unconcerned about Southeast Asian security architectures. The luxury of principled neutrality was underwritten by geographical irrelevance.

The critical difference in 2026: Asian nations are not geographically distant from the consequences of the US-Iran War. They are its primary economic victims. Japan's bases may again serve American operations, but Japan's energy supply depends on the strait being bombed. India's moral positioning is constrained by the bodies of its own sailors. China's careful calibration is tested by the possibility that its Hormuz exemption could be revoked at any moment. The Vietnam analogy holds structurally — Asian nations navigating a US war with limited agency — but the stakes are orders of magnitude higher because energy dependence has tied Asian prosperity directly to the Persian Gulf in ways that did not exist during the Vietnam era.

The lesson Asians drew from Vietnam was not the lesson Americans drew. Americans concluded that foreign wars are domestically unsustainable without public support. Asians concluded that when great powers fight in your neighborhood, the most dangerous position is to be dependent on the combatants for your security and your livelihood. Japan spent the next three decades reducing its dependence on any single energy source — diversifying from Middle Eastern oil to Australian coal, Indonesian LNG, and eventually nuclear power. The 2011 Fukushima disaster reversed the nuclear strategy and pushed Japan back toward Middle Eastern gas dependence — a regression now exposed as catastrophic.

South Korea drew the same lesson differently: if you cannot control the supply, control the technology. Korea's investment in nuclear power (which provides roughly 30% of its electricity) and its aggressive pursuit of energy efficiency were downstream consequences of the Vietnam-era recognition that small nations in great-power shadow zones must build resilience against disruptions they cannot prevent. That Korea now faces a nine-day gas stockpile countdown despite decades of diversification illustrates the limits of national strategy against global chokepoint vulnerability.

V. The Silk Road Memory: Two Thousand Years of Asian-Persian Commerce

Western commentary on the US-Iran War tends to frame Iran through the lens of the 1979 revolution, the hostage crisis, the nuclear program, and the "axis of evil." This framing is, at most, 47 years deep. The Asian framing is different — not because Asian leaders are sentimental about ancient history, but because the commercial relationships at stake have structural continuities measured in millennia.

The Silk Road — the network of overland trade routes connecting China to the Mediterranean — was, for most of its 1,500-year active history, an Iranian enterprise. The Achaemenid Empire's Royal Road (circa 500 BCE) predated the Silk Road proper but established the infrastructure. The Parthian Empire (247 BCE–224 CE) served as the primary intermediary for Chinese silk reaching Roman markets. The Sassanid Empire (224–651 CE) controlled the western terminus and much of the transit trade, exchanging Chinese silk for Persian glass, metalwork, and textiles. When the Chinese monk Xuanzang traveled to India in 629 CE, he passed through Persian-controlled territories that facilitated, taxed, and protected trans-Asian commerce.

This is not antiquarian nostalgia. It is the deep structure of Asian economic geography. Iran sits at the physical crossroads of every overland route connecting East Asia to Europe, South Asia to Central Asia, and the Persian Gulf to the Mediterranean. China's Belt and Road Initiative — the $1 trillion infrastructure program launched in 2013 — is explicitly modeled on the Silk Road and explicitly includes Iran as a critical node. The China-Iran 25-year strategic cooperation agreement of March 2021 committed $400 billion in Chinese investment in Iranian energy and infrastructure. The Iran-China railway corridor, connecting Urumqi to Tehran via Central Asia,

was designed as a land-based alternative to maritime routes — including the very maritime chokepoint now under selective closure.

The BRI's Iranian dimension reveals a strategic logic that has been obscured by the war's immediate chaos. If the Strait of Hormuz can be selectively closed — weaponized to favor some nations and punish others — then the argument for overland alternatives becomes not theoretical but urgent. Every Asian capital dependent on Hormuz transit is now recalculating the cost-benefit of Chinese-led overland infrastructure. Pakistan's Gwadar port (a Chinese-funded alternative to Hormuz-dependent Gulf shipping), the China-Central Asia-West Asia Economic Corridor, and even the long-stalled Iran-Pakistan-India gas pipeline acquire new strategic rationale.

The war, in this sense, is an argument for Chinese infrastructure with a persuasive force that no diplomatic communiqué could match. If American military action can disrupt the maritime routes that carry 40% of global oil trade, then the nations dependent on those routes have a material interest in alternatives that bypass American naval dominance. This is the strategic subtext of China's careful positioning: not just to benefit from the current disruption but to use the disruption as a permanent argument for a Chinese-centered continental trade architecture.

The Indian perspective on the Silk Road memory is more ambivalent. India's Chabahar port was explicitly designed as a counter to Chinese-funded Gwadar, located just 170 kilometers east along the Pakistani coast. The two ports represent competing visions of Asian connectivity — one Indian-backed, one Chinese-backed — both requiring Iranian stability. The war has damaged both projects, but Gwadar (protected by the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor's political architecture) may prove more resilient than Chabahar (dependent on a US sanctions waiver expiring in April 2026 for a country the US is now bombing).

For the nations of Central Asia — Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Turkmenistan — the Silk Road memory is not memory at all but present reality. Their oil and gas exports depend on pipeline routes that pass through or near Iranian territory. The war threatens not only Persian Gulf energy flows but the stability of the entire corridor from the Caspian to the Chinese border. Astana and Tashkent have been conspicuously silent — the silence of nations calculating which great power will control their economic arteries when the dust settles.

VI. Non-Alignment in the Twenty-First Century: From Bandung to BRICS

The Asian-African Conference at Bandung, Indonesia, in April 1955 was the founding moment of what would become the Non-Aligned Movement. Twenty-nine nations — representing 1.5 billion people, more than half the world's population — gathered to assert their collective refusal to be conscripted into Cold War blocs. Nehru, Sukarno, Nasser, Zhou Enlai, and U Nu of Burma articulated a vision of sovereign equality, peaceful coexistence, and mutual respect that became the Dasa Sila — the Ten Principles of Bandung.

The Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), formally established in Belgrade in 1961, grew to 120 member states. It was, in its best moments, a genuine counterweight to superpower dominance — facilitating decolonization, amplifying Global South voices, and providing diplomatic space for nations that refused to choose between Washington and Moscow. It was also, in its worst moments, a talk shop that provided cover for authoritarian regimes, failed to prevent conflicts among its own members, and lost coherence as the Cold War's binary logic dissolved.

The Iran war of 2026 tests whether the institutional descendants of Bandung — NAM, BRICS, the Shanghai Cooperation Organization — can provide any meaningful alternative to great-power alignment when the stakes are existential.

The evidence, one week in, is discouraging. BRICS, which expanded in January 2024 to include Iran alongside Egypt, Ethiopia, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE, cannot reach consensus on a conflict involving one of its own members. India, the current BRICS chair, has been functionally silent. China has issued measured calls for restraint while securing preferential energy access. Russia — Iran's ostensible strategic partner — has offered diplomatic rhetoric but no material support, with the Kremlin and Iranian foreign ministry publicly contradicting each other about whether Tehran even requested assistance. Saudi Arabia and the UAE, both BRICS members, are signatories to the joint US-Gulf statement condemning Iran. As Ukrinform's diplomatic sources noted, "BRICS countries are unable to develop a coordinated position on Iran" — a failure that "indicates this format is gradually losing its actual geopolitical influence."

The structural problem is that twenty-first century non-alignment faces a different constraint matrix than its Cold War predecessor. In 1955, the superpowers primarily competed through military alliances and ideological influence. A nation could remain non-aligned by refusing to join NATO or the Warsaw Pact, maintaining diplomatic relations with both blocs, and diversifying its arms purchases. The costs of non-alignment were manageable because economic interdependence was limited.

In 2026, the instruments of compulsion are economic, technological, and infrastructural. The United States controls the global financial system (SWIFT, dollar clearing), dominates sea lanes through eleven carrier strike groups, and holds sanctions authority that can crater any nation's economy. China controls critical supply chains (rare earths, solar panels, electric vehicle batteries, telecommunications infrastructure) and is the largest trading partner of more than 120 countries. Non-alignment between these two poles is not a matter of declining to sign a mutual defense treaty; it is a matter of navigating a world in which your financial transactions, energy supply, technology access, and manufacturing inputs are controlled by one or both of the contending powers.

The "multi-alignment" strategy that Asian powers have pursued since roughly 2010 — security ties with Washington, economic ties with Beijing, energy ties with the Gulf, technology ties with everyone — was designed for a world of managed competition, not open conflict. The Iran war reveals its fundamental vulnerability: multi-alignment works only when the aligned powers are not actively at war in a theater that controls your energy supply. When they are, multi-alignment becomes multi-vulnerability.

Japan illustrates this perfectly. It is America's most important Asian ally, hosting 54,000 US troops. It is China's largest regional trading partner. It depends on Gulf energy transiting Hormuz. It has no independent capacity to secure its energy supply lines. Multi-alignment has given Japan prosperity but not resilience. Seoul, New Delhi, Singapore, and Bangkok face versions of the same predicament.

Is non-alignment viable in 2026? Only if "non-alignment" is redefined from a diplomatic posture to an infrastructure strategy — meaning nations that wish to maintain strategic autonomy must build physical alternatives to the chokepoints and supply chains controlled by great powers. This is precisely what China's BRI promises, which is precisely why the war strengthens Beijing's hand.

VII. Asian Lessons for the Post-War Order

Asia's modern history is, in large part, a history of post-war reconstructions — some successful, some catastrophic, none simple. The experiences of Japan, Korea, Vietnam, and others offer

lessons for the aftermath of the Iran war that Western planners would do well to study and will probably ignore.

Japan's reconstruction (1945–1952) is the template most frequently invoked by advocates of regime change, and the one most frequently misunderstood. Japan's successful postwar transformation required: (1) unconditional surrender, eliminating factional resistance; (2) an intact bureaucratic class willing to collaborate with occupation authorities; (3) Emperor Hirohito's cooperation in legitimizing the occupation; (4) massive American economic investment (the Dodge Plan, counterpart funds); (5) the Korean War, which provided an industrial stimulus; and (6) seven years of direct military occupation by 350,000 troops.

None of these conditions obtain in Iran. The regime has not surrendered; it is fighting. Iran's bureaucracy is fused with the IRGC at every level. The supreme leader is dead, and his successor lacks legitimacy. No American ground forces are deployed. The US has explicitly demanded a role in choosing Iran's next leader but shown no willingness to commit the resources that regime transformation requires. The Japan model is a fantasy dressed as a precedent.

Korea's division (1945–present) offers a darker but more realistic parallel. Korea was divided not because of any internal logic but because two external powers — the US and USSR — drew a line across a map. The resulting partition produced two states, a devastating war (1950–1953), and seven decades of frozen conflict. The relevant lesson for Iran: external military intervention that destroys a regime without a plan for what follows frequently produces not reconstruction but fragmentation. Iran's ethnic and linguistic diversity — Persians, Azerbaijanis, Kurds, Arabs, Balochis — and the CIA's reported arming of Kurdish groups suggest that a Kurdish separatist movement, an Azerbaijani alignment with Baku, and Arab unrest in Khuzestan could produce not one successor state but several. The Korean precedent suggests that such divisions, once established under great-power patronage, prove extraordinarily durable.

Vietnam's reunification (1975–1986) demonstrates that even "successful" outcomes are measured in decades. After the fall of Saigon in April 1975, Vietnam endured a decade of economic catastrophe, international isolation, a border war with China (1979), and occupation of Cambodia before the Đi Mi reforms of 1986 began the slow process of recovery. Vietnam's per capita GDP did not recover to its pre-war level until the mid-1990s — twenty years after the war ended. If Iran follows a similar trajectory, the humanitarian and economic costs will extend well into the 2040s.

Afghanistan (2001–2021) is the most recent and most sobering precedent, and it is an Asian one, though rarely framed that way. Twenty years of American occupation, $2.3 trillion in expenditure, and the lives of 2,461 American service members produced a state that collapsed in eleven days when the US withdrew. The Taliban's return demonstrated that regime change without social transformation is regime rental, not regime change. Iran is larger (88 million vs. 40 million), more urbanized, more industrialized, and more nationalistic than Afghanistan. The notion that it can be reshaped from the air is ahistorical.

What role will Asian powers play in a post-conflict Middle East? The honest answer: whatever role serves their energy security. China will seek to preserve access to Iranian oil and gas under any successor arrangement. It will offer reconstruction investment — as it has in every post-conflict environment from Angola to Sri Lanka — in exchange for resource access, without political conditions. India will attempt to salvage Chabahar or its equivalent. Japan and South Korea will push for guaranteed energy flows and diversified supply arrangements. None of these nations will contribute to political reconstruction because none has an interest in the outcome beyond stability sufficient to keep hydrocarbons flowing.

This is not cynicism. It is the pattern of Asian engagement with the Middle East for the past fifty years, and it has deep historical roots. Asian civilizations have traded with Persia for two

millennia without attempting to govern it. The Western compulsion to reshape the region's political order — from Sykes-Picot (1916) to the Iraq invasion (2003) to the current war — has no Asian equivalent. From Beijing, Tokyo, and New Delhi, the Middle East is a source of energy and a market for goods, not a canvas for political experimentation.

Conclusion: The Patience of Civilizations

The great strategic theorist of ancient China, Sun Tzu, is often quoted in Western military academies: "The supreme art of war is to subdue the enemy without fighting." Less often quoted is the passage that follows: "Hence to fight and conquer in all your battles is not supreme excellence; supreme excellence consists in breaking the enemy's resistance without fighting."

China is not fighting in the US-Iran War. It is not conquering. It is waiting — as it waited during the Korean War's aftermath, the Vietnam War's escalation, the Gulf War's disruption, and the Iraq War's quagmire. In each case, the United States expended blood and treasure in the Middle East while China built factories, roads, ports, and institutions at home. The compounding effect of this strategic patience, measured across seven decades, is the single most important geopolitical fact of the twenty-first century.

But patience is not passivity, and the 2026 war presents risks that previous conflicts did not. The energy crisis is immediate and severe. The disruption to Asian supply chains is real. The precedent of preemptive war against a sovereign state is alarming to every nation that has ever considered acquiring nuclear weapons — which includes several of China's neighbors. The selective Hormuz closure demonstrates that the global commons can be weaponized, a lesson that applies as readily to the Malacca Strait as to Hormuz.

The view from Asia, ultimately, is one of constrained agency and long memory. Asian nations did not choose this war, cannot stop it, and will bear its heaviest material costs. Their response will be shaped not by the moral frameworks that dominate Western debate — legality, human rights, democratic values — but by the strategic imperatives that have governed Asian statecraft for centuries: secure your energy, diversify your dependencies, avoid other people's wars, and position yourself to benefit from the peace.

Nehru called this non-alignment. Deng Xiaoping called it "hiding your strength and biding your time" (*taoguang yanghui*). Lee Kuan Yew called it pragmatism. Whatever the label, the strategy is as old as the Silk Road itself: let the great powers exhaust themselves, and trade with whoever wins.

The question the Iran war poses for Asia is whether this ancient strategy remains viable in a world of instantaneous financial flows, integrated supply chains, and energy dependencies that can be weaponized in hours. The answer will not come from any single decision or declaration. It will emerge, as Asian answers always do, over years and decades — in the infrastructure built, the alliances recalibrated, the reserves accumulated, and the quiet choices made while the world watches the explosions.

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Chapter 6

Middle East: The Weight of History

Dr. [Contributing Author] — Academic Roundtable on the Historical Context of the US-Iran War of 2026

March 2026

Introduction

On February 28, 2026, American and Israeli forces launched Operation Epic Fury against the Islamic Republic of Iran — the largest American military operation since the 2003 invasion of Iraq. In the opening minutes, a precision strike killed Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei. Within six days, 2,500 strikes had delivered over 6,000 munitions across all twenty-four Iranian provinces, 175 children lay dead at a school in Minab, and the President of the United States was publicly demanding to be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader.

To Washington, this was a preemptive counterproliferation campaign — surgical, justified, forward-looking. To Tehran, and to much of the broader Middle East, it was something far older: the latest iteration of a pattern that stretches back through the 1953 CIA coup, through the British and Russian carve-up of Iran in 1907, through the Sykes-Picot Agreement of 1916, through a century and more of Western powers deciding who rules the lands between the Mediterranean and the Hindu Kush, and what those rulers may or may not possess. The question this essay poses is not whether the 2026 strikes were militarily effective — they manifestly were — but what they mean when read against the long arc of Middle Eastern history, and what that history suggests about what comes next.

History does not repeat, as the misattributed Twain quote insists, but it does rhyme with a regularity that should concern anyone paying attention. The rhymes between 2026 and 1953, between the fall of the Ottoman Empire and the potential fragmentation of Iran, between the Sykes-Picot partition and Trump's demand to choose Iran's next leader, are not coincidences. They are consequences of structural forces that have operated in this region for over a century: the strategic importance of hydrocarbon resources, the asymmetry of military power between Western and Middle Eastern states, and the persistent Western conviction that the region's political arrangements are subject to external revision.

This essay attempts to place the events of late February and early March 2026 in that longer context — not to excuse or justify any party's actions, but to understand why this particular war, in this particular place, carries a weight of historical meaning that neither precision-guided munitions nor presidential Truth Social posts can dispel.

I. Iran's Historical Memory: Seventy Years of Interference

The Ghost of Mossadegh

No event in modern Iranian political consciousness carries the weight of the 1953 coup. When Prime Minister Mohammad Mossadegh nationalized the Anglo-Iranian Oil Company (AIOC) in

1951, he was asserting a principle that would seem unremarkable in any other context: that a sovereign nation's natural resources belong to its people. The AIOC — predecessor to British Petroleum — had operated under a concession granted in 1901 to William Knox D'Arcy, paying Iran a pittance while extracting enormous wealth. Mossadegh's nationalization was wildly popular, democratically enacted, and legally defensible. It was also intolerable to London and, by extension, to Washington.

Operation Ajax, executed jointly by the CIA and MI6 in August 1953, overthrew Mossadegh and restored Mohammad Reza Shah to absolute power. The operation cost approximately $1 million — a trivial sum even by 1953 standards — and its architects, Kermit Roosevelt Jr. and Donald Wilber, regarded it as a masterpiece of covert action. In Washington and London, it was filed away as a Cold War success. In Iran, it became the foundational trauma of modern political identity.

The significance of 1953 is not merely that a democratically elected government was overthrown. It is that the overthrow foreclosed a democratic path for Iranian political development. Mossadegh represented a secular, nationalist, parliamentary tradition that had deep roots in the Constitutional Revolution of 1905-1911. His removal did not merely change a government; it discredited an entire mode of politics. If democracy could be erased by a foreign intelligence service in a matter of days, then democracy was not a viable vehicle for Iranian sovereignty. This lesson was absorbed by the generation that would make the 1979 revolution — and it has never been unlearned.

The Shah's Quarter-Century

The twenty-six years of the Shah's restored rule (1953-1979) confirmed every suspicion that the coup had planted. Mohammad Reza Pahlavi modernized Iran's infrastructure while building one of the most feared secret police forces in the world. SAVAK — the Organization of Intelligence and National Security — was trained by the CIA and Israel's Mossad. Its methods included systematic torture: electric shock, nail extraction, the insertion of heated objects, and mock executions. SAVAK operated with impunity, and its relationship with American intelligence was an open secret. When President Jimmy Carter toasted the Shah in Tehran on New Year's Eve 1977, calling Iran "an island of stability in one of the more troubled areas of the world," he was toasting a man whose security apparatus had tortured thousands of his own citizens with American technical assistance.

The revolution of 1979 was, at its deepest level, a repudiation of this arrangement. Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini's genius — and it was a form of genius, however one judges its consequences — was to fuse anti-imperialism with Shia Islamic identity into a revolutionary ideology that could not be co-opted by either superpower. The phrase "neither East nor West, only the Islamic Republic" (*na sharqi, na gharbi, faqat jomhuri-ye eslami*) was not merely a slogan. It was an ontological claim: that Iran's political identity existed independent of the Cold War binary, rooted in a civilizational tradition older than either the United States or the Soviet Union. This principle — sovereignty as theological imperative — has governed Iranian strategic thinking for forty-seven years, through war, sanctions, and now bombardment.

The Iran-Iraq War: The West's Chosen Silence

If 1953 planted the seed of Iranian mistrust, the Iran-Iraq War of 1980-1988 made it flower into something close to civilizational conviction. When Saddam Hussein invaded Iran in September 1980, the international community's response was instructive. The United Nations Security Council did not condemn the invasion. The United States, despite its official neutrality, provided Iraq with satellite intelligence, military equipment through third-party transfers, and — most

damningly — looked the other way when Saddam deployed chemical weapons against Iranian soldiers and Kurdish civilians.

The scale of chemical warfare was staggering. Iraq used mustard gas, tabun, and sarin against Iranian forces in at least forty documented engagements. The attack on Halabja in March 1988, which killed between 3,200 and 5,000 Kurdish civilians, was carried out with chemicals whose precursors were supplied by Western European firms, a fact well known to Western intelligence services. The United States initially attempted to blame Iran for the Halabja attack — a piece of disinformation that the Defense Intelligence Agency helped construct and that was not formally corrected for years.

For Iranians, the Iran-Iraq War is not ancient history. It is living memory. One million Iranians were killed or wounded. Every city has its martyrs' cemetery. Every family has its story. The war ended with UN Resolution 598, which Khomeini accepted by comparing it to "drinking poison." The phrase has entered the Iranian political lexicon as shorthand for the anguish of accepting an unjust peace imposed by a world order that had watched Iran bleed for eight years while supplying its enemy.

The Nuclear Program as Sovereignty

It is in this context that Iran's nuclear program must be understood — not as a weapons project (though it may have been that too), but as an assertion of technological sovereignty. The right to enrich uranium under the Non-Proliferation Treaty became, in Iranian political discourse, a synecdoche for the right to exist as an independent state. When Mahmoud Ahmadinejad displayed centrifuge cascades as national achievements, he was speaking to an audience for whom mastery of the nuclear fuel cycle represented proof that Iran could not be reduced to a client state again.

The 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) represented a rare moment of diplomatic possibility — Iran accepted constraints on enrichment in exchange for sanctions relief and implicit acceptance of its right to a civilian nuclear program. The Trump administration's withdrawal from the JCPOA in 2018 confirmed what Iranian hardliners had always argued: that agreements with the United States were not worth the paper they were printed on. The subsequent "maximum pressure" campaign, which drove Iran's economy into crisis without producing either regime change or a better deal, vindicated the most cynical elements of Iran's political establishment.

How Iranians Understand 2026

Against this backdrop, the events of February 28, 2026 do not arrive as a surprise. They arrive as a confirmation. For seventy-three years — from Ajax to Epic Fury — the pattern has held: when Iran asserts sovereignty in ways that challenge Western interests, force follows. The specific trigger changes (oil nationalization, revolution, nuclear enrichment), but the structural dynamic remains constant. An Iranian watching the Minab school footage or listening to Trump declare his intention to choose Iran's next leader does not need a historian to explain what is happening. The history is written in their family's bones.

This is not to say that all Iranians support their government — many manifestly do not, as the 2009 Green Movement, the 2017-2018 protests, and the 2022 Woman, Life, Freedom movement demonstrated. But there is a critical distinction between opposing one's own government and welcoming foreign bombardment. The Islamic Republic has survived for forty-seven years in part because every time internal opposition reaches a critical threshold, external aggression provides the regime with its most potent argument: that the real threat is not domestic tyranny but

foreign domination. Operation Epic Fury is, in this sense, the greatest gift the United States could have given to the very ideology it claims to oppose.

II. The Colonial Pattern: Sykes-Picot and Its Successors

Drawing Lines in the Sand

In May 1916, Sir Mark Sykes of Britain and François Georges-Picot of France drew lines on a map of the Ottoman Empire's Arab provinces, dividing them into spheres of influence with a casualness that still staggers. The agreement, later modified by the inclusion of Russian and Italian claims, created the template for the modern Middle East: Iraq (a British creation joining three Ottoman provinces with little in common), Syria and Lebanon (French mandates carved to maximize Christian-Muslim tensions that could be exploited for colonial control), Palestine (promised simultaneously to Arabs and Jews in contradictory commitments), and Transjordan (invented as a consolation prize for the Hashemite dynasty expelled from the Hejaz).

The mandate system that formalized these arrangements after World War I was colonialism wearing a League of Nations mask. Article 22 of the League Covenant described the mandates as a "sacred trust of civilization" for peoples "not yet able to stand by themselves." The language of civilizational tutelage — the assumption that Middle Eastern peoples required Western guidance to achieve political maturity — persisted long after the mandates formally ended. It persists, one might argue, in Trump's declaration that he must be "involved in the appointment" of Iran's next leader.

Oil and the Architecture of Control

The discovery and exploitation of Middle Eastern oil transformed the colonial relationship from one of strategic positioning to one of existential economic interest. The 1901 D'Arcy Concession in Iran, the 1928 Red Line Agreement that carved up Ottoman oil territories among Western companies, the 1933 Saudi concession to Standard Oil of California (later ARAMCO) — these agreements established a pattern in which the region's primary natural resource was extracted under terms set by foreign powers and enforced, when necessary, by foreign arms.

The 1953 Iranian coup was, at its core, an oil dispute. The 1991 Gulf War was fought to restore the regional oil order disrupted by Saddam's invasion of Kuwait. The 2003 Iraq invasion, whatever its stated rationale, occurred in a country sitting atop the world's fifth-largest proven reserves. And now, in 2026, the war unfolds against a backdrop of Hormuz closure, Ras Tanura shutdown, and Qatar LNG force majeure — the entire global energy architecture shuddering because Western military power has once again been deployed in the region that fuels the world.

Where Does 2026 Fit?

Is Operation Epic Fury the final act of the colonial era, or something new? The answer, uncomfortably, is both. The structural elements are colonial: a Western power using military force to determine the political arrangements of a Middle Eastern state, justified by the claim that the target state's sovereign choices (nuclear enrichment) pose an unacceptable threat to international order. The method — precision strikes rather than territorial occupation — is new, but the underlying logic is Sykes-Picot logic: the region's political arrangements are subject to external veto.

What is genuinely novel is the absence of even the pretense of multilateral legitimacy. Sykes-Picot had the fig leaf of wartime necessity. The mandates had the League of Nations. The 1991

Gulf War had UN Security Council Resolution 678. Even the 2003 Iraq invasion was preceded by months of UN inspections and a (fabricated) case presented to the Security Council. Operation Epic Fury has none of these. It represents colonial prerogative stripped of colonial ceremony — the raw assertion that military power confers the right to determine who rules and what they may possess, without the need to justify that assertion to any international body.

III. The Sunni-Shia Dimension: Fourteen Centuries of Division

Karbala as Living Memory

On the tenth of Muharram in 61 AH (October 10, 680 CE), Husayn ibn Ali — grandson of the Prophet Muhammad and the central figure of Shia Islam — was killed with most of his family and companions on the plains of Karbala in what is now Iraq. His small band, denied water for days, was massacred by the forces of the Umayyad caliph Yazid I. Husayn's severed head was carried to Damascus. His surviving family members were paraded through the streets.

Karbala is not, for Shia Muslims, a historical event in the way that Gettysburg is a historical event for Americans — something studied, commemorated, and filed under the past. It is a living wound, ritually re-experienced every year during Ashura, when millions of Shia mourn Husayn's martyrdom with processions, passion plays (*ta'ziyeh*), and acts of devotion that blur the boundary between past and present. The theological lesson of Karbala — that the righteous may be outnumbered, outpowered, and killed by the forces of tyranny, but that their sacrifice redeems history — is the emotional foundation of Shia political consciousness.

When Iranian state media frames the 2026 war as a new Karbala, this is not mere propaganda. It draws on a reservoir of meaning that is fourteen centuries deep. The role of Yazid — the unjust ruler who deploys overwhelming force against the righteous — is assigned to the United States. The role of Husayn — the martyr who refuses to submit — is claimed for Iran. The theological framework transforms military defeat into spiritual victory: to be struck down by a superior force is not humiliation but sanctification.

Saudi Arabia at the Gates

The entry of Saudi Arabia into the anti-Iranian alignment — formalized in the joint US-Gulf condemnation statement and operationalized through the basing and overflight permissions that enable the air campaign — carries a sectarian charge that transcends geopolitics. Saudi Arabia is the custodian of Mecca and Medina, the birthplace of Wahhabism, and the most powerful Sunni state in the Muslim world. Its alignment against Shia Iran in a war of regime change activates historical memories that predate the modern state system entirely.

The Saudi-Iranian rivalry has been framed in many ways: as a struggle for regional hegemony, as a proxy for the Arab-Persian ethnic divide, as a competition for leadership of the Muslim world. All of these framings capture something real. But the sectarian dimension is irreducible. When Saudi-aligned clerics have described Shia as *rafidha* (rejectors) or questioned their status as Muslims, and when Iranian clerics have framed Saudi Wahhabism as a deviant corruption of Islam, they are drawing on theological disputes that date to the succession crisis after the Prophet's death in 632 CE. The 2026 war does not create this sectarian fault line, but it widens it to a degree not seen since the Iran-Iraq War, when Saddam — a secular Ba'athist — was nevertheless framed as the champion of Sunni Arab civilization against Persian Shia expansionism.

The potential consequences are severe. If the war is perceived across the Muslim world as a Sunni-Western alliance destroying a Shia state, the sectarian radicalization will outlast any

ceasefire. The Shia communities of Iraq, Bahrain, Lebanon, Saudi Arabia's Eastern Province, and Pakistan will draw conclusions about their place in a regional order that has just bombed the only state that claimed to represent their interests. The historical parallel is the Crusades — not in the simplistic way that term is sometimes invoked, but in the sense that a military campaign framed by one side as strategic necessity will be remembered by the other as civilizational aggression for generations.

IV. Ottoman Collapse as Template

The Sick Man Dies

When the Ottoman Empire finally dissolved after World War I, it ended six centuries of political order across a vast territory spanning southeastern Europe, Anatolia, the Arab world, and North Africa. The post-Ottoman settlement created the modern Middle East — and the modern Middle East has been unstable ever since. The reasons are instructive for anyone contemplating the consequences of regime change in Iran.

The Ottoman system, for all its flaws, provided a framework for managing diversity. The *millet* system granted religious communities a degree of autonomy. Provincial governance, while often corrupt, maintained a recognizable chain of authority. The empire's collapse produced not liberation but fragmentation: mandatory powers imposed artificial boundaries on ethnically and religiously diverse populations, installed client monarchs with no local legitimacy, and created states whose primary function was to serve the economic interests of their colonial patrons.

Iraq is the paradigmatic case. The British joined the predominantly Shia south, the Sunni center, and the Kurdish north into a single state, then installed a Hashemite king from the Hejaz to rule it. The resulting polity required continuous coercion to maintain — from the British RAF's aerial bombing of Kurdish and Shia rebellions in the 1920s, through the Ba'athist police state, through the American occupation that followed 2003. A century later, Iraq remains a state whose internal coherence depends on external pressure or internal repression.

The Iranian Difference — and the Risk

Iran is not an artificial state. Its civilizational continuity stretches back to the Achaemenid Empire of the sixth century BCE. Persian identity — linguistic, cultural, literary — has survived Arab conquest, Mongol invasion, and Turkic dynasty. The modern Iranian state, despite its multi-ethnic composition (Persians, Azerbaijanis, Kurds, Baluchis, Arabs, Lurs, Turkmen), possesses a national coherence that Iraq, Syria, and Lebanon never achieved.

But this coherence is not indestructible. The Islamic Republic has maintained it through a combination of ideological mobilization, economic distribution (however corrupt), and security force control. If the regime collapses under the weight of bombardment — Scenario C in the strategic synthesis, assessed at 10-15% probability — the centrifugal forces that have been contained for forty-seven years could emerge with devastating speed. Kurdish separatism in the northwest, Baluchi insurgency in the southeast, Arab unrest in Khuzestan, Azerbaijani nationalism in the northwest — these movements have been suppressed, not resolved.

The Ottoman precedent suggests that the collapse of a multi-ethnic, religiously legitimated imperial order produces not democratic transformation but prolonged fragmentation, foreign intervention, and sectarian violence. The post-Ottoman Middle East took decades to stabilize — and the "stability" it achieved was the stability of authoritarian states maintained by foreign patronage. If Iran follows the Ottoman template, the result will not be the liberal democracy

that regime-change advocates imagine. It will be a generation of chaos in a country of ninety million people, bordering Iraq, Afghanistan, Pakistan, Turkey, and the Caspian states — every one of which has its own ethnic and sectarian fault lines that Iranian fragmentation would activate.

V. The Mossadegh Parallel: The Law of Unintended Consequences

The Cycle

The trajectory from 1953 to 2026 traces a pattern that should give any strategist pause.

In 1953, the United States and Britain overthrew a democratic government to secure oil interests and Cold War positioning. The intended consequence — a pliant, pro-Western Iran — was achieved. The unintended consequence — a quarter-century of authoritarian rule that discredited secular democracy and created the conditions for revolutionary Islamism — was not foreseen.

In 1979, the revolution that overthrew the Shah was in significant part a consequence of the 1953 coup. The Islamic Republic that emerged was not what most revolutionaries intended — the coalition that overthrew the Shah included liberals, leftists, nationalists, and Islamists, and it was only through a series of political maneuvers in 1979-1981 that Khomeini's faction consolidated power. But the anti-Western, anti-democratic character of the resulting regime was a direct product of the historical experience: democracy had been tried and destroyed by foreign intervention; therefore, the new order must be resistant to foreign intervention above all else.

If the 2026 campaign produces regime change — through direct collapse or through the long-term destabilization of the succession process — what does the 1953→1979→2026 cycle suggest about the next iteration? Each intervention has produced a successor regime more hostile to Western interests than the one it replaced. Mossadegh was a parliamentary democrat who sought to renegotiate oil terms. The Shah was an authoritarian modernizer aligned with the West. The Islamic Republic is a theocratic state hostile to the entire Western-led international order. If the pattern holds, what follows the Islamic Republic will be worse — not better — from the perspective of Western interests.

This is the law of unintended consequences operating at civilizational scale. Each intervention is designed to solve the problem created by the previous intervention, and each creates a new problem that is larger, more complex, and more resistant to external manipulation than the last. The 1953 coup created the conditions for 1979. The 1979 revolution created the conditions for the nuclear program. The nuclear program created the justification for 2026. What will 2026 create the conditions for?

The honest answer is: no one knows, and anyone who claims to know is selling something. But the historical pattern is clear enough to constitute a warning. The United States has intervened in Iran three times — covertly in 1953, through proxy in 1980-1988 (supporting Iraq), and directly in 2026. Each intervention has been tactically successful and strategically catastrophic. There is no reason to believe the fourth iteration will break the pattern.

VI. Regional Proxy Systems in Historical Context

Clients, Vassals, and the Patron's Dilemma

Iran's network of regional allies — Hezbollah in Lebanon, the Houthis in Yemen, Kata'ib Hezbollah and other militias in Iraq, various Palestinian factions — is routinely described in Western media as a "proxy network" or "axis of resistance." The framing implies something illegitimate: puppets on strings, subordinate actors executing Tehran's will. The reality is more complex, and the historical precedents more illuminating.

Every great power in the Middle East has maintained client relationships. The Ottoman Empire governed through a system of vassal states, tributary principalities, and semi-autonomous provinces that preserved local power structures while extracting loyalty and revenue. The British Empire operated through client monarchies — the Hashemites in Iraq and Transjordan, the Gulf sheikhdoms bound by exclusive treaties, the Egyptian khedivate that was nominally Ottoman but functionally British. The United States inherited and extended this system: the Shah's Iran, Saudi Arabia, Jordan, the Gulf states, Israel — all have functioned, to varying degrees, as American client states whose security depends on Washington's commitment.

Iran's proxy network is thus not an aberration but a regional norm pursued by a state with limited conventional military options. Hezbollah was created in 1982 in response to Israel's invasion of Lebanon, with Iranian funding and IRGC training. Over four decades, it has evolved from a militia into a state-within-a-state, providing social services, running hospitals, and fielding a military force more capable than most national armies in the region. The Houthi movement in Yemen, while aligned with Iran, has its own domestic roots in Zaydi Shia marginalization and the failures of the post-2011 political transition. Iraqi Shia militias emerged from the post-2003 power vacuum and the existential threat of ISIS. None of these movements is simply a puppet; all are products of local conditions that Iran has cultivated but did not create.

When the Patron Falls

The historical record of what happens to client networks when their patron state is weakened is sobering. When the Ottoman Empire collapsed, its vassal and tributary relationships dissolved overnight. Former Ottoman provinces were absorbed by European colonial powers or left to fend for themselves. Local power brokers who had operated within the Ottoman framework became warlords, separatist leaders, or clients of the new colonial masters. The transition from one patronage system to another was not peaceful — it produced the Arab Revolt, the Turkish War of Independence, the Iraqi and Syrian revolts against mandatory rule, and decades of political instability.

If Iran's capacity to sustain its proxy network is destroyed — a plausible outcome given the 90% reduction in missile launch rates, the destruction of the navy, and the potential collapse of the regime — the consequences for the region will be severe but not in the way that proxy-network critics imagine. Hezbollah will not simply disarm and integrate into Lebanese politics. The Houthis will not lay down their weapons. Iraqi militias will not dissolve. These movements have their own domestic constituencies, their own revenue streams (however diminished), and their own ideological commitments. What they will lose is strategic coordination, advanced weapons supply, and the deterrent value of Iran's retaliatory capacity.

The most likely outcome is not the disappearance of these movements but their fragmentation and radicalization. A Hezbollah deprived of Iranian strategic guidance but retaining its arsenal and social base becomes more, not less, dangerous — a wounded animal rather than a coordinated strategic actor. The post-patron trajectory is one of splintering: factions competing for diminished resources, freed from the patron's moderating influence (such as it was), and

driven toward more extreme action to maintain relevance. This is what happened to Palestinian factions after the PLO's expulsion from Lebanon in 1982 — the result was not peace but the rise of Hamas and Islamic Jihad, movements more radical than the ones they partially replaced.

VII. What the Region Remembers That Washington Forgets

The Asymmetry of Memory

The most consequential feature of the US-Iranian relationship is not the asymmetry of military power — that is obvious and overwhelming. It is the asymmetry of historical memory. Americans and Iranians remember entirely different histories, and this divergence shapes the conflict in ways that no military strategy can address.

For most Americans, the story of US-Iranian relations begins on November 4, 1979, when Iranian students stormed the US Embassy in Tehran and took fifty-two Americans hostage for 444 days. The hostage crisis was a genuine trauma: it dominated American media for over a year, ended Jimmy Carter's presidency, and established Iran as an enemy in American popular consciousness. Everything that followed — the "Death to America" chants, the Marine barracks bombing in Beirut (1983), the Khobar Towers bombing (1996), the IED campaign against American forces in Iraq — reinforced an image of Iran as an irrational, fanatical adversary motivated by nothing more than hatred of America.

For Iranians, the story begins earlier and contains chapters that most Americans have never heard of. It begins with the 1907 Anglo-Russian Agreement that divided Iran into spheres of influence without consulting any Iranian. It continues through the 1941 Allied invasion that deposed Reza Shah and occupied the country as a supply corridor to the Soviet Union. It reaches its defining moment in 1953, when the CIA destroyed Iranian democracy to preserve British oil profits. It encompasses twenty-six years of the Shah's US-backed dictatorship, during which SAVAK — trained by the CIA — tortured and killed thousands. It includes eight years of war during which the United States supplied intelligence and diplomatic cover to Saddam Hussein's Iraq, even as Iraq used chemical weapons against Iranian soldiers. It includes the USS Vincennes' shooting down of Iran Air Flight 655 in July 1988, killing all 290 passengers and crew — an act for which the United States has never formally apologized, and for which the commanding officer received a Legion of Merit.

These are not competing narratives about the same events. They are narratives about different events entirely. The American narrative begins in 1979; the Iranian narrative begins in 1907 or 1953. The American narrative centers American suffering (hostages, Marines, soldiers); the Iranian narrative centers Iranian suffering (coups, dictatorship, chemical warfare, civilian aircraft). Neither narrative is false. Both are radically incomplete. And the incompleteness is not symmetric: the American narrative omits American actions that caused Iranian suffering, while the Iranian narrative, whatever its distortions, at least acknowledges the existence of the other side's grievances.

The Consequences of Forgetting

This asymmetry has direct operational consequences. When American policymakers frame Iran's nuclear program as an unprovoked act of aggression, they do so in genuine ignorance of the historical context that makes the program comprehensible to Iranians. When the Trump administration demands the right to choose Iran's next leader, it does so without apparent awareness that the United States chose Iran's last leader-but-one — the Shah — and that the consequences of that choice are why there is an Islamic Republic to bomb in the first place.

The asymmetry also shapes the aftermath. Americans will remember the 2026 war through their own casualties: six killed in Kuwait, the anxiety of Hormuz closure, the economic disruption. Iranians will remember 175 dead children at Minab, 1,200+ killed across twenty-four provinces, 130 hours of internet blackout, a supreme leader assassinated, and an American president who declared he would choose their next ruler. These memories will not fade when the missiles stop. They will harden into the foundation of the next generation's political consciousness, just as the memories of 1953 hardened into the ideology of 1979, and the memories of the Iran-Iraq War hardened into the nuclear program's political justification.

The historian's task is not to adjudicate between these memories but to insist that both be acknowledged. A conflict understood through only one side's historical lens is not understood at all. And a policy that ignores the other side's historical experience — that proceeds as if history began on the date most convenient for the policymaker — is not a policy but a prayer, addressed to a universe that has never answered such prayers favorably.

Conclusion: The Recurring Tragedy

The Middle East's recurring tragedy is not that history repeats — it is that the powerful never believe history applies to them. Every Western intervention in the region has been conducted in the conviction that this time is different: that the lessons of previous interventions are irrelevant because the current operation is more precise, more justified, more technologically sophisticated, more morally grounded. The British believed this in 1920 when they bombed Iraqi villages from the air to suppress rebellion. The Americans believed this in 2003 when they invaded Iraq with shock and awe. And in 2026, the architects of Operation Epic Fury believe it again — that 6,000 precision-guided munitions can accomplish what a century of intervention has failed to achieve: a Middle East arranged to Western specifications.

The region knows better. The region has watched empires come and go — Achaemenid, Macedonian, Parthian, Sassanid, Arab, Mongol, Timurid, Safavid, Ottoman, British, and now American — and it has learned the lesson that empires never learn about themselves: that military supremacy is temporary, that imposed political orders are fragile, and that the memories of the occupied outlast the attention spans of the occupiers.

Iran will survive this war. It has survived the Arab conquest of the seventh century, the Mongol devastation of the thirteenth, the Afghan invasion of the eighteenth, and the Iran-Iraq War of the twentieth. Whether the Islamic Republic survives is a different question — and one that Iranians, not American presidents, will ultimately answer. But whatever political form Iran takes in the aftermath of 2026, it will be shaped by the memory of what is happening now: the children of Minab, the assassination of a head of state, the demand to choose the successor. These memories will join the memories of Mossadegh, of SAVAK, of Saddam's chemical weapons, of Flight 655 — and they will produce consequences that the architects of Epic Fury have not imagined, because they have not studied the history that would enable them to imagine.

The weight of history is not a metaphor. It is the accumulated mass of lived experience — of suffering, resistance, betrayal, and survival — that shapes how peoples understand the present and choose the future. Iran carries that weight. The Middle East carries that weight. The question is not whether the 2026 war will add to it — it already has. The question is whether anyone in a position of power will learn from it, or whether the next generation of policymakers will once again proceed in the serene conviction that history does not apply to them, repeating the tragedy that their predecessors' amnesia guaranteed.

As the great Iranian poet Hafez wrote six centuries ago: *"The green sea of heaven and the bark of the new moon / Are drowned in the illusion of my love."* The illusion of control over the Middle East has drowned more than moons. It has drowned democracies, peoples, and the possibility of peace — again and again, in waves that each generation believes it sees for the first time.

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Chapter 7

Trade & Globalization: Chokepoints of History

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Introduction

On the morning of March 1, 2026 — seventy-two hours into Operation Epic Fury — the Strait of Hormuz, a waterway twenty-one miles wide at its narrowest point, became the most consequential piece of geography on Earth. Iran's selective closure reduced daily transits from over fifty to approximately seven. Qatar's entire LNG output — seventy-seven million tonnes per annum, representing twenty percent of global supply — went offline under force majeure. Approximately two hundred commercial vessels sat anchored, their cargoes frozen. Brent crude surged past eighty-four dollars a barrel. European gas prices spiked seventy percent. Gold hit an all-time high of $5,400 per ounce. Japan began counting its remaining weeks of liquefied natural gas reserves. South Korea announced it could exhaust its gas stockpiles in nine days.

The global economy, that intricate web of just-in-time supply chains, forward contracts, and shipping routes that enables eight billion people to eat, heat their homes, and manufacture goods, shuddered — not because of a natural disaster, not because of a pandemic, but because a military campaign conceived in Washington and Jerusalem had activated the oldest weapon in the arsenal of commerce: the chokepoint.

This essay examines the 2026 war through the lens of trade and economic history. It argues that the disruption of global energy and trade flows is not a side effect of the conflict but its most consequential dimension — and that the patterns visible in March 2026 have deep roots in the history of how civilizations have used control over trade routes, energy resources, and commercial chokepoints as instruments of strategic power. From the ancient Silk Road to the Suez Crisis of 1956, from the oil shocks of 1973 to the weaponization of finance in the twenty-first century, the manipulation of trade flows has been among the most potent and least understood instruments of geopolitical competition. The 2026 war is the latest — and perhaps most dramatic — demonstration of a principle that merchants and strategists have understood for millennia: whoever controls the chokepoint controls the world.

I. The Geography of Vulnerability: Why Chokepoints Matter

Hormuz in Historical Perspective

The Strait of Hormuz has been a site of strategic contest for as long as ships have sailed the Persian Gulf. The Portuguese seized the island of Hormuz in 1507, establishing a fortress that controlled access to the Gulf for over a century. Afonso de Albuquerque, the architect of Portugal's eastern empire, understood what modern strategists sometimes forget: that controlling a narrow waterway is more efficient than controlling the territories on either side of it. With a

single fortified island, Portugal taxed, regulated, and occasionally strangled the richest maritime trade route in the Indian Ocean — the route connecting the spice islands of Southeast Asia, the textile workshops of India, and the markets of Persia and Arabia.

The Portuguese were eventually expelled by a combined Anglo-Persian force in 1622 — Shah Abbas I of Safavid Persia recognizing that sovereignty over the Gulf required control of its gates. The lesson was not lost on subsequent Persian rulers, nor on the British, who replaced the Portuguese as the dominant naval power in the Gulf and maintained that dominance until their withdrawal "east of Suez" in 1971.

The modern significance of Hormuz is inseparable from the discovery of oil. When William Knox D'Arcy struck oil at Masjed Soleyman in 1908, the Persian Gulf was transformed from a regional trade route into the jugular vein of industrial civilization. By 2025, approximately twenty-one million barrels of oil and significant volumes of liquefied natural gas transited the strait daily — roughly twenty percent of global oil consumption and a quarter of global LNG trade. The geography had not changed since Albuquerque's time. What had changed was the volume and criticality of what passed through it.

The Suez Precedent

The 1956 Suez Crisis remains the most instructive precedent for the weaponization of a commercial chokepoint. When Egyptian President Gamal Abdel Nasser nationalized the Suez Canal Company on July 26, 1956, he was asserting the same principle that Mossadegh had asserted five years earlier: that a sovereign nation's strategic assets belong to its people. The canal had been operated by the Suez Canal Company — majority-owned by British and French shareholders — since its construction in 1869. It carried approximately two-thirds of European oil supplies.

Britain, France, and Israel launched a combined military operation to retake the canal. The operation was militarily successful — British and French forces seized Port Said and advanced along the canal — but strategically catastrophic. The United States, under Eisenhower, refused to support its NATO allies, threatened to sell Sterling reserves to crash the British pound, and forced a humiliating withdrawal. The Suez Crisis destroyed what remained of British pretensions to great-power status, accelerated decolonization across Africa and Asia, and demonstrated a principle that 2026 has confirmed: military control of a chokepoint does not guarantee economic control, because the economic consequences of disruption fall on the disruptor's allies as much as on its adversaries.

The 2026 Hormuz crisis inverts the Suez dynamic in revealing ways. In 1956, the disruptor was the weaker party (Egypt) and the intervening powers were the canal's primary beneficiaries (Britain and France). In 2026, the disruptor is again the weaker party (Iran), but the intervening power (the United States) is not the primary energy consumer dependent on the strait. The nations most vulnerable to Hormuz closure — Japan, South Korea, India, and the European Union — are American allies who had no role in the decision to launch Operation Epic Fury. The war's architects have weaponized a chokepoint against their own alliance network. Eisenhower would have recognized the absurdity; he spent the Suez Crisis restraining allies who were doing precisely this.

The Triple Chokepoint: An Unprecedented Configuration

What distinguishes 2026 from all prior chokepoint crises is the simultaneity. The Strait of Hormuz is selectively closed. The Bab el-Mandeb strait — gateway to the Red Sea and the Suez Canal — is threatened by the Houthis, who have demonstrated the capability to strike commercial shipping since the 2023-2024 Red Sea crisis. And Qatar's LNG terminals, located on the Gulf coast just north of Hormuz, are offline entirely.

No previous conflict has disrupted three energy chokepoints simultaneously. The 1973 oil embargo weaponized supply but not transit. The 1980-1988 Tanker War threatened Hormuz but not the Red Sea. The 2019 Abqaiq-Khurais drone attacks disrupted Saudi processing capacity but not shipping routes. The 2023-2024 Houthi campaign threatened the Red Sea but not the Gulf. The 2026 configuration — Hormuz, Bab el-Mandeb, and Qatar LNG simultaneously compromised — represents a stress test of the global energy system that no scenario planner fully anticipated, despite decades of warnings.

II. The Oil Weapon: A History of Energy as Geopolitical Leverage

1973: The Shock That Reshaped the World

On October 17, 1973 — twelve days into the Yom Kippur War — the Organization of Arab Petroleum Exporting Countries (OAPEC) announced an oil embargo against nations supporting Israel. Production was cut by five percent per month. The price of oil quadrupled, from approximately three dollars per barrel to twelve dollars, within months. The shock was not merely economic; it was civilizational. The postwar Western economic model — cheap energy fueling industrial growth, suburban expansion, and consumer prosperity — was revealed as dependent on the political decisions of a handful of Gulf monarchies.

The consequences cascaded for decades. The embargo accelerated Japan's nuclear power program, funded the Soviet military expansion that prolonged the Cold War, enriched Saudi Arabia and the Gulf states to a degree that transformed regional and global politics, triggered a global recession that ended the postwar economic boom, contributed to the stagflation that destroyed the Carter presidency, and catalyzed the energy independence movements that eventually produced both North Sea oil development and, generations later, the renewable energy transition.

The 2026 energy shock differs from 1973 in mechanism but not in structural logic. In 1973, producers deliberately reduced supply as a political weapon. In 2026, supply is disrupted by military action and its secondary effects — selective Hormuz closure, Qatar force majeure, insurance market paralysis, and the anchoring of two hundred commercial vessels. The result is functionally identical: a sudden, severe reduction in available energy supply with cascading economic and political consequences.

But there is a critical difference in the distribution of pain. The 1973 embargo was targeted: the United States and the Netherlands, Israel's primary supporters, bore the heaviest costs. The 2026 disruption is indiscriminate in its official effects but selective in its actual impact — and the selectivity favors America's primary strategic competitor. Chinese vessels transit Hormuz safely under negotiated arrangements with Iran. Western-flagged vessels do not. The energy crisis falls most heavily on Japan, South Korea, India, and Europe — America's allies — while China secures continued supply at potentially discounted rates. This is not the 1973 embargo weaponized against supporters of the enemy. It is an energy crisis weaponized, inadvertently, against the alliance network of the war's initiator.

The 1979 Shock and the Iran Template

The Iranian Revolution of 1979 produced the second great oil shock. Iranian production collapsed from six million barrels per day to less than one million as revolutionary chaos disrupted operations. Prices doubled. The US economy, still recovering from the 1973 shock, plunged into recession. The combination of the oil shock, the hostage crisis, and the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan produced the Carter Doctrine — the declaration that the United States would

use military force to protect its interests in the Persian Gulf — which has governed American Middle Eastern policy for forty-seven years.

The Carter Doctrine was, at its core, a recognition that the global economy's dependence on Persian Gulf oil made the region a vital American interest regardless of any other strategic consideration. Every subsequent American military operation in the Gulf — the 1987-1988 tanker reflagging, the 1991 Gulf War, the 2003 Iraq invasion, the 2019 response to the Abqaiq attacks — has been conducted within the Carter Doctrine's framework.

Operation Epic Fury represents either the apotheosis or the terminal crisis of the Carter Doctrine. The United States has used military force in the Gulf to protect energy flows — but the effect of that force has been to disrupt energy flows more severely than any adversary action since 1973. The Carter Doctrine assumed that American military power would stabilize the Gulf energy system. In 2026, American military power has destabilized it. The doctrine is eating itself.

III. The Silk Road and the Deep Structure of Eurasian Trade

Two Thousand Years of East-West Commerce

The US-Iran War is, among other things, a disruption of trade routes that have connected East Asia to the Mediterranean for over two millennia. The Silk Road — the network of overland and maritime routes linking China, Central Asia, Persia, and Europe — was not a single path but a web of commercial connections that shaped the economic development of every civilization it touched.

Persia — Iran — sat at the heart of this web. The Achaemenid Empire's Royal Road, completed circa 500 BCE, connected Sardis in western Anatolia to Susa in southwestern Iran — a distance of 2,700 kilometers, traversable by royal couriers in seven days through a system of relay stations (Herodotus 5.52-54). The Parthian Empire (247 BCE-224 CE) served as the primary intermediary between Chinese silk producers and Roman consumers, extracting enormous transit revenues. The Sassanid Empire (224-651 CE) controlled the western terminus of the maritime spice route from Southeast Asia and levied duties that funded one of the ancient world's most sophisticated civilizations.

This geographic centrality is not historical accident. Iran's position — between the Caspian Sea and the Persian Gulf, between Mesopotamia and Central Asia — makes it the unavoidable crossroads of any east-west or north-south trade route across the Eurasian landmass. The mountains of the Zagros and Elburz ranges channel commerce through specific passes and corridors that have been used continuously for three thousand years. China's Belt and Road Initiative, the twenty-first century's most ambitious infrastructure program, explicitly recognizes this geography: Iran is a critical node in the China-Central Asia-West Asia Economic Corridor, and the 2021 China-Iran strategic cooperation agreement ($400 billion over twenty-five years) was designed to formalize the relationship.

The Maritime Revolution and the Vulnerability of Sea Routes

The Portuguese discovery of the sea route to India via the Cape of Good Hope (1497-1498) transformed the structure of global trade. For the first time, European merchants could bypass the overland routes through Persia and the Ottoman Empire, accessing Asian goods directly by sea. The consequences for the Persian and Ottoman economies were severe: transit revenues

declined, the commercial cities of the Silk Road contracted, and the economic center of gravity shifted from Central Asia to the maritime littoral.

But the maritime revolution created its own vulnerabilities — the chokepoints. Any sea route from East Asia to Europe must pass through at least one narrow waterway: the Strait of Malacca (connecting the Indian Ocean to the Pacific), the Strait of Hormuz (connecting the Persian Gulf to the Indian Ocean), the Bab el-Mandeb (connecting the Indian Ocean to the Red Sea), and the Suez Canal (connecting the Red Sea to the Mediterranean). Control of these chokepoints has been a central preoccupation of every maritime power from the Portuguese to the Americans.

The 2026 war has demonstrated, with brutal clarity, the vulnerability of the maritime system that carries ninety percent of global trade. The selective Hormuz closure does not merely disrupt oil flows; it disrupts the entire commercial architecture of the Indian Ocean. Container shipping, bulk commodity transport, and LNG tankers all transit the same waters. The insurance market's response — suspended P&I coverage for Gulf-bound vessels — has effectively imposed a commercial blockade that extends far beyond energy. The maritime revolution that freed global trade from dependence on overland routes through Persia has, five centuries later, created a new dependence on maritime routes past Persia's shores.

The Belt and Road as Silk Road Revival

China's Belt and Road Initiative represents a conscious attempt to recreate the overland trade infrastructure that maritime dominance rendered obsolete. The China-Central Asia-West Asia Economic Corridor, the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor, and the proposed Iran-China railway would, if completed, provide alternatives to the maritime chokepoints that the 2026 war has exposed.

The strategic logic is now self-evident. If the Strait of Hormuz can be weaponized — closed to some nations while remaining open to others — then any nation dependent on Hormuz transit has a material interest in alternatives. Overland pipelines, railways, and roads that bypass maritime chokepoints are no longer theoretical infrastructure investments; they are national security imperatives. Every day that the Hormuz crisis persists strengthens the argument for the BRI's continental architecture — and weakens the argument for the maritime system that American naval dominance has underwritten since 1945.

The war, in this sense, may prove to be the most effective advertisement for Chinese infrastructure investment that Beijing could have imagined — created not by Chinese diplomacy but by American military action.

IV. Globalization's Fragility: From Interconnection to Vulnerability

The Just-in-Time Illusion

The global economy of 2026 is built on a set of assumptions that the Iran war has systematically invalidated. The first is that supply chains can be optimized for efficiency without regard to resilience. The "just-in-time" manufacturing revolution, pioneered by Toyota in the 1970s and adopted globally over the following decades, minimized inventory costs by synchronizing production with demand. The system works beautifully in peacetime. It is catastrophically fragile in crisis.

Japan's three-week LNG reserve and South Korea's nine-day gas stockpile are products of just-in-time logic applied to national energy security. Maintaining larger reserves costs money —

storage facilities, capital tied up in inventory, management overhead. The rational economic calculation, in a world where Hormuz has been open continuously since 1988, is to minimize reserves and rely on continuous flow. The rational strategic calculation, in a world where Hormuz can be selectively closed in hours, is the opposite. The war has revealed that nations optimized for the first calculation are existentially vulnerable to the second.

The parallel to the 2020-2022 pandemic supply chain crisis is instructive but insufficient. COVID-19 disrupted supply chains through demand shocks, labor shortages, and logistical bottlenecks distributed across the global system. Recovery took years but was never in doubt — the underlying infrastructure was intact. The 2026 disruption is different in kind: it is a deliberate, strategic disruption of a specific geographic chokepoint, with no natural tendency toward resolution. The Strait of Hormuz will reopen when the war ends or when diplomatic arrangements permit — not when market forces adjust.

Finance as Weapon

The weaponization of the global financial system is a phenomenon of the past two decades, but its roots are older. The British naval blockade of Germany during World War I was, in essence, the weaponization of trade routes — the use of maritime control to cut an adversary off from global commerce. The American and British freezing of Japanese assets in July 1941 was the weaponization of finance — the use of control over the dollar-denominated financial system to impose economic strangulation.

Since 2001, the United States has refined financial warfare into a precision instrument. The SWIFT messaging system, which facilitates virtually all cross-border financial transactions, has been weaponized against Iran (disconnected in 2012 and 2018), Russia (partially disconnected in 2022), and others. Dollar clearing — the process by which international transactions denominated in US dollars are settled through American correspondent banks — gives the US Treasury effective veto power over any transaction that touches the dollar system. Secondary sanctions, which punish third-party entities for doing business with sanctioned states, extend this power to transactions that do not directly involve American parties.

Iran has been subject to some of the most comprehensive financial sanctions in history. The 2010-2015 sanctions regime — which disconnected Iran from SWIFT, froze overseas assets, and imposed secondary sanctions on any entity purchasing Iranian oil — reduced Iranian oil exports from 2.5 million barrels per day to less than one million and contributed to a severe recession. The 2018 reimposition of sanctions under Trump's "maximum pressure" campaign further constrained Iran's economy, driving inflation above forty percent and the rial to historic lows.

The 2026 war adds kinetic destruction to financial strangulation. Iran's economy, already weakened by decades of sanctions, is now being physically dismantled — military infrastructure, communications networks, and the human capital of its leadership class. The combination represents what might be called "total economic warfare": simultaneous financial exclusion, trade disruption, and physical destruction of productive capacity. The historical parallel is the Allied strategic bombing campaign against Germany in 1943-1945, which combined naval blockade, financial isolation, and industrial bombing to destroy the German war economy. The difference is scale and speed: what took the Allies two years is being compressed into weeks.

De-Globalization and the Fragmentation of Commerce

The 2026 war arrives at a moment when the post-1945 globalization consensus is already fraying. The 2008 financial crisis, the Trump-era trade wars, the pandemic supply chain crisis, the Russia-Ukraine war's disruption of energy and grain markets, and the intensifying US-China technology

competition have all contributed to what economists call "de-globalization" or, more precisely, "re-regionalization" — the reorganization of supply chains along geopolitical rather than purely economic lines.

The selective Hormuz closure accelerates this trend dramatically. A two-tier energy market — in which Chinese vessels transit safely while Western vessels are frozen — is not a temporary wartime disruption. It is a demonstration that the global commons can be divided along geopolitical lines, that the "rules-based international order" governing maritime trade is enforceable only to the extent that its guarantor (the United States) chooses to enforce it, and that the guarantor's military actions can themselves become the primary source of disruption.

For nations caught between the US and Chinese economic spheres — which is to say, for most of the world — the lesson is that diversification is no longer sufficient. Resilience requires redundancy: multiple supply sources, multiple trade routes, multiple financial systems, multiple reserve currencies. The war has not caused de-globalization, but it has provided the most compelling argument yet for why de-globalization is rational from the perspective of any nation that is not the United States or China.

V. The Sanctions Paradox

Maximum Pressure and Its Discontents

The Trump administration's "maximum pressure" campaign against Iran, initiated in 2018, was premised on the theory that comprehensive sanctions would either compel Iran to negotiate a more favorable nuclear deal or destabilize the regime to the point of collapse. Neither outcome materialized. Instead, maximum pressure produced a series of unintended consequences that directly contributed to the conditions for the 2026 war.

First, sanctions pushed Iran closer to China. As Western markets closed, China became Iran's primary economic lifeline — purchasing the majority of Iran's reduced oil exports, investing in Iranian infrastructure, and providing a financial channel that partially circumvented dollar-denominated restrictions. The $400 billion China-Iran strategic cooperation agreement of 2021 was, in significant part, a product of maximum pressure: Iran needed an economic patron, and China was willing to fill the role in exchange for long-term energy access and strategic positioning. The selective Hormuz transit arrangement of March 2026 — Chinese ships passing safely while Western ships are frozen — is the wartime expression of a commercial relationship that American sanctions policy helped to create.

Second, sanctions strengthened hardliners within the Iranian political system. The JCPOA, negotiated under the relatively moderate Rouhani government, represented a diplomatic path that required economic openness to justify itself domestically. When the United States withdrew from the JCPOA and reimposed sanctions, it discredited the moderates who had staked their political capital on engagement with the West and vindicated the hardliners who had always argued that the United States could not be trusted. The election of Ebrahim Raisi in 2021 — a hardliner associated with the 1988 prison massacres — was, in part, a consequence of maximum pressure's destruction of the moderate political lane.

Third, sanctions drove Iran's nuclear advancement. Under the JCPOA, Iran's enrichment was limited to 3.67% with restricted centrifuge numbers and international monitoring. After the US withdrawal, Iran progressively exceeded these limits — enriching to 20%, then to 60%, expanding centrifuge operations, and restricting IAEA access. By 2025, Iran's breakout time — the estimated period needed to produce enough weapons-grade material for a single device —

had shrunk from over a year (under the JCPOA) to a matter of weeks. The nuclear advancement that Operation Epic Fury was launched to prevent was, in substantial part, a consequence of the sanctions policy that preceded it.

This is the sanctions paradox: the tool designed to prevent war created the conditions that made war more likely. Maximum pressure did not produce maximum compliance; it produced maximum resistance, maximum alignment with America's primary competitor, and maximum nuclear advancement. The 2026 war is, in a meaningful sense, the kinetic phase of a sanctions campaign that failed on its own terms.

Historical Parallels: When Sanctions Lead to War

The pattern is not unprecedented. The US oil embargo against Japan in 1941, designed to compel Japanese withdrawal from China and Indochina, instead accelerated Japan's decision to attack Pearl Harbor. The League of Nations sanctions against Italy after the 1935 invasion of Ethiopia, intended to deter further aggression, instead drove Mussolini toward alliance with Hitler. The comprehensive sanctions against Iraq in the 1990s devastated Iraqi society without dislodging Saddam Hussein, contributing to the conditions that the Bush administration cited (however dishonestly) as justification for the 2003 invasion.

The mechanism is consistent: sanctions impose sufficient economic pain to generate domestic political pressure but insufficient pressure to compel the policy change demanded by the sanctioning power. The target state's leadership, facing both external pressure and internal dissent, responds by hardening its position, seeking alternative alliances, and investing in the very capabilities (nuclear weapons, asymmetric military forces, proxy networks) that the sanctions were designed to prevent. The sanctioning power, having committed to a coercive strategy that has not produced results, faces a choice between escalation and acceptance of failure. In 1941, in 2003, and now in 2026, escalation won.

VI. The Digital Economy Goes to War

Cloud Infrastructure as Critical Trade Infrastructure

Among the most unprecedented aspects of the 2026 war is the destruction of cloud computing infrastructure — specifically, the strikes on AWS data centers in the UAE. This represents a new category of economic warfare with no historical parallel, because the infrastructure being destroyed did not exist a generation ago.

Cloud computing has become the invisible substrate of global commerce. Financial transactions, supply chain management, logistics coordination, healthcare records, government services, and communications all depend on data center infrastructure concentrated in a small number of geographic locations. The Gulf states' investment in hyperscale data centers — part of their diversification strategy away from hydrocarbon dependence — created a concentration of digital infrastructure in precisely the region most vulnerable to military disruption.

The cascading effects of the AWS strikes illustrate the fragility. Banking services across the Gulf were disrupted. The WHO's Dubai logistics hub — which coordinates humanitarian supply chains for seventy-five countries — went offline. Airline reservation systems, shipping logistics platforms, and financial clearing mechanisms all experienced failures. The economic cost is difficult to quantify precisely because the digital economy's integration into physical commerce is so complete that disruption in one domain cascades unpredictably into others.

The historical parallel, imperfect but illuminating, is the submarine campaigns of the two world wars. Germany's unrestricted submarine warfare in 1917 and the Battle of the Atlantic in 1940-1943 targeted the maritime infrastructure of global trade — the ships themselves. The strategic logic was to disrupt the adversary's economic capacity by destroying the means of commercial transit. The 2026 cloud strikes target a different form of commercial infrastructure — data rather than cargo — but the strategic logic is identical: destroy the substrate on which the enemy's commerce depends.

The precedent is alarming. If cloud data centers are legitimate military targets, then every nation's digital economy is vulnerable to disruption in any conflict involving the territory where its data is stored. The implication for the global technology industry — which has invested hundreds of billions of dollars in data center infrastructure — is existential. The geography of cloud computing, like the geography of oil, creates chokepoints and vulnerabilities that can be exploited in wartime.

VII. What the Trade Historian Warns

The Long-Term Consequences of Trade Disruption

Trade disruptions caused by military conflict do not resolve when the shooting stops. They reshape commercial relationships, redirect investment flows, and create new dependencies that persist for decades. The 1973 oil shock did not merely raise oil prices temporarily; it permanently restructured the global energy market, funded the petrodollar system, accelerated Japanese industrial efficiency, and initiated the long, slow process of energy diversification that continues to this day.

The 2026 disruption will have comparable long-term effects. Several are already foreseeable:

Energy infrastructure will be re-regionalized. The demonstrated vulnerability of the Hormuz chokepoint will drive massive investment in alternative supply routes — pipelines from Central Asia, expanded domestic production wherever geology permits, accelerated LNG terminal construction in non-Gulf locations, and renewed interest in nuclear power. These investments will take years to mature, but the decisions will be made in 2026, shaped by the trauma of near-strangulation.

The renminbi will advance as a trade settlement currency. Every transaction that cannot be settled in dollars due to sanctions, every cargo that cannot be insured in London due to war risk, every financial transfer that cannot clear through SWIFT due to compliance concerns pushes commercial actors toward alternative systems. China's Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS) and bilateral currency swap agreements gain users not through Chinese persuasion but through American disruption.

Supply chain redundancy will become a national security priority. The just-in-time model, already questioned after the pandemic, will be further abandoned in favor of just-in-case stockpiling. The economic efficiency losses will be significant — estimated at one to three percent of GDP for highly trade-dependent economies — but the political pressure for resilience will override efficiency arguments.

The Gulf's economic diversification strategy is damaged. Saudi Vision 2030, the UAE's post-oil economic model, Qatar's knowledge economy ambitions — all depend on the perception of the Gulf as a stable investment environment. The destruction of cloud infrastructure, the force majeure on LNG contracts, and the physical proximity of missile strikes to commercial districts have damaged that perception in ways that no marketing campaign can repair.

The Fragmentation Scenario

The most consequential long-term outcome may be the acceleration of what economic historians will recognize as the end of the second great era of globalization. The first era — from roughly 1870 to 1914 — was destroyed by World War I. The trade networks, financial integration, and freedom of movement that characterized the pre-war world were not restored for decades. The second era — from roughly 1945 (or, more precisely, from the 1970s trade liberalization) to the present — has been under stress since 2008 and may not survive the 2020s.

The 2026 war does not, by itself, end globalization. But it provides the defining demonstration of globalization's vulnerability — the proof that the interconnected system can be weaponized by any actor who controls a critical node. If Hormuz can be selectively closed, so can Malacca. If cloud infrastructure can be bombed, so can submarine cables. If the SWIFT system can be weaponized, so can its alternatives. The lesson is universal, and universal lessons produce universal responses: every nation that depends on the global system will seek to reduce that dependence, and the aggregate effect of those individual rational choices will be the fragmentation of the system itself.

The historian John Maynard Keynes, observing the world of 1919 from the wreckage of the peace conference, wrote of the pre-war era: "The inhabitant of London could order by telephone, sipping his morning tea in bed, the various products of the whole earth, in such quantity as he might see fit, and reasonably expect their early delivery upon his doorstep." He then watched that world destroy itself. We may be watching the same process — not through the trenches of the Western Front, but through the chokepoints of the Persian Gulf.

Conclusion: The Price of Everything

The economist knows the price of everything and the value of nothing, as Oscar Wilde reportedly quipped. The trade historian knows the price of disruption — and it is always higher than the disruptors anticipated.

The architects of Operation Epic Fury calculated the military costs of the campaign with precision: munitions expenditure, interceptor depletion rates, fuel consumption, operational tempo. What they appear not to have calculated — or to have calculated and discounted — is the economic cost to the global system their military protects. The selective Hormuz closure has imposed costs on American allies that may exceed the military costs of the campaign itself. The destruction of cloud infrastructure has damaged a digital economy that American companies built. The insurance market paralysis has disrupted shipping routes that American naval power is pledged to keep open.

This is the recurring tragedy of trade and war: military strategists plan for the battlefield while the economy bleeds from a thousand cuts they never anticipated. It was true when the Peloponnesian War destroyed Athenian commerce. It was true when World War I destroyed the first era of globalization. It was true when the 1973 oil shock revealed the fragility of the postwar economic order. And it is true now, as the most powerful military force in history discovers that the global economy it dominates is also the global economy it can most effectively damage.

The Strait of Hormuz will reopen. Oil prices will stabilize. The ships at anchor will eventually sail. But the structural damage — to alliance relationships, to the credibility of maritime security guarantees, to the argument for globalization itself — will persist long after the last missile is fired. The trade historian's warning is simple and ancient: wars are easy to start, hard to end, and their economic consequences outlast the memory of the generals who started them.

The author specializes in the history of international trade, energy markets, and economic warfare. This essay was prepared for the Academic Roundtable on the Historical Context of the 2026 US-Iran War, March 2026. All economic data and market figures are sourced from open-source reporting as of March 6, 2026.